

MOVEMENTAL · ONBOARDED LEADER RESEARCH

Digital Reality Profile: Dave Ferguson

Movement leader research dossier — profile, content catalog, digital presence, fragmentation story, and onboarding materials.

Generated June 09, 2026 · 35 sections · Slug: dave-ferguson

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Research Index

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/README.md

Dave Ferguson — research sidebar manifest

Canonical paths aligned with Author Profile `/profile` navigation.

Sidebar slug	File	Status
author-profile	profile/identity.md	populated
author-profile	network/organizations.md	populated
biography	profile/biography.md	populated
theological-profile	profile/theology.md	populated
vocational-profile	summary.md	populated
vocational-profile	profile/calling-profile.md	empty
voice-editorial-identity	profile/voice-analysis.md	populated
bibliography	content/books.md	populated
frameworks	content/frameworks.md	populated
articles-blog-posts	content/articles.md	populated
audio-podcast	content/audio.md	populated
video-content	content/videos.md	populated
content-audit	content/content-audit.md	populated
academic-work	content/academic.md	populated
courses-training	content/courses.md	populated
audience-profile	analysis/audience-analysis.md	populated
where-you-publish	digital-presence/websites.md	populated
where-you-publish	digital-presence/platforms.md	populated
where-you-publish	digital-presence/newsletters.md	populated
social-media	digital-presence/social-media.md	populated
the-fragmentation-story	fragmentation-story.md	populated
a-letter	reflected-understanding/dave-ferguson.md	populated
(onboarding)	welcome-letter.md	populated

Staff-only research lives in `_staff/` ; collateral in `_misc/` .

At a Glance — Summary

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/summary.md

Digital Reality Profile: Dave Ferguson

Research Date: January 4, 2026

Confidence Level: High

Executive Summary

Dave Ferguson is a prominent Christian movement leader, author, and pastor with a significant digital presence spanning personal and institutional platforms. As the founding pastor of Community Christian Church (Chicago), visionary leader of NewThing Network, and President/CEO of Exponential Conference, Ferguson has established himself as a key voice in church planting and leadership multiplication.

His digital presence includes a personal website (daveferguson.org) with an active blog, 9+ published books spanning 2007-2025, active social media presence (Instagram), and extensive institutional content through Community Christian Church, NewThing Network, and Exponential Conference.

Ferguson's content consistently focuses on leadership multiplication, church planting, missional living, and spiritual journey themes. His work demonstrates strong alignment with Movemental's target audience of Christian movement thought leaders, authors, preachers, and practitioners.

Primary Opportunities: Content repurposing (sermons and talks into articles), content interconnection across platforms, content series development around key themes, and network amplification through Movemental's platform.

Current Digital Presence

Personal Brand

daveferguson.org: Personal website with clean, professional design

- Active blog section
- Book promotion and information
- About, Contact pages
- Social media integration (Facebook, Twitter/X, Instagram)

Social Media:

- Instagram: @fergusondave (active)
- Facebook: Link present on website
- Twitter/X: Link present on website

Published Works

9+ Books Published (2007-2025):

1. "The Big Idea" (2007)
2. "Exponential: How You and Your Friends Can Start a Missional Church Movement" (2010)
3. "On The Verge" (2011)
4. "Discover Your Mission Now" (2012)
5. "Keeping Score" (2013)
6. "Finding Your Way Back to God" (2015) - Co-authored with Jon Ferguson
7. "Starting Over"
8. "Hero Maker: Five Essential Practices for Leaders to Multiply Leaders"
9. "B.L.E.S.S.: 5 Everyday Ways to Love Your Neighbor and Change the World"

Institutional Platforms

Community Christian Church (communitychristian.org):

- Multi-site missional community
- Recognized as one of America's most influential churches
- Likely contains extensive sermon/teaching library
- Multi-site structure with multiple locations

NewThing Network (newthing.org):

- International church-planting movement
- Movement resources and training materials
- Network support and equipping content

Exponential Conference (exponential.org):

- World's largest church planting conference
- Conference talks and presentations
- Resource distribution
- Annual conference structure

Content Landscape

Content Forms

- **Books:** 9+ published works (2007-2025)
- **Blog Posts:** Active blog on personal website
- **Sermons/Teaching:** Through Community Christian Church (volume to be assessed)
- **Conference Talks:** Through Exponential Conference (volume to be assessed)
- **Social Media:** Active Instagram presence
- **Movement Resources:** Through NewThing Network

Content Themes

Primary Themes:

1. **Leadership Multiplication:** Developing and multiplying leaders
2. **Church Planting:** Strategies for reproducing churches
3. **Missional Living:** Practical neighbor engagement and community transformation
4. **Spiritual Journey:** Helping people reconnect with faith
5. **Church Strategy:** Growth strategies and mission-focused approaches

Theological Focus: Missional theology, church multiplication, leadership development, community transformation, practical application

Movement Focus: Church planting, leadership multiplication, missional movement, reproduction

Content Organization

Personal Website: Simple, clear structure with Book, Blog, About, Contact sections

Institutional Content: Distributed across Community Christian Church, NewThing Network, and Exponential Conference websites

Content Strategy: Book-driven with blog for ongoing engagement, supported by institutional platforms

Discoverability Assessment

SEO Indicators

- Clean URL structure on personal website
- Clear page titles
- Social media integration
- Book promotion with likely good internal linking

Content Indexing

- Personal website likely well-indexed
- Book titles and author pages searchable
- Conference speaker pages provide visibility
- Institutional websites provide authority

Social Sharing

- Social media links present on website
- Active Instagram presence

- Facebook and Twitter links present
- Book promotion likely includes social sharing

Domain Authority

- Personal domain (daveferguson.org) - owned
- Strong institutional backing
- Multiple published books
- Conference and movement leadership roles
- Established presence (2007+)

Gap Analysis

Embodied Work vs. Digital Expression

Well Represented Digitally:

- Books (all 9+ available digitally)
- Personal brand (website, blog, social media)
- Institutional presence (church, movement, conference websites)

Partially Represented:

- Sermons/teaching (likely available but volume/accessibility to be assessed)
- Conference talks (likely available but discoverability to be assessed)
- Blog content (active but volume/themes to be assessed)

Potential Gaps:

- Content repurposing: Are sermons transcribed and published as articles?
- Content interconnection: Are content pieces clearly connected?
- Content series: Are themes developed into content series?
- Content discoverability: Is content easily searchable and organized?

Primary Gaps Identified

1. **Content Repurposing:** Opportunities to repurpose sermons, talks, and teaching into articles and other forms
2. **Content Interconnection:** Opportunities to connect content pieces and create content journeys
3. **Content Series Development:** Opportunities to develop themes into content series
4. **Discoverability:** Opportunities to improve content organization and searchability
5. **Platform Fragmentation:** Content scattered across multiple platforms without unified hub

Opportunities for Digital Amplification

1. **Repurpose existing content** into multiple forms (sermons → articles, talks → content)
2. **Connect content pieces** to create content journeys
3. **Develop content series** around key themes (leadership, planting, missional living)
4. **Improve discoverability** through organization and optimization
5. **Create unified content hub** to organize content across platforms

Movemental Opportunities

What Movemental Would Change

Content Organization:

- Unified content hub for all content
- Better content organization and discoverability
- Content indexes and resource pages
- Clear content journeys

Content Interconnection:

- Connected content pieces across platforms
- Content journeys that guide readers
- Linked related content
- Building on previous content

Content Repurposing:

- Easier repurposing of sermons into articles
- Development of talks into content
- Expansion of book concepts
- Multiple content forms from single sources

Network Effects:

- Content amplified through Movemental network
- Connections to other leaders' content
- Cross-references and connections
- Increased discoverability through network

Revenue Model:

- Direct subscription model
- Course/training monetization
- Newsletter monetization
- Direct-to-audience revenue

What Would Remain the Same

Voice & Control:

- Dave Ferguson's voice and perspective remain his own
- Content creation remains under his control
- Editorial control maintained
- Personal brand preserved

Theological Positions:

- All theological positions preserved
- Personal convictions maintained
- Movement alignment preserved

Existing Content:

- All existing books remain as published
- All blog content remains
- All institutional content remains

Relationships & Networks:

- Existing relationships preserved
- Institutional affiliations maintained (Community Christian Church, NewThing, Exponential)
- Movement connections preserved

Institutional Work:

- Community Christian Church work continues
- NewThing Network leadership continues
- Exponential Conference leadership continues

Specific Opportunities for Dave Ferguson

1. Content Repurposing:

- Sermons → Articles: Transcribe and publish sermon insights, develop sermon series into article series
- Conference Talks → Content: Transcribe talks, develop into articles, create content series
- Teaching → Multiple Forms: Capture teaching insights in articles, develop into courses

2. Content Expansion:

- Leadership Multiplication: Expand "Hero Maker" concepts, develop leadership frameworks, create content series
- Church Planting: Expand "Exponential" concepts, develop planting strategies, create content series
- Missional Living: Expand "B.L.E.S.S." concepts, develop missional practices, create content series

3. **Ecosystem Building:**

- Create unified content hub
- Connect content pieces across platforms
- Develop themes into content series
- Create content journeys

4. **Network Amplification:**

- Content discoverable through Movemental network
- Connections to other leaders' content
- Cross-references increase visibility
- Network recommendations increase reach

Network Effect Potential

High Potential For:

- Content amplification through network
- Audience growth through network reach
- Content development through network collaboration
- Movement impact through collective authority

What We Will NOT Do

Boundaries

- **No Content Changes:** All existing content remains unchanged
- **No Voice Changes:** Dave Ferguson's voice and perspective remain his own
- **No Theological Changes:** All theological positions preserved
- **No Relationship Changes:** Existing relationships and networks preserved
- **No Institutional Changes:** All institutional work and commitments continue

What Remains Entirely Dave Ferguson's

- Voice, control, and personal brand
- All existing content and published works
- All relationships and networks
- All institutional work and commitments
- All editorial and creative control

Research Notes

Recent Developments (2025)

- Transitioned from Lead Pastor to Co-Founding Pastor at Community Christian Church

- NewThing Network joined forces with Exponential Conference
- These transitions may create new content opportunities and distribution patterns

Research Limitations

- Initial research phase - deeper content analysis needed
- Blog content volume and themes to be assessed
- Sermon/teaching content volume to be verified
- Conference talk content to be cataloged
- Social media engagement metrics to be assessed

Confidence Level

High Confidence in:

- Identity verification
- Core digital presence mapping
- Content themes and focus areas
- Institutional affiliations
- Published works

Medium Confidence in:

- Content volume assessments
- Content organization details
- Discoverability specifics
- Gap analysis specifics

Research conducted: January 4, 2026

Confidence Level: High

Sources: See sources.md

Author Profile — Identity

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/profile/identity.md

Identity: Dave Ferguson

Status: Complete

Last updated: 2026-05-27

Confidence: HIGH (core facts); MEDIUM (some education details, birth year)

Disambiguation

"Dave Ferguson" is a common name. This profile covers the church-planting pastor and movement leader associated with Community Christian Church (Naperville/Chicago, IL), NewThing, and Exponential. There are no significant name collisions in the Christian ministry or church-planting world, but researchers should distinguish:

1. **Dave Ferguson (church planter, author, movement leader)** — THIS IS OUR SUBJECT.
Co-Founding Pastor of Community Christian Church (founded 1989), Founder/Visionary of NewThing, CEO of Exponential. Known for Hero Maker, B.L.E.S.S., and On the Verge.
Residence: Naperville, IL.
2. **Dave Ferguson (leadership coach)** — A separate individual who appears on LinkedIn as "The Leaders' Coach." Unrelated to our subject. Distinguish by Naperville/Chicago geography and church-planting context.
3. **Dr. David L. Ferguson** — A different individual (deceased, per obituary listings). Unrelated.

Reliable disambiguation modifiers: "Community Christian Church," "Naperville," "NewThing," "Exponential," "@fergusondave," "church planting," "Hero Maker," "BLESS," "reproducing churches."

Canonical Identity

Field	Value	Confidence	Source
Full Name	Dave Ferguson (no middle name/initial publicly used)	HIGH	daveferguson.org/about-dave , exponential.org/person/dave-f
Known As / Goes By	Dave Ferguson; @fergusondave	HIGH	daveferguson.org , instagram.com/fergusondave
Birth Year	Circa 1962 (Internet Archive catalog record for The Big Idea lists "Ferguson, Dave, 1962-")	MEDIUM	archive.org/details/bigideafocusmess0000ferg
Birth Date	UNKNOWN — no public birth date found	UNVERIFIED	—
Birthplace	UNKNOWN — grew up in Chicago area after age 4; parents moved from rural Missouri	PARTIAL	Outreach Magazine interview referenced in search results
Current Location	Naperville, Illinois (Chicago area)	HIGH	exponential.org/person/dave-f ; instagram.com/fergusondave
Nationality	American	LIKELY	All institutional affiliations are US-based
Primary Current Role	Co-Founding Pastor, Community Christian Church; CEO & President, Exponential	HIGH	communitychristian.org/about ; exponential.org/about

Education

Institution	Degree	Field	Year	Source
Lincoln Christian University (Lincoln, IL)	Bachelor of Arts	Bible and Communications	1986	lincolinchristian.edu — 2021 Restoration Award ; confirmed "LCC '86 BA"
Wheaton College Graduate School (Wheaton, IL)	Master of Arts	Educational Ministries, specializing in Church Planting	1991 (baseline; not directly confirmed in fetched sources)	Baseline identity- verification.md ; wheaton.edu adjunct faculty listing confirms current adjunct role

Notes on education:

- The Lincoln Christian University degree is verified: the university's own 2021 Restoration Award announcement designates Dave as "LCC '86 BA."
- Jon Ferguson is confirmed as "LCC '87 BA" — one year behind Dave, consistent with reported college roommate relationship.
- The Wheaton Graduate School MA (1991) is stated in the baseline document and consistent

with Ferguson being on Wheaton's adjunct faculty in Evangelism and Leadership; the specific 1991 graduation year has not been independently verified from a fetched source — MEDIUM confidence.

- No doctoral degree has been identified. Ferguson holds an MA, not a PhD. He is an alumnus of Lincoln Christian and Wheaton, not an academic theologian.

Career Timeline

Year(s)	Role	Organization	Source
Pre-1989	Youth pastor (first full-time ministry role)	Unspecified (unnamed church context)	exponential.org/person/dave-f
March 5, 1989	Co-founded	Community Christian Church — first service at Naperville Central High School cafeteria with Dave, Jon, and 5 college friends	communitychristian.org/about
1989–2025	Founding and Lead Pastor	Community Christian Church (Naperville/Chicago area multi-site)	daveferguson.org/about-dave ; communitychristian.org/about
1997 (approx.)	Multi-site expansion	First additional CCC campus launched in Romeoville, IL — among earliest multi-site churches in America	communitychristian.org/about
2001	Co-founded	NewThing Network — international church-planting movement launched out of Community Christian Church	communitychristian.org/about
2007	Published	The Big Idea (Zondervan/Leadership Network Innovation Series)	amazon.com
2007–present	Author	11 books spanning church strategy, leadership multiplication, missional living, and spiritual formation	daveferguson.org/books
~2010	Founded / led	Exponential Conference; became President/CEO	exponential.org/about
2010–present	Adjunct Professor	Wheaton College Graduate School — Evangelism and Leadership Department	Life and Leadership; wheaton.edu
April 1, 2025	NewThing joined Exponential	As unified organization; NewThing ceased as separate entity	exponential.org/bettertogether
May 1, 2025	Transitioned	Lead Pastor → Co-Founding Pastor, Community Christian Church; Ted Coniaris became Lead Pastor	communitychristian.org/about ; unseminary.com

Current Roles (as of 2026)

Role	Organization	Notes
Co-Founding Pastor	Community Christian Church (7 locations: Aurora, Carillon, Downers Grove, Lincoln Park, Naperville, Plainfield, Yorkville)	Focuses on teaching, coaching; Ted Coniaris is Lead Pastor since May 2025
CEO & President, Co-Founder	Exponential (nonprofit, 501(c)3)	Serves evangelical church-planting community across 100+ networks and denominations; vision: "16% Mission"
Founder / Visionary	NewThing (now integrated into Exponential)	Merged April 1, 2025; Patrick O'Connell became Executive Director of Practice
Author	Published by Zondervan, WaterBrook/Multnomah, Exponential Resources	Most recent: Multiplier (Zondervan Reflective, March 2026)
Adjunct Professor	Wheaton College Graduate School (Evangelism and Leadership)	Ongoing

Family & Personal

- **Spouse:** Sue Ferguson — described by Dave as "the perfect complement with her drive and honesty, keeping me grounded"; a forming influence on his personal and ministry life
- **Children:** Three — Amy, Joshua (Josh), and Caleb
- **Father:** Dave's father was a church planter (moved from rural Missouri to Chicago when Dave was age 4 to plant a church in the Restoration Movement tradition). His father later became a campus pastor at Community Christian Church.
- **Brother:** Jon Ferguson — co-founder of Community Christian Church, co-author on multiple books; the two have described doing "all of life together — from D & J Lawn Service as boys, to college roommates, to planting the church." Jon is also a Co-Founding Pastor at CCC.
- **Running:** Ferguson runs marathons; active in fitness (mentioned in podcast contexts)
- **Self-description:** "award-winning author, founding and lead pastor of Chicago's Community Christian Church... visionary for the international church-planting movement NewThing and president of the Exponential Conference" (standard bio language)

Institutional Affiliations

Organization	Role	Status
Community Christian Church	Co-Founding Pastor	Active (as of 2025–2026)
Exponential	CEO & President, Co-Founder	Active
NewThing	Founder/Visionary (integrated into Exponential)	Integrated April 2025
Wheaton College Graduate School	Adjunct Professor, Evangelism and Leadership	Active (confirmed per adjunct faculty listing)
Stadia East	Board member	Referenced in older sources; status unconfirmed as of 2026 — UNKNOWN

Digital Presence

Platform	Handle / URL	Status
Personal website	daveferguson.org	Active — blog, books, about, contact
Instagram	@fergusondave	Active
Facebook	facebook.com/dave.ferguson	Active
LinkedIn	linkedin.com/in/daveferguson	Active
Exponential profile	exponential.org/person/dave-f	Active
Community Christian	communitychristian.org	Active

Key Relationships & Collaborators

Person	Relationship	Source
Jon Ferguson	Brother, co-founder CCC, frequent co-author	Multiple sources; daveferguson.org
Alan Hirsch	Co-author (On the Verge, 2011); intellectual peer in missional-church movement	amazon.com
Warren Bird	Co-author (Hero Maker, 2018)	amazon.com
Patrick O'Connell	Co-author (Together, Exponential); became Executive Director of Practice at Exponential post-merger	amazon.com ; exponential.org/bettertogether
Todd Wilson	Co-author (Becoming a Level Five Multiplying Church eBook)	theunstuckgroup.com
Ted Coniaris	Pastoral apprentice; succeeded Ferguson as Lead Pastor at CCC, May 2025	communitychristian.org ; unseminary.com
Raj Pillai	Chief of Staff, Exponential International	exponential.org/bettertogether
Eric Bramlett	Co-author (The Big Idea); Executive Pastor of Worship Arts at CCC	amazon.com ; communitychristian.org
Ed Stetzer	Endorser (Hero Maker) — "Dave has an unmatched heart and passion for multiplication"	heromakerbook.org

Open Gaps

- Full legal first/middle name not confirmed publicly (goes by "Dave," no legal name record found)
- Exact birth date: not public; birth year circa 1962 is LOW-MEDIUM confidence (one library catalog source)
- Stadia East board membership: listed in older biographies; current status unknown
- Specific MA thesis title or thesis topic from Wheaton Graduate School: not found
- Ferguson's Twitter/X handle: links exist on website but handle not confirmed in fetched sources (may be @fergusondave or @daveferguson)

Biography

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/profile/biography.md

Biography: Dave Ferguson

Status: Complete

Last updated: 2026-05-27

Narrative Biography

Dave Ferguson is a church planter, author, and movement leader who has spent more than three decades building one of America's most influential churches, launching an international church-planting network, and catalyzing a global movement of reproducing congregations. As CEO of Exponential, Co-Founding Pastor of Community Christian Church, and the founding visionary of NewThing, Ferguson has become one of the defining practitioner voices in the North American church-multiplication movement. His work is distinguished by a rare integration of local pastoral depth — he co-founded a single church in 1989 and watched it become a multi-site community of thousands — with global apostolic ambition: the NewThing network grew to nearly 1,700 church-planting networks in 47 countries by 2022 before merging with Exponential in 2025.

Ferguson's story begins in the Midwest. When he was approximately four years old, his parents moved from rural Missouri to the Chicago area to plant a church in the Restoration Movement tradition — the independent Christian Church network that traces its heritage to the 19th-century restoration of New Testament Christianity. Ferguson grew up in that church-planting household, watching his father establish and lead a congregation that eventually grew to roughly 1,000 members and expanded to multiple locations before "multisite" had become a recognized category in American church leadership. His father would eventually become a campus pastor at the church Dave himself founded — a remarkable multigenerational story of church-planting continuity. His brother Jon Ferguson — two years younger than Dave — shared that upbringing and would become his most consistent ministry partner across forty years, from a childhood lawn care business ("D & J Lawn Service") to college roommates at Lincoln Christian University to co-founders of Community Christian Church.

Education

Dave Ferguson earned his Bachelor of Arts in Bible and Communications from Lincoln Christian University (Lincoln, IL) in 1986. Jon Ferguson graduated from the same institution the following year ("LCC '87 BA"), confirming the brothers' documented college overlap. After Lincoln Christian, Dave pursued graduate study at Wheaton College Graduate School, earning

a Master of Arts in Educational Ministries with a specialization in Church Planting in 1991 (year per baseline documentation; year unconfirmed from a fetched primary source). His first full-time ministry role following his education was as a youth pastor — a formative context where his focus on developing leaders first took shape.

The Founding of Community Christian Church (1989)

On March 5, 1989, Dave and Jon Ferguson gathered with five friends from college in the cafeteria of Naperville Central High School and held the first service of what would become Community Christian Church. The founding vision was simple but far-reaching: to create a community that would help people "find their way back to God." That phrase — "helping people find their way back to God" — has remained the organizational tagline and north star for more than three and a half decades.

The early years required the kind of patience and tenacity common to church-planting stories. From that high school cafeteria, the church grew gradually and consistently. Approximately eight years after launch, in the late 1990s, Community Christian Church established its first additional campus in Romeoville, Illinois — making it one of the early pioneers of the multi-site model in American evangelical churches, before that model had widespread recognition or a common name. The Romeoville launch established the church's identity not merely as a single congregation but as a network of connected communities sharing a common mission and culture.

Over the following decades, the church continued to expand across the Chicago suburbs. By the time Ferguson stepped out of the Lead Pastor role in 2025, Community Christian operated seven locations: Aurora, Carillon, Downers Grove, Lincoln Park, Naperville, Plainfield, and Yorkville. The church's three-fold vision — functioning as an impact church, a reproducing church, and a catalyst for global church movement — held together local presence and global ambition. The church has been consistently recognized by Outreach Magazine as one of America's most influential churches.

Dave's father eventually joined the CCC staff as a campus pastor, and Jon Ferguson has served as Co-Founding Pastor, teacher, and movement architect throughout. Sue Ferguson, Dave's wife, has been a grounding and formative presence throughout the pastoral journey; the couple has three children — Amy, Joshua, and Caleb.

NewThing: From Local Vision to Global Network (2001-2025)

In 2001, twelve years after founding Community Christian Church, Ferguson launched NewThing — a church-planting mission designed to take the reproducing-church vision beyond CCC's own campuses and catalyze a broader movement. NewThing's mission was to be "a catalyst for a movement of reproducing churches," and its approach centered on equipping and networking leaders who could replicate church planting ecosystems across cities and nations.

The network's growth was significant. By 2022, NewThing comprised 1,696 church-planting networks operating in 47 countries. Ferguson served as the visionary and apostolic leader of the network throughout this period, working with Patrick O'Connell and others on practical implementation. The NewThing model emphasized relationality and reproducibility: rather than simply planting churches, it sought to build systems and cultures that could generate church-planting movements organically across diverse contexts.

The theological logic underlying NewThing is captured in the concept that shaped Ferguson's book *Together: The Great Collaboration* (2020, with Patrick O'Connell): the Great Commission (Go), the Great Commandment (Love), and the Great Collaboration (Together) are inseparable. Reproducing churches are not independent entrepreneurial ventures but interconnected communities advancing a shared kingdom agenda through networked relationships.

Exponential: Building the Church-Planting Ecosystem

Alongside NewThing, Ferguson served as President/CEO and Co-Founder of Exponential — the world's largest church-planting conference and resource network. Exponential operates as a 501(c)3 nonprofit serving the evangelical church-planting community across more than 100 networks and denominations. Its organizing vision is what Ferguson calls the "16% Mission": currently only 7% of American churches are multiplying; the goal is to reach a tipping point where 16% of U.S. churches become reproducing or multiplying, generating movement dynamics across the broader culture.

Exponential provides conferences (both national and regional), learning communities, cohorts, resources, and research to equip church planters and multiplication-minded leaders. Ferguson's leadership of the conference has made him a central convener of the North American church-planting conversation.

The 2025 Convergences

Two major transitions in 2025 marked a significant reshaping of Ferguson's institutional landscape.

First, on April 1, 2025, NewThing officially joined Exponential as a unified organization. NewThing ceased operations as a separate entity, and its staff, networks, and expertise were integrated into Exponential's structure. Patrick O'Connell became Executive Director of Practice within the merged organization. The merger was framed around three objectives: advancing the 16% Mission in the U.S., launching Exponential International (leveraging NewThing's relationships across 60+ countries across nine world regions), and strengthening financial development. Ferguson described the animating principle behind the decision as "Kingdom over Castle" — a phrase that captures his conviction that organizational structures should be subordinated to kingdom mission.

Second, on May 1, 2025, Ferguson transitioned from Lead Pastor to Co-Founding Pastor at Community Christian Church. Ted Coniaris — who had joined CCC as a leadership resident approximately eight years earlier, planted a location, and served as director of all location

pastors — became Lead Pastor after an eighteen-month public apprenticeship process. The transition embodied the very hero-making and apprenticeship theology Ferguson has written and taught: an eighteen-month process using the five-step apprenticeship model that Ferguson himself had articulated in Exponential — "I do, you watch, we talk" through to "You do, someone else watches." Ferguson remains on the CCC staff team, focusing on teaching, coaching, and leading Exponential.

Authorship Arc

Ferguson's books trace the evolution of his ministry thinking across nearly two decades. They fall into four thematic clusters:

Church strategy and the "Big Idea" (2007–2011): The Big Idea (Zondervan, 2007, with Jon Ferguson and Eric Bramlett) introduced his philosophy of one laser-focused teaching theme per week, aligned across all church ministries through creative collaboration. Exponential (Zondervan, 2010, with Jon Ferguson) narrated the Community Christian story as a template for missional church movements. On the Verge (Zondervan, 2011, with Alan Hirsch) co-articulated the apostolic-movement framework with the foremost missional theologian of the era, grounding CCC's practice in Hirsch's "mDNA" and "Apostolic Genius" theology.

Mission activation and multiplication metrics (2012–2013): Discover Your Mission Now (Missio Publishing, 2012, with Jon Ferguson and Tim Sutherland) laid out five missional practices for everyday Christians. Keeping Score (Exponential Resources, 2014) challenged churches to redefine success metrics around disciple-making and movement-making rather than attendance and budget alone.

Relational evangelism and spiritual journey (2015–2016): Finding Your Way Back to God (WaterBrook/Multnomah, 2015, with Jon Ferguson) addressed the returning and spiritually wandering with the "Five Awakenings" framework drawn from the Parable of the Prodigal Son: Awakening to Longing, Regret, Help, Love, and Life. Starting Over (WaterBrook/Multnomah, with Jon Ferguson) addressed the recognize-release-redeem process for regret in five life domains.

Leadership multiplication (2018–2026): Hero Maker (Zondervan, 2018, with Warren Bird) is Ferguson's defining work on leadership development, presenting the five practices of hero-making leaders — multiplication thinking, permission giving, disciple multiplying, gift activating, and kingdom building — as a holistic culture shift from individual heroism to leadership multiplication. B.L.E.S.S. (2020, with Jon Ferguson) distilled missional neighboring into five everyday practices. Together (Exponential, 2020, with Patrick O'Connell) articulated the networked-collaboration model underlying NewThing. Multiplier (Zondervan Reflective, March 2026) addresses sustainable leadership health through the RPMS framework and the external multiplication practices required for long-term kingdom impact.

Ferguson also co-authored the eBook *Becoming a Level Five Multiplying Church* (with Todd Wilson and Alan Hirsch), which introduced the five-level framework for diagnosing where a church falls on the growth-to-multiplication spectrum.

Lincoln Christian University Recognition

In 2021, Lincoln Christian University honored both Dave (LCC '86 BA) and Jon Ferguson (LCC '87 BA) with its Restoration Award — the university's highest alumni recognition. The award cited their founding of Community Christian Church, the NewThing network, and the Exponential Conference as expressions of the university's Restoration Movement heritage applied to church-planting innovation.

Origin & Formation

Dave Ferguson's formation was shaped by three convergent forces: a church-planting household, a Restoration Movement theological inheritance, and a Midwestern relational culture that prizes collaboration over celebrity.

Growing up watching his father plant and grow a church from scratch gave Ferguson an early, concrete picture of what it looks like to start a congregation from nothing and see it grow. The Restoration Movement heritage — with its emphasis on returning to New Testament Christianity, baptism, and non-creedal simplicity — provided a theological grammar that prized practicality, Scripture centrality, and ecclesial reproducibility over denominational distinctives. Lincoln Christian University, a Restoration Movement institution, deepened that formation.

The brother-partnership with Jon Ferguson is one of the most distinctive features of Ferguson's ministry ecology. The two have co-founded, co-written, and co-pastored for their entire adult lives. This relational co-leadership is not incidental but reflects Ferguson's core conviction: that the kingdom advances through collaboration, not individual heroism.

Key Relationships & Influences

Person	Relationship	Significance
Jon Ferguson	Brother, co-founder, frequent co-author	From childhood through 2025, Jon has been Dave's most consistent ministry partner; co-authored seven books; CCC co-founder and Co-Founding Pastor
Alan Hirsch	Co-author, intellectual peer	On the Verge (2011) brought Ferguson's reproducing-church practice into dialogue with Hirsch's apostolic-movement theology. Endorser of Multiplier (2026).
Warren Bird	Co-author (Hero Maker)	Bird's research background complemented Ferguson's practitioner voice in articulating the five hero-making practices
Patrick O'Connell	Co-author (Together), institutional partner	Led NewThing operationally; became Executive Director of Practice at Exponential after merger
Todd Wilson	Co-author, Exponential partner	Collaborated on the Level Five Multiplying Church framework
Ted Coniaris	Pastoral apprentice, successor	Embodied the hero-making model Ferguson has taught; became Lead Pastor of CCC on May 1, 2025
Ed Stetzer	Endorser, peer	Billy Graham Distinguished Chair at Wheaton College; endorsed Hero Maker: "Dave has an unmatched heart and passion for multiplication"
Eric Bramlett	Co-author (The Big Idea), long-term CCC colleague	Served as creative collaborator at CCC and co-authored the church's Big Idea methodology
Sam Stephens	Exemplar figure	Indian church-planting leader whose father began a mission in the 1950s; by implementing apprenticeship structures in 1992, grew from 200 to ~70,000 churches. Ferguson uses this story to illustrate the exponential power of disciple-making movements.
Dennis Gamauf	Formative mentor figure	Gave Ferguson an ICNU conversation at summer camp: "Dave, I see in you someone who could be a really good leader" — an affirmation Ferguson still credits as shaping his self-understanding

In Their Own Words

"My fruit grows on other people's trees." — via [workplaces.org transcript](#)

"I'm the platform; I'm not the show." — via [workplaces.org transcript](#)

"As a leader, you reproduce who you are." — via [workplaces.org transcript](#)

"If you don't have a dream that's bigger than you, you need to get a bigger dream." — via [churchleadership.com](#)

"Multiplication church planting leads to movement and movement is how we accomplish the mission of Jesus." — via churchleaders.com

"You can tell what a culture values by what gets spontaneous applause." — quoting Kim Hammond; used by Ferguson in teaching culture formation, via churchleaders.com

"It's God's job to judge people. It's the Holy Spirit's job to convict people. It's your job to love your neighbor." — via churchleaders.com

"Am I trying to be the hero, or am I trying to make heroes out of others?" — Hero Maker (2018), via goodreads.com

"It's a travesty when we keep [Christianity] to ourselves and we don't multiply at every level." — via churchleaders.com

"You reproduce who you are and what you do." — Multiplier (2026), via jeffmclain.com

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Theological Profile

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/profile/theology.md

Theological Profile: Dave Ferguson

Status: Complete

Last updated: 2026-05-27

Core Thesis

The mission of Jesus is fundamentally a multiplication mission, and the church fulfills that mission not by growing larger but by reproducing disciples, leaders, groups, churches, and networks at every level. A leader's primary calling is not to be the hero — not to accumulate platform, congregation, or influence — but to make heroes of others by calling out their God-given gifts and releasing them into apprenticeship-based ministry. Healthy, reproducing leaders and healthy, reproducing churches are the engine of kingdom movement; the church does not advance through the addition of attendees but through the multiplication of sent, mission-shaped people. This multiplication vision must be held together by relational collaboration ("the Great Collaboration") and grounded in incarnational neighboring practices (BLESS) that make the mission concrete and accessible for every ordinary Christian.

Theological Tradition

Primary: Evangelical missional theology, rooted in church-planting practice and the reproducing-church movement.

Denominational heritage: Independent Christian Church / Churches of Christ (Restoration Movement). Ferguson grew up in a Restoration Movement household (his parents planted a church in this tradition when he moved from Missouri to Chicago at age 4). Lincoln Christian University — his undergraduate institution — is a flagship Restoration Movement school. Community Christian Church operates in the independent Christian Church tradition, emphasizing non-creedal, Scripture-centered Christianity, baptism, and ecclesial simplicity. The Restoration Movement's historic concern for returning to New Testament Christianity maps closely onto Ferguson's emphasis on apostolic church planting and movement ecclesiology.

Secondary influences:

- **Missional-incarnational movement** (Alan Hirsch, Michael Frost): Ferguson co-authored *On the Verge* (2011) with Hirsch; his practical ecclesiology draws heavily on Hirsch's "mDNA" (missional DNA), "Apostolic Genius," and APEST (Apostles, Prophets, Evangelists, Shepherds, Teachers) framework, applying these to the American multi-site and church-planting context.

- **Church-growth movement (adapted and critiqued):** Ferguson employs church-growth language (metrics, growth stages, scoreboards) but redirects it toward multiplication rather than accumulation. His five-level church typology (decline, plateau, growing, reproducing, multiplying) critiques the dominant Level 3 "growing" model as insufficient.

- **Evangelical missiology:** Engages the broader evangelical church-planting conversation through Exponential, where he convenes leaders from 100+ networks and denominations spanning Baptist, Wesleyan, Reformed, Pentecostal, and non-denominational traditions.

Theological method: Practitioner-inductive. Ferguson develops theology from the ground up — from lived church-planting experience at CCC and the NewThing network — and then frames it in accessible biblical terms. He is not a systematic theologian but a theological practitioner: he reads Scripture through the lens of what he has seen work in church planting, and he reads church-planting practice through the lens of what he finds in Jesus's ministry and the book of Acts.

Key Frameworks & Models

Framework	Description	Primary Source
Five-Level Church Typology	Level 1: Declining; Level 2: Plateaued; Level 3: Growing (most churches); Level 4: Reproducing; Level 5: Multiplying (movement-generating). Only ~4% of US churches are at Level 4 and far fewer at Level 5. The 16% Mission targets a tipping point where Level 4-5 churches become 16% of the total.	Becoming a Level Five Multiplying Church (eBook, with Todd Wilson and Alan Hirsch); theunstuckgroup.com
Five Practices of Hero Makers	1. Multiplication Thinking — shift from "my leadership" to "ministry through multiplied leaders"; 2. Permission Giving — ICNU conversations that release others' potential; 3. Disciple Multiplying — making disciples who make disciples via the five-step apprenticeship model; 4. Gift Activating — commissioning people's God-given gifts for ministry; 5. Kingdom Building — measuring success by kingdom advancement (disciples made and released), not attendance.	Hero Maker (Zondervan, 2018, with Warren Bird)
ICNU (I See in You)	The practice of naming and affirming the leadership potential in others before they see it in themselves. "I see in you what you don't see in yourselves" — Jesus's posture toward his disciples. A mentor named Dennis Gamauf gave Ferguson an ICNU conversation ("Dave, I see in you someone who could be a really good leader") that Ferguson credits as formative to his identity. ICNU conversations are the mechanism of permission giving.	exponential.org/hero-maker-2-permission-giver ; Hero Maker (2018)
Five-Step Apprenticeship Model	Jesus-shaped disciple-making in five steps: (1) I do, you watch, we talk; (2) I do, you help, we talk; (3) You do, I help, we talk; (4) You do, I watch, we talk; (5) You do, someone else watches. Each step progressively releases the apprentice toward independent multiplication. Ferguson applied this model to his own pastoral succession: Ted Coniaris moved through these steps over an 18-month process before becoming Lead Pastor in May 2025.	unseminary.com ; Hero Maker (2018); Exponential (2010)
BLESS (Five Missional Practices)	A five-practice framework for everyday incarnational neighboring: B egin with prayer (daily intercession for five specific neighbors); L isten (ask questions, understand their lives without immediately talking); E at (share meals; build relationship over food); S erve (respond to the needs discovered through listening); S hare (tell your personal story of faith when the relationship is ready). Rooted in Genesis 12:2 ("I will bless you... and you shall be a blessing") and illustrated by a Thai missionary study where "blessers" led ~100 people to faith versus 2 for information-distributors.	B.L.E.S.S. (2020, with Jon Ferguson); christianpost.com
Five Awakenings	Framework for understanding the spiritual journey of the prodigal/returning person, drawn from the Parable of the Prodigal Son: (1) Awakening to Longing; (2) Awakening to	Finding Your Way Back to God (WaterBrook/

Framework	Description	Primary Source
	Regret; (3) Awakening to Help; (4) Awakening to Love; (5) Awakening to Life. Designed for spiritually wandering people and for churches doing outreach and evangelism.	Multnomah, 2015, with Jon Ferguson)
The Big Idea	One laser-focused theme per week, aligned across all church ministries — preaching, children's ministry, small groups, hospitality, social media — through creative collaboration among church staff and volunteers. Counters "idea overload" in churches that bombard people with multiple competing messages.	The Big Idea (Zondervan, 2007, with Jon Ferguson and Eric Bramlett)
The Great Collaboration	The three great commands of Jesus synthesized: Great Commission (Go) + Great Commandment (Love) + Great Collaboration (Together). Reproducing church networks are not optional accessories but the infrastructure for kingdom movement.	Together: The Great Collaboration (Exponential, 2020, with Patrick O'Connell)
RPMS (Leader Health Gauges)	Four diagnostic "gauges" for monitoring leader health and preventing drift: Relational (Am I connected to life-giving relationships?), Physical (Am I stewarding my body?), Mental (Is my mind clear and grounded?), Spiritual (Am I abiding in Christ?). Drawn from Luke 2:52 ("Jesus grew in wisdom [mental] and stature [physical], and in favor with God [spiritual] and men [relational]"). Journaling-based practice, rated 1-10 daily.	Multiplier (Zondervan Reflective, 2026); globalleadership.org
The Drift Trio	Three corrosive forces that cause leaders to drift from health and integrity: (1) The World — surrounding leaders with empty, fleeting values; (2) The Flesh — corrupted desires and disordered passions; (3) The Devil — spiritual adversary working behind the scenes. Ferguson frames drift as incremental and unconscious: "leaders drift one day at a time."	Multiplier (2026); jeffmclain.com
Six Permission-Giving Levels	A spectrum for releasing leadership: (1) Watch and discuss; (2) Plan together; (3) They propose, you discuss; (4) They plan, you give feedback; (5) They handle independently, report results; (6) Complete autonomy. Leaders can calibrate where a given person sits on this spectrum and progressively move toward greater release.	exponential.org/hero-maker-2-permission-giver
Four-Stage Movement Framework (from On the Verge, with Hirsch)	(1) Imagine — develop missional perspective; (2) Shift — reframe ecclesial concepts; (3) Innovate — implement genuine innovation; (4) Move — generate sustained apostolic momentum. Applied to established large churches seeking to become apostolic movements.	On the Verge (Zondervan, 2011, with Alan Hirsch)

Distinctive Theological Positions

Multiplication over growth: Ferguson makes a consistent and sharp distinction between churches that grow (Level 3) and churches that reproduce and multiply (Levels 4–5). Growth without reproduction is, in his framework, a theological failure — it keeps kingdom resources within one organization rather than investing them in the next generation of disciples and churches. "Church growth is good but it's only good if it leads to multiplication, which is best." (churchleaders.com)

Every leader reproduces who they are: Leadership formation is ontological, not merely behavioral. "You reproduce who you are and what you do." (Multiplier, 2026) This is why internal health — relational, physical, mental, spiritual — is a theological issue, not merely a personal wellness concern. A spiritually unhealthy leader will inevitably replicate that unhealthiness in those they disciple.

Hero making over heroism: The American church-leader culture prizes the "hero pastor" — the gifted speaker and visionary leader who builds a large platform. Ferguson argues this is a theological distortion. Jesus spent 73% of his time with the Twelve (the apprenticeship minority) rather than the crowds. The leader's primary calling is to make other leaders great, not to be great themselves. "Am I trying to be the hero, or am I trying to make heroes out of others?" (Hero Maker, 2018)

Mission belongs to every believer: BLESS is deliberately designed to be practiced by "everyone — young and old" (book subtitle). The New Testament vision is of a kingdom of priests (1 Peter 2:9) in which every follower is sent on mission. Ferguson consistently pushes against a clergy-lay distinction in mission, framing all Christians as missionaries within their existing relational networks.

Prevenient grace shapes neighborly evangelism: In the BLESS framework, prayer comes first because Ferguson holds that God is already at work in every neighbor before the Christian shows up. The task is to listen and discern what God is already doing, then join it — rather than launching an "outreach program" that treats the neighbor as a passive target.

Kingdom metrics, not church metrics: Ferguson argues that churches measure the wrong things — attendance and budget — rather than the right things: disciples made, leaders released, churches planted. His concept of the "kingdom scoreboard" tracks who is currently in apprenticeship and how many leaders have been developed and released, making multiplication visible and accountable.

Collaboration as kingdom infrastructure: The merger of NewThing into Exponential in 2025 was framed by the principle "Kingdom over Castle." Organizations that hold their structures too tightly diminish the kingdom; leaders who are willing to subordinate institutional interests to kingdom mission enable movement-scale impact.

Spiritual health as multiplication prerequisite: Multiplier (2026) makes the argument that sustainable kingdom multiplication requires internal health first. "You can't multiply something that's not first alive in you." The leader who neglects the RPMS gauges will eventually fail publicly in ways that harm the communities they serve.

Ecclesiology

Ferguson's ecclesiology is best characterized as **apostolic-reproducing**: the church is a sent, reproducing organism, not a gathered, attracting institution. Its primary task is not to grow one congregation but to generate a movement of disciples and churches across every context.

Key ecclesiological commitments:

- **Multi-site as reproducing vehicle:** CCC's early expansion into multiple campuses was not merely a growth strategy but an expression of the church's identity as a reproducing community.
 - **Networked churches over independent churches:** NewThing's model of interconnected church-planting networks reflects Ferguson's conviction that the kingdom advances through collaboration ("Together"), not through the isolation of independent congregations.
 - **The local church as movement catalyst:** Community Christian Church has understood itself not as a destination but as a launching pad — an "impact church, reproducing church, and catalyst for global church movement" simultaneously.
 - **Restoring New Testament patterns:** The Restoration Movement heritage shows in Ferguson's appeal to Jesus's ministry and the book of Acts as the normative pattern for how the church should plant, reproduce, and multiply.
-

Intellectual Genealogy

Primary theological influences:

- **Alan Hirsch** — Ferguson's most significant intellectual conversation partner. The co-authorship of *On the Verge* (2011) brought Hirsch's APEST framework, mDNA, "Apostolic Genius," and *Forgotten Ways* missiological vision into direct integration with Ferguson's reproducing-church practice. Ferguson is self-described as "high on the apostolic gifting" — language drawn directly from Hirsch's APEST typology.
- **The Restoration Movement tradition** — Non-creedal, Scripture-centered, baptism-emphasizing, and ecclesially pragmatic. Ferguson's distrust of denominational gatekeeping and his appeal to New Testament simplicity trace to this heritage.
- **Jesus's discipleship model** — Ferguson reads the Gospels primarily through the lens of Jesus's time-allocation: 73% with the Twelve (apprenticeship), 27% with the masses. This becomes the hermeneutical key for his hero-making theology.

In conversation with:

- Todd Wilson (Exponential co-leader; Level Five church framework)
- Warren Bird (research collaborator; Hero Maker)
- Patrick O'Connell (NewThing implementation; Together)
- Ed Stetzer, Craig Groeschel, Christine Caine, Mark Batterson, Carey Nieuwhof, Derwin L. Gray (endorsers of Multiplier)

Pushes back against:

- **The hero-pastor model:** The celebrity-leader culture that prizes platform above reproduction. Ferguson's "hero maker" language is a deliberate inversion of this model.
 - **Attractional ecclesiology:** Churches designed to attract and retain — "come and see" — rather than to send and multiply — "go and be." The BLESS framework is explicitly designed to move everyday Christians out of a consumer posture into a missionary posture.
 - **Attendance-and-budget scorecards:** The dominant metrics of American church health, which Ferguson argues incentivize growth at Levels 1–3 and make multiplication invisible.
 - **Organizational castle-keeping:** Leaders and organizations that prioritize institutional self-preservation over kingdom collaboration. "Kingdom over Castle" is the counterproposal.
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Theological Evolution

Ferguson's theology has developed across three broadly identifiable phases:

Phase 1 — Church strategy and the Big Idea (2007–2011): The earliest books (The Big Idea, Exponential, On the Verge) focus on ecclesial structure and methodology — how a single church can become a movement, how creative collaboration aligns ministries, how the apostolic-movement framework maps onto contemporary American church planting. This phase is primarily strategic and ecclesiological.

Phase 2 — Mission activation and spiritual journey (2012–2015): Discover Your Mission Now, Keeping Score, and Finding Your Way Back to God mark a turn toward the individual believer's missional identity and the spiritual journey of the un- or de-churched. The theology here is more pastoral and evangelistic — how does every Christian participate in mission? What does the journey back to God look like? This phase broadens the audience from church leaders to ordinary Christians and spiritual seekers.

Phase 3 — Leader health and multiplication sustainability (2018–2026): Hero Maker (2018), B.L.E.S.S. (2020), and Multiplier (2026) represent Ferguson's mature integration of multiplication theology with leader formation and personal health. The question is no longer simply "how do churches multiply?" but "how do leaders sustain the inner life that makes multiplication possible over decades?" This phase introduces the RPMS framework and the concept of the Drift Trio — arguably Ferguson's most theologically searching contribution, because it takes the multiplication imperative and grounds it in a realistic anthropology of human limitation and the possibility of leadership failure.

Throughout all three phases, Ferguson's core commitments — reproducing disciples, releasing leaders, networking churches, measuring by kingdom metrics — remain constant. The progression moves from ecclesial methodology to personal missional formation to integrated leader health.

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Vocational Profile

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/profile/calling-profile.md

Dave Ferguson: Calling Profile

Status: Complete

Last updated: 2026-06-05

Calling statement

Dave Ferguson is called to **multiply leaders, churches, and movements** — to shift the North American church from addition to reproduction, from hero-pastor culture to hero-making culture, and from isolated congregations to networked kingdom collaboration. His vocation is practitioner-first: in March 1989 he and his brother Jon gathered five college friends in a high school cafeteria to plant Community Christian Church, watched it grow into a seven-location multi-site community, and used that local laboratory to launch NewThing (2001) and Exponential — building an international church-planting network that reached nearly 1,700 networks in 47 countries before merging with Exponential in 2025. Ferguson is not primarily a theologian or a conference personality; he is a multiplication architect who has spent more than three decades proving that the mission of Jesus is fulfilled when ordinary disciples, leaders, and churches reproduce at every level. His defining vocational signature is hero-making: "My fruit grows on other people's trees."

Core calling elements

1. Church multiplication movement catalyst

- Convenes the world's largest church-planting conference (Exponential) and advances the "16% Mission" — the tipping point where reproducing churches become 16% of U.S. congregations
- Built NewThing as "a catalyst for a movement of reproducing churches" (2001–2025)
- Frames multiplication as the mission of Jesus: "Multiplication church planting leads to movement and movement is how we accomplish the mission of Jesus."

2. Local church practitioner

- Co-founded Community Christian Church in 1989; led it as Lead Pastor for 36 years before transitioning to Co-Founding Pastor in May 2025
- Pioneered multi-site expansion in the late 1990s (Romeoville campus) before the model was widely recognized
- Embodied his own succession theology: Ted Coniaris apprenticed for 18 months through the five-step model before becoming Lead Pastor

3. Hero-maker and leadership multiplier

- Hero Maker (2018) is his defining vocational articulation — five practices that shift leaders from heroism to multiplication thinking, permission giving, disciple multiplying, gift activating, and kingdom building
- "As a leader, you reproduce who you are" — internal health is vocational, not merely personal
- "Am I trying to be the hero, or am I trying to make heroes out of others?"

4. Network architect and convener

- Merged NewThing into Exponential (April 2025) under the principle "Kingdom over Castle" — organizational structures subordinated to kingdom mission
- Articulates the Great Collaboration: Great Commission (Go) + Great Commandment (Love) + Great Collaboration (Together)
- Bridges denominations and networks — Exponential serves 100+ networks across Baptist, Wesleyan, Reformed, Pentecostal, and non-denominational traditions

5. Mission activator for ordinary Christians

- BLESS framework makes incarnational neighboring accessible to every believer — begin with prayer, listen, eat, serve, share
- "It's God's job to judge people. It's the Holy Spirit's job to convict people. It's your job to love your neighbor."
- Consistently pushes against clergy-lay distinctions in mission

Vocational arc

Season	Milestone	Calling expression
Formation	Church-planting household (parents moved from Missouri to Chicago at age 4); Lincoln Christian University BA (1986); Wheaton MA in Church Planting (~1991)	Restoration Movement heritage; relational Midwestern collaboration culture
Launch	Community Christian Church founded — March 5, 1989, Naperville Central High School cafeteria	"Helping people find their way back to God" as enduring north star
Expansion	Multi-site pioneer (~1997 Romeoville); NewThing launched (2001); Exponential founded (~2010)	Local church → reproducing network → global convening platform
Articulation	The Big Idea (2007) → Exponential (2010) → On the Verge with Alan Hirsch (2011) → Hero Maker (2018) → B.L.E.S.S. (2020) → Multiplier (2026)	Practitioner theology published across strategy, multiplication, mission, and leader health
Convergence	NewThing joins Exponential (April 2025); Lead Pastor → Co-Founding Pastor at CCC (May 2025)	Kingdom over Castle; living the hero-making succession he has taught

Movement leadership map

Influence area	Scope	Role
Church planters and multiplication leaders (North America)	National	Exponential CEO; 16% Mission convener; Level 4–5 church typology
Global church-planting networks	47+ countries (pre-merger NewThing footprint)	Exponential International via NewThing relationships
Senior pastors and lead pastors	National	Hero Maker practices; apprenticeship succession model; RPMS leader health
Ordinary Christians / neighbors	Every context	BLESS everyday missional practices
Restoration Movement / independent Christian Church	Denominational heritage	Lincoln Christian Restoration Award (2021); CCC as reference church

Content-calling alignment

Content type	Serves calling?	Notes
Hero Maker (2018)	Yes — defining	Five hero-making practices; Warren Bird co-author
Exponential (2010)	Yes — narrative	CCC story as missional movement template
On the Verge (2011, with Alan Hirsch)	Yes — theological bridge	Apostolic-movement framework for established churches
B.L.E.S.S. (2020)	Yes — mission activation	Everyday neighboring for every believer
Together (2020, with Patrick O'Connell)	Yes — network	Great Collaboration ecclesiology underlying NewThing
Finding Your Way Back to God (2015)	Yes — pastoral	Five Awakenings for spiritually wandering people
Multiplier (2026)	Yes — leader health	RPMS gauges and sustainable multiplication
Becoming a Level Five Multiplying Church	Yes — diagnostic	Five-level typology with Todd Wilson and Alan Hirsch
Exponential Conference & resources	Yes — equipping	World's largest church-planting convening platform
Community Christian Church teaching	Yes — practitioner base	Multi-site sermons and culture as lived laboratory

Overall alignment: Very strong. Nearly all published work serves the same vocational through-line — multiplication at every level, hero-making leadership, and mission accessible to ordinary Christians.

Distinctive vocational signature

Ferguson's calling is distinguished within the wider church-multiplication ecosystem by three features:

1. **Practitioner credibility at scale** — he built one of America's most influential churches from a cafeteria, not from a think tank. Exponential and NewThing grew out of lived local practice, not theory imposed on others.
2. **Hero-making as vocational center** — where many multiplication leaders emphasize church planting math, Ferguson emphasizes leader development culture. His succession of Ted Coniaris is the lived proof of the model.
3. **Kingdom over Castle** — his 2025 institutional convergences (NewThing → Exponential; Lead Pastor → Co-Founding Pastor) embody the conviction that structures exist to serve multiplication, not to preserve organizational castles.

In his own words

"My fruit grows on other people's trees."

"I'm the platform; I'm not the show."

"If you don't have a dream that's bigger than you, you need to get a bigger dream."

"It's a travesty when we keep [Christianity] to ourselves and we don't multiply at every level."

Voice & Editorial Identity

[docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/profile/voice-analysis.md](#)

Voice Analysis: Dave Ferguson

Status: Complete

Last updated: 2026-05-27

Sources analyzed: workplaces.org podcast transcript, churchleaders.com podcast transcripts, churchleadership.com podcast, globalleadership.org article, exponential.org blog posts, heromakerbook.org, thinkr.org blog, patheos.com and jeffmcclain.com Multiplier reviews, christianpost.com BLESS interview, redletterchallenge.com podcast, christianstandard.com interview, Goodreads reviews of Hero Maker, Multiplier, and Finding Your Way Back to God.

Voice Summary

Dave Ferguson writes and speaks as an optimistic, framework-building practitioner — someone whose theological convictions were forged in the concrete experience of planting a church from scratch in a high school cafeteria and watching it become one of America's most influential multi-site communities. His voice is accessible, story-anchored, and relentlessly oriented toward multiplication. He is more motivator than diagnostician, more apostolic catalyzer than systematic theologian. Where JR Woodward leads with careful academic diagnosis, Ferguson leads with contagious optimism and practical permission. His signature move is to take a cultural assumption (leaders should be heroes; success means a big crowd) and invert it with a crisp, memorable counter-frame (make heroes of others; measure your kingdom scoreboard). He is framework-heavy — every concept comes packaged in numbered practices, acronyms, or named steps — but the frameworks are always in service of a motivational invitation, not an analytical conclusion.

The Ascent Leader profile captures a core trait: Ferguson is characterized by "natural optimism and his innovation in church planting and the multisite model." This optimism is not naivety — his Multiplier (2026) engages seriously with leader failure and drift — but it is the dominant register of his public voice. He believes multiplication is possible, accessible, and urgent, and he communicates that conviction with enthusiasm and concrete examples.

Writing Characteristics

Dimension	Assessment
Register	Popular-practitioner. Ferguson writes for church leaders and ordinary Christians, not academics. Prose is clear, direct, and conversational. He integrates theological concepts (kingdom metrics, apostolic gifting, prevenient grace) without heavy theological terminology; where he uses a concept word, he immediately illustrates it. Accessible to a wide evangelical readership.
Complexity	Moderate. Ferguson's frameworks are multi-part (five practices, five awakenings, five levels, five steps, four gauges) and systematic, but the individual components are simple and clearly defined. The density comes from the number of distinct frameworks across his body of work, not from the complexity of any single framework. Multiplier reviewers note his writing combines "transparency and shared vulnerability" with practical structures.
Tone	Motivational-invitational. Ferguson consistently writes from a posture of possibility: multiplication is not just desirable but achievable, and the reader has what it takes. He is direct about diagnosing problems (the hero-pastor culture, the attendance scorecard, leadership drift) but the emotional landing is always toward hope and action rather than judgment.
Storytelling	High — concrete personal narratives are central to his communication. Stories include: Dennis Gamauf's ICNU conversation at summer camp; the friendship with Michael Kinne (baptized after years of breakfast and home group); Sam Stephens's Indian church-planting movement growing from 200 to 70,000 churches; the five-step apprenticeship applied in Ferguson's own pastoral succession (Ted Coniaris). He reaches quickly for a specific person or moment to ground any abstraction.
Humor	Light to moderate. Ferguson uses self-deprecation and relational warmth in spoken contexts (he has described his analytical nature with ironic self-awareness). Written work is generally earnest and direct, but less humor-dense than some evangelical communicators.
Scripture Use	Illustrative and practical. Key texts recur across his body of work: Luke 2:52 (Jesus grew in wisdom, stature, favor with God and men — the RPMS template), John 14:12 ("greater things than me"), Matthew 28:18-20 (Great Commission), 1 Peter 2:9 (kingdom of priests), Genesis 12:2 (be a blessing), Acts 1:8 (Jerusalem, Judea, Samaria, the ends of the earth). Ferguson does not do extended exegesis; he uses Scripture to crystallize and authorize his practitioner frameworks. He reads the Gospels primarily through the lens of Jesus's time-allocation: 73% with the Twelve (apprenticeship), 27% with the crowds.

Signature Patterns

Recurring Phrases and Language

- **"Helping people find their way back to God"** — the foundational tagline of Community Christian Church; appears across all contexts as the organizing mission statement
- **"Hero maker"** — his signature leadership identity term; the leader who makes heroes of others rather than seeking personal heroism
- **"Multiplication thinking"** — the paradigm shift from "How can I grow my church?" to "How can we multiply God's kingdom?"

- **"Reproducing churches"** — his preferred descriptor for Level 4–5 churches; the noun phrase that distinguishes his vision from mere "growing churches"
- **"My fruit grows on other people's trees"** — his most quoted personal axiom on hero-making leadership (attributed to Bob Buford); captures the shift from personal platform to others' flourishing
- **"I'm the platform; I'm not the show"** — companion axiom defining the leader's role in a multiplying culture
- **"Kingdom over castle"** — his framing for the NewThing-Exponential merger decision; the principle that organizational interests must be subordinated to kingdom mission
- **"ICNU"** — "I see in you"; the verbal gesture of calling out potential in others before they see it in themselves
- **"The 16% Mission"** — his organizing metric for Exponential: reaching the tipping point where 16% of US churches are reproducing/multiplying
- **"Kingdom scorecard" / "kingdom metrics"** — his alternative to attendance-and-budget scorecards; tracks disciples made and leaders released
- **"The drift trio"** — the world, the flesh, and the devil; three forces that erode leader health incrementally
- **"As a leader, you reproduce who you are"** — the ontological foundation of his Multiplier thesis

Favorite Frameworks

Ferguson almost always structures his content around numbered frameworks. The pattern appears in virtually every book:

- 5 practices of hero makers (Hero Maker)
- 5 steps of the apprenticeship model
- 5 BLESS practices
- 5 awakenings to God (Finding Your Way Back to God)
- 5 levels of church multiplication
- 4 RPMS gauges (Multiplier)
- 6 permission-giving levels
- 4 stages of apostolic movement (with Hirsch, On the Verge)

This is not arbitrary numerology — the numbered framework is his primary teaching vehicle. It reflects his conviction that practices need to be simple enough to remember and reproducible enough to hand off. The framework becomes a curriculum that others can teach.

Acronyms and Mnemonics

Ferguson favors memorable acronyms and letter-codes:

- **BLESS** — Begin, Listen, Eat, Serve, Share (the five missional neighboring practices)
- **ICNU** — I see in you (the permission-giving conversation)
- **RPMS** — Relational, Physical, Mental, Spiritual (the leader health gauges)

Each acronym is designed for practical deployment by people with no specialized theological training. This is a signature characteristic: the frameworks should work for a church volunteer, not just a seminary graduate.

Argument Structure

Ferguson's typical communication pattern:

1. **Cultural diagnosis** — name the dominant (and problematic) assumption or default behavior ("most leaders try to be the hero"; "churches measure attendance and budget"; "we don't multiply at every level")
2. **Inversion / counter-frame** — introduce his reframe with a crisp, memorable phrase ("be a hero maker, not a hero"; "measure your kingdom scorecard")
3. **Biblical grounding** — anchor the reframe in Scripture or in Jesus's ministry pattern (Jesus spent 73% of his time with the Twelve; Genesis 12 blessing language; Luke 2:52 wholeness)
4. **Named framework** — give the reframe a numbered structure (five practices, five steps, four gauges) that makes it teachable and reproducible
5. **Story** — illustrate with a specific person, relationship, or church story (Sam Stephens's movement; Michael Kinne's baptism; Ted Coniaris's succession)
6. **Practical invitation** — close with an accessible first step or question ("Who are you currently apprenticing?" "Who needs an ICNU conversation from you?")

This structure differs from Woodward's diagnostic-constructive pattern in that Ferguson lands on invitation rather than framework completion. The call to action is more motivational, less analytical.

Opening Style

Ferguson tends to open with a question that reframes how the listener understands their current situation:

- "Are you trying to be the hero, or are you trying to make heroes out of others?"
- "How can I grow my church?" versus "How can we multiply God's kingdom?"
- "If you don't have a dream that's bigger than you, you need to get a bigger dream."

He begins in the tension between the existing paradigm and the multiplication paradigm, then moves toward resolution.

Identity Inversion

Ferguson's most consistent rhetorical strategy is identity inversion: the good leader is not the one who builds the biggest platform but the one who makes others great. This inversion applies across every level — the hero-making pastor, the permission-giving ICNU conversation, the apprenticeship that releases a leader to independence, the church that plants daughter churches, the organization that merges into a larger kingdom mission ("Kingdom over Castle"). The inversion is always from accumulation to release, from heroism to hero-making, from self-amplification to others-multiplication.

Sample Passages (Verbatim from Fetched Sources)

"My fruit grows on other people's trees." — [workplaces.org transcript](#)

"I'm the platform; I'm not the show." — [workplaces.org transcript](#)

"As a leader, you reproduce who you are." — [workplaces.org transcript](#)

"Leaders are culture creators, and if you like the culture that's around you, chances are you helped create it." — [workplaces.org transcript](#)

"If you don't have a dream that's bigger than you, you need to get a bigger dream." — [churchleadership.com](#)

"If you don't have a dream that makes you dependent on God, you need to get a bigger dream." — [churchleadership.com](#)

"Jesus spent 73 percent of his time in small group... apprenticeship context." — [churchleadership.com](#)

"Leadership development [is] another expression of discipleship." — [churchleadership.com](#)

"The one thing every hero maker possesses that everyone around him or her needs is permission." — [exponential.org/hero-maker-2-permission-giver](#)

"If the people around you cannot get a yes, they will never discover the dream God has for their lives." — [exponential.org/hero-maker-2-permission-giver](#)

"I see in you what you don't see in yourselves." — [exponential.org/hero-maker-2-permission-giver](#)

"Am I trying to be the hero, or am I trying to make heroes out of others?" — Hero Maker (2018), via [goodreads.com](#)

"Multiplication church planting leads to movement and movement is how we accomplish the mission of Jesus." — [churchleaders.com](#)

"It's a travesty when we keep [Christianity] to ourselves and we don't multiply at every level." — [churchleaders.com](#)

"Church growth is good but its only good if it leads to multiplication, which is best." — churchleaders.com

"We need to multiply at every level. We multiply leaders, we multiply groups, we multiply teens, we multiply locations and sites and also we multiply networks of church plants." — churchleaders.com

"There's a shift in the church where young leaders are thinking in terms of serial multiplication." — churchleaders.com

"If we will, as leaders and Christ followers, die to ourselves, we actually experience more life." — churchleaders.com

"You can tell what a culture values by what gets spontaneous applause." — churchleaders.com (Ferguson cites this from Kim Hammond)

"It's God's job to judge people. It's the Holy Spirit's job to convict people. It's your job to love your neighbor." — churchleaders.com

"In order to get to level 4 or 5, you have to reproduce micro before macro. Make disciples inside the church before you can recruit disciples outside of the church." — redletterchallenge.com

"You reproduce who you are and what you do." — Multiplier (2026), via jeffmclain.com

"You can't multiply something that's not first alive in you." — Multiplier (2026), via patheos.com

"With more external influence comes greater personal responsibility." — Multiplier (2026), via patheos.com

Speaking vs. Writing

Based on podcast appearances (workplaces.org, churchleaders.com, churchleadership.com, redletterchallenge.com):

- **More story-forward:** In conversation, Ferguson moves quickly to specific names and moments. He will mention a specific church planter he met, a specific ICNU conversation, a specific breakfast relationship. The narrative concreteness is even more pronounced in spoken than written form.
- **Same framework architecture:** Whether speaking or writing, the numbered frameworks (five practices, four gauges, five levels) appear reliably. He cannot help but organize: the structure is instinctive, not merely stylistic.
- **Warm and collaborative:** Ferguson is a natural conversationalist. He builds on interviewers' questions, acknowledges counterarguments ("For some folks listening, they're going..."), and invites the listener into the discovery rather than lecturing. Podcast interviewers consistently describe him as engaging and personable.

- **Optimism is the dominant emotional note:** Unlike leaders who build tension before offering resolution, Ferguson tends to begin in possibility. His spoken voice signals that multiplication is already happening and the listener can join it.
- **Self-awareness about personal wiring:** He has described himself as "high on the apostolic gifting" and notes that he gets "an adrenaline rush with change or disruption" and that "excitement for innovation is just how God wired me." This self-knowledge is offered with good humor, not ego.
- **Marathon metaphor:** Ferguson runs marathons, and the long-game framing surfaces in his spoken teaching. "Multiplication isn't about burning out in a flurry of activity. It's about leading in a way that is sustainable, healthy, and lasts for the next 10, 20, or even 50 years." (Multiplier, 2026) The athletic discipline shapes his communication about the long arc of ministry.

Comparison with Alan Hirsch (Co-Author Counterpart)

Dimension	Dave Ferguson	Alan Hirsch
Rhetorical mode	Motivational-invitational	Prophetic-apostolic
Primary register	Practitioner-popular	Missiological-prophetic
Opening move	Inversion/counter-frame ("Are you a hero or hero maker?")	Provocative declaration ("The church has lost its apostolic DNA")
Storytelling	High — personal relationships, named individuals, local church narratives	High — historical movements, cross-cultural, grand narrative
Framework density	Very high (5 practices, 5 steps, 5 levels, 4 gauges, 5 awakenings, 6 permission levels, etc.)	High (6 mDNA elements, APEST, organic systems)
Tone	Optimistic, invitational, accessible	Urgent, prophetic, sometimes confrontational
Urgency	Moderate — multiplication is the mission; let's do this	High — the church must change or die
Intellectual depth	Practitioner depth (not academic depth)	Academic-practitioner (missiological scholarship)
Signature language	"Hero maker," "ICNU," "BLESS," "kingdom scorecard," "multiplication thinking"	"Apostolic Genius," "mDNA," "Forgotten Ways," "APEST," "missional-incarnational"
Self-identity	"I'm high on the apostolic gifting"; church planter; multiplication catalyst	"Apostolic movement catalyst"; missiologist; prophetic voice

Both Ferguson and Hirsch share the same fundamental apostolic vision — reproducing, movement-oriented churches that embody the mission of Jesus rather than managing an institution. Their collaboration in *On the Verge* (2011) was productive because they occupy distinct rhetorical roles: Hirsch supplies the prophetic-missiological framework, Ferguson supplies the practical-motivational deployment. Ferguson applies Hirsch's mDNA language to the pragmatics of running a multi-site church and a church-planting network.

Patterns Specific to Dave Ferguson (Not Shared with Hirsch)

1. **Personal vulnerability about drift and failure:** Multiplier and his Global Leadership Network article on RPMS represent a more self-disclosing register than his earlier books. He acknowledges the reality of leadership failure and drift in ways that feel personally informed.
 2. **The succession story as culminating illustration:** Ferguson used his own transition from Lead Pastor to Co-Founding Pastor — and Ted Coniaris's 18-month apprenticeship — as a live demonstration of the hero-making framework. This willingness to embody his theology publicly (and to let go of the platform) is one of his most credibility-building moves.
 3. **Movement through everyday people, not just specialized leaders:** BLESS and Finding Your Way Back to God both target ordinary Christians, not just pastors. This democratizing impulse distinguishes Ferguson from movement leaders who primarily address professional clergy.
 4. **The organizational merger as theology-in-action:** The NewThing-Exponential merger (2025), framed as "Kingdom over Castle," is an unusual instance of a movement leader's institutional decisions themselves functioning as theological witness. Ferguson is willing to dissolve what he built for the sake of what he believes.
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docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/content/books.md

Dave Ferguson — Complete Bibliography

Catalog Date: 2026-05-27

Status: Verified from multiple sources (Amazon, Audible, Goodreads, publisher pages, Exponential.org, Christianbook.com, PenguinRandomHouse.com, Regnery/Salem, WaterBrook Multnomah)

Authored / Co-Authored Books (Full Trade Editions)

1. The Big Idea: Focus the Message, Multiply the Impact

Field	Detail
Full Title	The Big Idea: Focus the Message, Multiply the Impact
Subtitle (alternate edition)	Aligning the Ministries of Your Church through Creative Collaboration
Series	Leadership Network Innovation Series
Authors	Dave Ferguson, Jon Ferguson, Eric Bramlett
Publisher	Zondervan
Publication Date	February 1, 2007
Pages	208
Format — Print	Paperback (ISBN-13: 978-0310272410 / ISBN-10: 0310272416)
Format — eBook	Kindle available (ISBN-13: 978-0310313953)
Format — Audiobook	Yes — Audible/Zondervan; Narrator: Walter Dixon; Length: 4 hrs 59 mins; Released January 11, 2010
Amazon URL	https://www.amazon.com/Big-Idea-Ministries-Collaboration-Leadership/dp/0310272416
Goodreads URL	https://www.goodreads.com/en/book/show/216426
Goodreads Rating	3.66 / 5 (173 ratings)

Description: Argues that when a church organizes its entire ministry around a single theme or "big idea" for each week — every sermon, children's message, small group study, and bulletin item — it generates a multiplied impact in the lives of congregants. Dave and Jon Ferguson draw from the practices at Community Christian Church in Naperville to show how

creative collaboration among ministry leaders creates unified messaging that sticks. A practical guide for churches seeking to break from siloed programming and move toward coordinated ministry.

2. Exponential: How You and Your Friends Can Start a Missional Church Movement

Field	Detail
Full Title	Exponential: How You and Your Friends Can Start a Missional Church Movement
Series	Exponential Series
Authors	Dave Ferguson, Jon Ferguson
Publisher	Zondervan
Publication Date	April 17, 2010
Pages	213 (print); 192 pages reported on some editions
Format — Print	Paperback (ISBN-13: 978-0310326786 / ISBN-10: 0310326788)
Format — eBook	Kindle available (ISBN-13: 978-0310586395)
Format — Audiobook	Yes — Audible/Zondervan; Narrator: Patrick Lawlor; Length: 7 hrs 40 mins; Released May 4, 2010
Amazon URL	https://www.amazon.com/Exponential-Friends-Missional-Church-Movement/dp/0310326788
Goodreads URL	https://www.goodreads.com/book/show/8844724-exponential
Goodreads Rating	4.01 / 5 (442 ratings, 39 reviews)

Description: The anchor book in the Exponential Series. Dave and Jon Ferguson argue that the Great Commission calls every follower of Jesus to reproduce their faith — not merely to add converts but to multiply them. Drawing on their experience leading Community Christian Church and the NewThing church-planting movement, they present a compelling case for "exponential" church growth: discipleship that multiplies at every level, from individual to church to network. Practical, accessible, and movement-oriented. One of Ferguson's most widely read works.

3. On the Verge: A Journey Into the Apostolic Future of the Church

Field	Detail
Full Title	On the Verge: A Journey Into the Apostolic Future of the Church
Series	Exponential Series
Authors	Alan Hirsch, Dave Ferguson
Publisher	Zondervan
Publication Date	May 3, 2011
Pages	348
Format — Print	Paperback (ISBN-13: 978-0310331001 / ISBN-10: 0310331005)
Format — eBook	Available
Format — Audiobook	Yes — Audible/Scribd; Narrator: Tom Parks; Length: 10 hrs 57 mins
Amazon URL	https://www.amazon.com/Verge-Journey-Apostolic-Future-Exponential/dp/0310331005
Goodreads URL	https://www.goodreads.com/book/show/27991490-on-the-verge
Goodreads Rating	3.98 / 5 (177 ratings, 15 reviews)

Description: A substantial collaborative work from two of the most prominent voices in the church multiplication movement. Hirsch brings his apostolic imagination framework (drawn from *The Forgotten Ways*) while Ferguson grounds it in the practical experience of NewThing and Community Christian Church. The book argues the Western church stands on the verge of a massive, category-shifting transformation — and that churches must embrace an apostolic, reproducing movement posture where every person is living a mission-sent life. Covers APEST leadership, missional DNA, and the structural changes required for genuine multiplication.

4. Discover Your Mission Now: Five Simple Practices to Change Your World

Field	Detail
Full Title	Discover Your Mission Now! Five Simple Practices to Change Your World
Authors	Dave Ferguson, Jon Ferguson, Tim Sutherland
Editor	Eric Bramlett
Publisher	Missio Publishing (originally distributed free via Exponential; also available via Amazon)
Publication Date	January 1, 2012
Pages	UNKNOWN — needs verification
Format — Print	Trade Paperback (ISBN-13: 978-0983086482 / ISBN-10: 0983086486)
Format — eBook	Available free via Exponential (exponential.org/resource-ebooks/discover-your-mission-now/)
Format — Audiobook	Not confirmed
Amazon URL	https://www.amazon.com/Discover-Your-Mission-Dave-Ferguson/dp/0983086486
Goodreads URL	https://www.goodreads.com/en/book/show/17565727
Goodreads Rating	4.04 / 5 (26 ratings)

Description: Presents five missional practices drawn from Jesus' ministry — originally developed for use at Community Christian Church and NewThing network churches. Guides readers to a "crystal clear understanding of the Jesus mission and your part in it," with each practice described as "simple to understand, but challenging to live out daily." Functions as an accessible on-ramp to missional living. Heavily used as a free resource for church planting networks.

5. Keeping Score: How to Know If Your Church Is Winning

Field	Detail
Full Title	Keeping Score: How to Know If Your Church Is Winning
Author	Dave Ferguson
Publisher	Exponential (published as part of the "Seek + Save" free eBook series)
Publication Date	January 1, 2014
Pages	UNKNOWN (short eBook / booklet format)
Format — Print	Print-on-demand / eBook only
Format — eBook	Free download via Exponential (exponential.org/resource-ebooks/keeping-score/)
Format — Audiobook	Not confirmed
Goodreads URL	https://www.goodreads.com/book/show/20498561-keeping-score
Goodreads Rating	3.89 / 5 (9 ratings, 4 reviews)

Description: The debut title in Exponential's 2014 "Seek + Save" free eBook series. Ferguson argues that most churches measure the wrong metrics — attendance, giving, and building size — and proposes a theologically grounded alternative scorecard built around three metrics and three diagnostic questions. Covers the difference between a scoreboard and a scorecard, and provides practical help for measuring discipleship, mission, and movement making. Widely circulated as a free resource for church leaders.

6. Finding Your Way Back to God: Five Awakenings to Your New Life

Field	Detail
Full Title	Finding Your Way Back to God: Five Awakenings to Your New Life
Authors	Dave Ferguson, Jon Ferguson
Publisher	WaterBrook (an imprint of Random House / Penguin Random House)
Publication Date	February 24, 2015 (eBook/hardcover); paperback April 2016
Pages	224
Format — Print	Hardcover (ISBN-13: 978-1601426093 / ISBN-10: 1601426097); Paperback also available
Format — eBook	Kindle (ISBN-13: 978-1601426109)
Format — Audiobook	Yes — Audible/WaterBrook; Narrator: Mike Chamberlain; Length: 5 hrs 14 mins; Released March 11, 2015
Amazon URL	https://www.amazon.com/Finding-Your-Way-Back-God/dp/1601426097
Publisher URL	https://waterbrookmultnomah.com/books/235828/finding-your-way-back-to-god-by-dave-ferguson-and-jon-ferguson/
Goodreads URL	https://www.goodreads.com/book/show/23209999-finding-your-way-back-to-god
Goodreads Rating	4.05 / 5 (172 ratings, 23 reviews)

Description: The Ferguson brothers' outreach-focused book, designed both for seekers and for Christians to share with friends who are spiritually searching. Builds on the Parable of the Prodigal Son and maps five "awakenings" in the journey back to God: (1) I wish things were different; (2) There's got to be something more; (3) I can't do this on my own; (4) God, you're real; (5) I belong here. Written for broad accessibility and used by many churches as a seeker series companion.

7. Starting Over: Your Life Beyond Regrets

Field	Detail
Full Title	Starting Over: Your Life Beyond Regrets
Authors	Dave Ferguson, Jon Ferguson
Publisher	WaterBrook / Multnomah (an imprint of Penguin Random House)
Publication Date	2016 (hardcover first edition)
Pages	208
Format — Print	Hardcover (ISBN-13: 978-1601426116 / ISBN-10: 1601426119); Paperback (ISBN-13: 978-1601426123)
Format — eBook	Kindle available (ISBN-13: 978-1601426130)
Format — Audiobook	Not confirmed on Audible
Amazon URL	https://www.amazon.com/Starting-Over-Your-Beyond-Regrets/dp/1601426119
Publisher URL	https://www.penguinrandomhouse.com/books/235829/starting-over-by-dave-ferguson-and-jon-ferguson/9781601426123
Goodreads URL	https://www.goodreads.com/en/book/show/29885430-starting-over
Goodreads Rating	3.74 / 5 (34 ratings)

Description: Draws on both scientific research and biblical truths to help readers move past regret in five key life areas: relationships, health, purpose, finances, and spirituality. The Ferguson brothers argue that regrets are not dead ends but invitations to renewal — and offer practical tools for getting unstuck when regret threatens to trap people again. Designed as a companion for individual reading and group study (with a corresponding Participant's Guide).

8. Hero Maker: Five Essential Practices for Leaders to Multiply Leaders

Field	Detail
Full Title	Hero Maker: Five Essential Practices for Leaders to Multiply Leaders
Series	Exponential Series
Authors	Dave Ferguson, Warren Bird
Foreword	J.D. Greear
Publisher	Zondervan
Publication Date	March 13, 2018
Pages	272
Format — Print	Hardcover (ISBN-13: 978-0310536932 / ISBN-10: 0310536936); Paperback (ISBN-13: 978-0310588931)
Format — eBook	Kindle available
Format — Audiobook	Yes — Audible/Zondervan; Narrators: Mark Smeby, John Behrens, Gabe Wicks; Length: 6 hrs 17 mins; Released August 14, 2018
Amazon URL	https://www.amazon.com/Hero-Maker-Essential-Practices-Exponential/dp/0310536936
Goodreads URL	https://www.goodreads.com/en/book/show/35553381-hero-maker
Goodreads Rating	4.02 / 5 (737 ratings, 64 reviews)
Companion Website	https://heromakerbook.org/

Description: Ferguson's most commercially successful book. A "hero maker" is defined as a leader who shifts from being the hero to making others the hero in God's unfolding story. The book argues that this shift — from addition to multiplication — is the critical barrier to church growth beyond Level 2 on Exponential's five-level scale. Five essential practices: (1) Multiplication Thinking; (2) Permission Giving; (3) Disciple-Multiplying; (4) Gift Activating; (5) Kingdom Building. Co-written with Warren Bird (longtime Leadership Network researcher). Foreword by J.D. Greear. Anchored Exponential's 2018 conference theme.

9. BLESS: 5 Everyday Ways to Love Your Neighbor and Change the World

Field	Detail
Full Title	BLESS: 5 Everyday Ways to Love Your Neighbor and Change the World
Authors	Dave Ferguson, Jon Ferguson
Publisher	Salem Books (an imprint of Regnery Publishing)
Publication Date	January 5, 2021
Pages	208
Format — Print	Paperback (ISBN-13: 978-1684510887 / ISBN-10: 1684510880)
Format — eBook	Available (ISBN-13: 978-1684511044)
Format — Audiobook	Yes — Audible/Salem; Narrator: William Sarris; Length: 4 hrs 54 mins; Released March 9, 2021
Amazon URL	https://www.amazon.com/BLESS-Everyday-Neighbor-Change-World/dp/1684510880
Publisher URL	https://www.regnery.com/9781684510887/bless/
Goodreads URL	https://www.goodreads.com/book/show/49680194-bless
Goodreads Rating	4.20 / 5 (500 ratings, 59 reviews)

Description: The Ferguson brothers present five everyday practices for sharing faith organically with neighbors, co-workers, and friends. BLESS stands for: Begin with prayer, Listen, Eat, Serve, and tell your Story. The framework is designed to be natural rather than awkward — an alternative to programmatic evangelism. Widely adopted as a small-group study and outreach strategy tool in churches affiliated with Community Christian Church and Exponential. One of Dave Ferguson's highest-rated books on Goodreads.

10. Multiplier: How Healthy Leaders Create Lasting Impact

Field	Detail
Full Title	Multiplier: How Healthy Leaders Create Lasting Impact
Series	Exponential Series
Author	Dave Ferguson
Publisher	Zondervan
Publication Date	March 17, 2026
Pages	320
Format — Print	Hardcover (ISBN-13: 978-0310176701 / ISBN-10: 0310176700)
Format — eBook	Kindle available (ISBN-13: 978-0310176718)
Format — Audiobook	Yes — Audible/Zondervan; Narrator: Dave Ferguson; Length: 9 hrs 19 mins; Released March 17, 2026
Amazon URL	https://www.amazon.com/Multiplier-Healthy-Leaders-Lasting-Exponential/dp/0310176700
Goodreads Rating	UNKNOWN — too recently published; needs research

Description: Ferguson's newest solo-authored book, released in March 2026. Examines four gauges of leader health — spiritual, relational, physical, and mental — and argues that only leaders who are genuinely healthy are worth multiplying. Calls readers to "commit to becoming people who are worth multiplying" through a three-part journey: discovering what they are currently reproducing, hearing from God regarding what he has entrusted them to reproduce, and setting guardrails to stay faithful. Builds on and extends the Hero Maker framework with a personal formation emphasis.

Shorter Works / Exponential eBooks and Workbooks

These are digital-first publications distributed primarily through Exponential.org. Most are free downloads.

Title	Authors	Publisher	Year	ISBN	Format	Notes
Keeping Score: How to Know If Your Church Is Winning	Dave Ferguson	Exponential	2014	UNKNOWN	Free eBook	See full entry above
Becoming a Level Five Multiplying Church	Todd Wilson, Dave Ferguson (with Ed Stetzer, Alan Hirsch)	Exponential	2016	978-1624240041	Paperback + eBook	Introduces the 5-level church multiplication framework; expanded version includes Hirsch chapter
The Legacy of a Hero Maker	Dave Ferguson, Todd Wilson	Exponential	June 18, 2019	978-1624240331	Paperback	Supplemental resource to Hero Maker; focuses on Bob Buford as a Hero Maker case study
Together: The Great Collaboration	Dave Ferguson, Patrick O'Connell	Exponential	January 2, 2020	978-1624240478	Paperback + free eBook	Argues that Jesus' John 17 prayer points to a "Great Collaboration" alongside the Great Commandment and Great Commission; draws on stories of reproducing church networks
Together With Networks	Exponential (Ferguson, ed.)	Exponential	2020	UNKNOWN	Free eBook	Companion resource to Together
Revitalizing Evangelism: Lost Cause Workbook 1	Dave Ferguson, Rick Richardson	Exponential	2022	UNKNOWN	Free PDF Workbook	Part 1 of 5-part Lost Cause workbook series; interactive PDF
Multiplying Evangelism for a Movement: Lost Cause Workbook 5	Dave Ferguson, Rick Richardson	Exponential	2023	UNKNOWN	Free PDF Workbook	Part 5 of 5-part series; movement-scale evangelism strategies
Good, Great, Greater: Measuring	Dave Ferguson (gen. ed.),	Exponential	January 1, 2025	978-1624241260	Paperback + eBook (219 pp.)	Multi-contributor volume; moves beyond Becoming

Title	Authors	Publisher	Year	ISBN	Format	Notes
What Matters on the Journey to Level 5 Multiplication	Jason Stewart (gen. ed.)					Level Five; real stories and practical strategies for Level 5 multiplication

Forewords & Introductions Written by Dave Ferguson

Book	Author	Publisher	Year	ISBN	Notes
Pioneering Movements: Leadership That Multiplies Disciples and Churches	Steve Addison	InterVarsity Press (IVP)	2015	978-0830844418	Full foreword; confirmed on daveferguson.org/blog/foreword-for-pioneering-movements-by-steve-addison
Discipology: The Art and Science of Making Disciples	Peyton Jones	Zondervan (Exponential Series)	2026	978-0310180333	Written introduction; listed as credited contributor on Amazon product page

Companion/Study Materials for Trade Books

Title	Co-Author	Publisher	Year	ISBN	Notes
Finding Your Way Back to God Participant's Guide	Jon Ferguson	WaterBrook	2015	978-1601426734	Group study companion
Can I Find My Way Back to God?	Jon Ferguson	WaterBrook	2015	978-1601427830	Short evangelistic booklet
Starting Over Participant's Guide	Jon Ferguson	WaterBrook/Multnomah	2016	UNKNOWN — needs research	Group study companion

Goodreads Author Summary

Metric	Value
Profile URL	https://www.goodreads.com/author/show/126850.Dave_Ferguson
Distinct Works Listed	96 (many are editions/translations)
Average Rating (all works)	4.06 / 5
Total Ratings (major titles)	~2,300+ across confirmed titles
Most-Rated Book	Hero Maker (737 ratings)
Highest-Rated Book	BLESS (4.20 / 5)

Amazon Author Page

- **URL:** <https://www.amazon.com/Dave-Ferguson/e/B001JSE63Y>
- **Audible Author Page:** <https://www.audible.com/author/Dave-Ferguson/B001JSE63Y>

Sources

- Amazon product pages (multiple titles)
- Audible author and title pages ([audible.com/author/Dave-Ferguson/B001JSE63Y](https://www.audible.com/author/Dave-Ferguson/B001JSE63Y))
- Goodreads author and book pages
- Zondervan publisher pages
- WaterBrook / Penguin Random House ([penguinrandomhouse.com](https://www.penguinrandomhouse.com), [waterbrookmultnomah.com](https://www.waterbrookmultnomah.com))
- Salem Books / Regnery ([regnery.com](https://www.regnery.com))
- Exponential.org resource and product pages
- [Christianbook.com](https://www.christianbook.com)
- AbeBooks (for ISBN verification)
- daveferguson.org/books
- heromakerbook.org
- Research conducted 2026-05-27

Frameworks

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/content/frameworks.md

Dave Ferguson — Signature Frameworks

Catalog Date: 2026-06-02

Status: Grounded in Ferguson's published books and primary teaching sources (see [profile/theology.md](#), [content/books.md](#), and the linked URLs).

Each framework below is drawn from Dave Ferguson's own books and teaching. The one-sentence prose summary under each table is the dossier card body.

Five Practices of a Hero Maker

Field	Value
Introduced	2018 (Hero Maker: Five Essential Practices for Leaders to Multiply Leaders, Zondervan, with Warren Bird)
Components	Multiplication Thinking; Permission Giving; Disciple Multiplying; Gift Activating; Kingdom Building
Source	heromakerbook.org

A hero maker is a leader who stops trying to be the hero and instead makes heroes of others, multiplying leaders through five practices — multiplication thinking, permission giving, disciple multiplying, gift activating, and kingdom building.

BLESS — Five Everyday Missional Practices

Field	Value
Introduced	2020 (B.L.E.S.S.: 5 Everyday Ways to Love Your Neighbor and Change the World, Salem/Regnery, with Jon Ferguson)
Components	Begin with prayer; Listen; Eat; Serve; Share your story
Source	bless-book.org

BLESS distills everyday incarnational neighboring into five repeatable practices — begin with prayer, listen, eat, serve, and share your story — so that mission belongs to every ordinary Christian rather than to a program.

ICNU — "I See in You" (Permission Giving)

Field	Value
Introduced	2018 (Hero Maker, practice two — Permission Giving)
Components	Naming latent leadership in another; the ICNU conversation; calibrated release across six permission-giving levels
Source	exponential.org/hero-maker-2-permission-giver

ICNU is the practice of seeing and naming the leadership potential in someone before they see it in themselves — the "I see in you" conversation that releases people into ministry and forms the engine of permission giving.

Five-Step Apprenticeship Model

Field	Value
Introduced	2010 (Exponential, Zondervan, with Jon Ferguson); developed further in Hero Maker (2018)
Components	I do, you watch, we talk → I do, you help, we talk → You do, I help, we talk → You do, I watch, we talk → You do, someone else watches
Source	unseminary.com — CCC leadership succession

The five-step apprenticeship model makes disciples who make disciples by moving an apprentice through progressive stages — from watching to being watched — until they can reproduce the practice in someone else.

Five-Level Multiplying Church Typology

Field	Value
Introduced	2016 (Becoming a Level Five Multiplying Church, Exponential, with Todd Wilson and Alan Hirsch)
Components	Level 1 Declining; Level 2 Plateaued; Level 3 Growing; Level 4 Reproducing; Level 5 Multiplying
Source	theunstuckgroup.com — Level Five interview

Ferguson's five-level typology diagnoses where a church sits on the spectrum from declining to multiplying, arguing that most churches plateau at "growing" (Level 3) and that genuine movement requires reproducing and multiplying churches (Levels 4–5).

The Great Collaboration (the "Three Greats")

Field	Value
Introduced	2020 (Together: The Great Collaboration, Exponential, with Patrick O'Connell)
Components	Great Commission (Go); Great Commandment (Love); Great Collaboration (Together)
Source	exponential.org/bettertogether

The Great Collaboration holds that Jesus' John 17 prayer adds a third "great" alongside the Commission and the Commandment — that reproducing churches advance the kingdom together as networked relationships, not as isolated congregations.

Five Awakenings (Finding Your Way Back to God)

Field	Value
Introduced	2015 (Finding Your Way Back to God: Five Awakenings to Your New Life, WaterBrook, with Jon Ferguson)
Components	Awakening to Longing; to Regret; to Help; to Love; to Life
Source	waterbrookmultnomah.com — Finding Your Way Back to God

The Five Awakenings map the spiritual journey of the returning person through the lens of the Prodigal Son — longing, regret, help, love, and life — giving churches a shared language for evangelism and re-engagement.

RPMS — Four Leader-Health Gauges

Field	Value
Introduced	2026 (Multiplier: How Healthy Leaders Create Lasting Impact, Zondervan)
Components	Relational; Physical; Mental; Spiritual (daily self-assessment, drawn from Luke 2:52)
Source	globalleadership.org — combat drift

RPMS gives leaders four daily gauges — relational, physical, mental, and spiritual — to monitor their own health and resist drift, on the conviction that you reproduce who you are, so only healthy leaders are worth multiplying.

Articles & Blog Posts

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/content/articles.md

Dave Ferguson — Published Articles, Blog Posts & Online Writing

Catalog Date: 2026-05-27

Status: Verified from web searches; dates approximated where not visible in source. Ferguson is a prolific practitioner-writer; this catalog represents confirmed titles with URLs, not an exhaustive archive.

Summary

Dave Ferguson does not maintain a high-volume personal blog on the model of a full-time blogger. His written output is distributed across three channels: (1) his personal site daveferguson.org (light blog), (2) Exponential.org (where he posts as a leader and contributor), and (3) third-party publications including Outreach Magazine, Lewis Center for Church Leadership, Christianity Today, and Global Leadership Network. He also maintains a newer Substack newsletter (launched early 2026). Total confirmed articles across all platforms: 30-50+.

Personal Website: daveferguson.org/blog

URL: <https://daveferguson.org/>

Structure: Personal site with Blog section; simple layout promoting books, newsletter, and contact

Confirmed Blog Posts (representative sample — full archive not paginated in search results)

Title	Date (approx.)	Topic	URL
"A Simple Solution to Find More Church Planters"	UNKNOWN	Church planting pipeline / leadership recruitment	daveferguson.org (no direct URL confirmed)
"Europe: A Trip to the Future of the American Church"	UNKNOWN	Post-Christian trends; Ferguson's observations from six European countries	daveferguson.org (no direct URL confirmed)
"Looking Back..."	c. 2021	One-year retrospective on COVID-era transition to online ministry	daveferguson.org (no direct URL confirmed)
"My Prepared Notes for the Carey Nieuwhof Leadership Podcast"	UNKNOWN	Behind-the-scenes notes on CNLP appearance	https://daveferguson.org/blog/my-prepared-notes-for-the-carey-nieuwhof-leadership-podcast

Note: The daveferguson.org blog does not appear to use a paginated archive or tag-based browsing visible in search results. The total post count is uncertain. The site also promotes a free chapter download for BLESS and a Substack newsletter subscription.

Substack Newsletter

URL: <https://daveferguson3.substack.com>

Status: Launched approximately January 2026 (described as "4 months ago" in late April 2026)

Content: Not yet cataloged; posts not yet indexed in web searches at research date (2026-05-27)

Note: Dave Ferguson's personal Substack appears to be in early stages. Contrast with the more active Exponential newsletter/content pipeline.

Exponential.org — Articles and Blog Posts

Profile page: <https://exponential.org/person/dave-f/>

Role: Co-founder and President/CEO of Exponential

Dave Ferguson is one of the most frequent contributors to Exponential's content platform. Articles are tied closely to conference themes and book launches. The following are confirmed titles with dates from the Exponential author page.

Confirmed Articles (reverse chronological)

#	Title	Date	Topic	URL
1	Creating The Future Church: 4 Practices for Mobilizing Next-Gen Leaders	Aug 11, 2025	Next-generation leadership mobilization	https://exponential.org/creating-the-future-church-4-practices-for-mobilizing-next-gen-leaders/
2	Moving to Multiplication	Mar 7, 2024	Church multiplication movement	https://exponential.org/moving-to-multiplication/
3	The Narratives of Evangelism	Jan 8, 2023	Reframing evangelism stories	https://exponential.org/the-narratives-of-evangelism/
4	Is Evangelism a Lost Cause?	Nov 2, 2022	Lost Cause series — evangelism revitalization	https://exponential.org/is-evangelism-a-lost-cause/
5	Empowered Culture	Feb 14, 2022	Spirit-empowered church culture	https://exponential.org/empowered-culture/
6	Empowered Life	Feb 7, 2022	Spirit-empowered personal life	https://exponential.org/empowered-life/
7	Empowered Heart	Jan 31, 2022	Spirit-empowered inner life	https://exponential.org/empowered-heart/
8	Empowered: Wait and Then Move	Jan 14, 2022	Spirit-led action; waiting on God	https://exponential.org/empowered-wait-and-then-move/
9	Is Your Church Winning at Multiplication?	Oct 19, 2016	Church multiplication scorecard	https://exponential.org/multiplying-churches/
10	The '5 Awakenings' To Help People Find Their Way Back To God	Mar 2, 2015	Five awakenings framework; Finding Your Way Back to God	https://exponential.org/the-5-awakenings-to-help-people-find-their-way-back-to-god/

Hero Maker Launch Articles (Late 2017 — Early 2018)

This cluster of articles accompanied the Hero Maker book launch and Exponential's 2018 conference campaign:

#	Title	Date	URL
11	Hero Maker Introduction	May 10, 2018	https://exponential.org/hero-maker-introduction/
12	The Multiplication Conversation Continues	Apr 5, 2018	https://exponential.org/core-multiplication-message/
13	Hero Maker: Five Essential Practices for Leaders to Multiply Leaders (webinar replay)	Jan 24, 2018	https://exponential.org/hero-maker-five-essential-practices-leaders-multiply-leaders-church-god-webinar-replay/
14	5 Practices of Hero Making	Nov 9, 2017	https://exponential.org/5-practices-hero-making/
15	Hero Maker Practice 5: Are You Asking the Right Kingdom-Building Question?	Nov 7, 2017	https://exponential.org/hero-making-5-kingdom-builder/
16	Hero Maker Practice 3: Are You Making Disciples or Disciple Multipliers?	Nov 7, 2017	https://exponential.org/hero-maker-3-disciple-multiplier/
17	Hero Maker Practice 2: Are You Leading With a Bias to 'Yes'?	Nov 7, 2017	https://exponential.org/hero-maker-2-permission-giver/
18	Hero Maker Practice 1: Are You Thinking Beyond What You Can Do Alone?	Nov 7, 2017	https://exponential.org/hero-maker-1-multiplication-thinking/

Note: Additional webinar-replay posts exist from the Hero Maker launch (Dec 2017–Mar 2018); see exponential.org/person/dave-f/ for full list.

Lewis Center for Church Leadership (churchleadership.com)

Author page: <https://www.churchleadership.com/author/dave-ferguson/>

#	Title	Date	Co-Author	Topic	URL
1	Commissioning: A Simple Tool for Activating People's Gifts	Aug 17, 2021	—	Activating congregants through the act of commissioning	https://www.churchleadership.com/leading-ideas/commissioning-a-simple-tool-for-activating-peoples-gifts/
2	5 Essential Practices of a Hero-Making Leader	Aug 25, 2020	Warren Bird	How effective leaders make other people heroes	https://www.churchleadership.com/leading-ideas/5-essential-practices-of-a-hero-making-leader/
3	4 Ways to Multiply Disciples the Way Jesus Did	Feb 19, 2020	Warren Bird	Jesus' discipleship methods applied to modern ministry	https://www.churchleadership.com/leading-ideas/4-ways-to-multiply-disciples-the-way-jesus-did/

Outreach Magazine (outreachmagazine.com)

Archive page: <https://outreachmagazine.com/dave-ferguson>

Role: Described as a regular contributor; Ferguson and Community Christian Church were named in Outreach 100 lists repeatedly.

#	Title	Date	Topic	URL
1	Unity of the Spirit	UNKNOWN	Church unity and collaboration	https://outreachmagazine.com/features/85302-dave-ferguson-unity-of-the-spirit.html
2	The Reproducible Life — Part 2	UNKNOWN	Reproducible life practices; church planting	https://outreachmagazine.com/interviews/57047-dave-ferguson-the-reproducible-life-part-2.html
3	Collaboration Is the Future — Part 1	UNKNOWN	Future of collaboration in church networks	https://outreachmagazine.com/interviews/57041-dave-ferguson-collaboration-is-the-future-part-1.html
4	Community Christian Church, Chicago (profile/interview)	UNKNOWN	Church profile	https://outreachmagazine.com/interviews/4366-dave-ferguson-community-christian-church-chicago.html
5	Coming Together as a Team for Kingdom Multiplication	UNKNOWN	Teamwork for church multiplication	https://outreachmagazine.com/features/church-planting/50745-teamwork-for-kingdom-multiplication.html
6	An Unprecedented Opportunity (interview)	UNKNOWN	COVID-era church opportunity	https://outreachmagazine.com/interviews/23902-dave-ferguson-2.html
7	Multiplying Leaders (interview)	UNKNOWN	Leadership multiplication; Hero Maker themes	https://outreachmagazine.com/interviews/84098-dave-ferguson-multiplying-leaders.html
8	Keeping Score: Measuring What Matters	c. 2024	Church scorecard; Multiplier-era themes	https://outreachmagazine.com/features/81954-keeping-score-measuring-what-matters.html

Note: Additional articles likely exist in Outreach's archive; full archive may require site login.

Global Leadership Network (globalleadership.org)

#	Title	Date	Topic	URL
1	7 Steps to Creating a Culture that Makes Heroes	UNKNOWN	Hero Maker culture-building framework	https://globalleadership.org/articles/leading-organizations/7-steps-to-creating-a-culture-that-makes-heroes-dave-ferguson/

Christianity Today (christianitytoday.com)

Author page: <https://www.christianitytoday.com/writers/dave-ferguson/> (page returned 404 at research date — may have been reorganized)

Status: Multiple sources confirm Dave Ferguson has contributed to Christianity Today, including articles about helping people find their way to God, expert panel responses, and leadership lessons. Specific titles and dates were not retrievable from available search results at time of research.

George P. Wood / PentecostalTheology.com

#	Title	Date	Topic	URL
1	Review of The Big Idea	Aug 17, 2007	Book review; The Big Idea concepts	https://georgepwood.com/2007/08/17/the-big-idea-by-dave-ferguson-et-al/

Key Thematic Clusters Across Articles

Primary Themes (appear in 5+ pieces)

1. **Church Multiplication / The Five Levels** — Exponential's framework for categorizing churches from addition to multiplication; appears throughout 2014–present
2. **Hero Making / Leadership Multiplication** — The shift from addition-thinking to multiplication-thinking in leadership development; peak 2017–2021
3. **Evangelism and Missional Outreach** — BLESS practices, "lost cause" evangelism revitalization, seeker-focused approaches; peak 2015 and 2022–2023

Secondary Themes (appear in 2–4 pieces)

1. **Spirit-Empowered Ministry** — Exponential 2022 conference theme; four articles in the "Empowered" series
 2. **Church Collaboration / Networks** — Together framework, network-based movement; 2020 emphasis
 3. **Church Planting Pipeline** — Recruiting, training, and deploying church planters; recurring across Outreach and Lewis Center pieces
-

Social Media Writing

Platform	Handle	Notes
Twitter / X	@daveferguson	Active; confirmed presence
Instagram	@fergusondave	Active; described as primary social platform
Facebook	PastorDaveFerguson	Active; confirmed on website
LinkedIn	linkedin.com/in/daveferguson/	Active professional presence; posts about NewThing, Exponential
Substack	https://daveferguson3.substack.com	Launched ~early 2026; content not yet archived in search results

Sources

- daveferguson.org (personal site and blog)
- exponential.org/person/dave-f/ (author page with full article list)
- churchleadership.com/author/dave-ferguson/
- outreachmagazine.com/dave-ferguson
- globalleadership.org (search results)
- christianitytoday.com/writers/dave-ferguson/ (URL retrieved but 404 at research date)
- daveferguson.org/blog/my-prepared-notes-for-the-carey-nieuwhof-leadership-podcast
- Research conducted 2026-05-27

Audio & Podcast

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/content/audio.md

Audio & Podcast Content: Dave Ferguson

Research Date: 2026-05-27

Confidence Level: Medium-High

Researcher: Movemental Research Team

Summary

Dave Ferguson **hosts/co-hosts one podcast**: the **Hero Maker Podcast** on Exponential.org, which he co-hosted with Exponential CEO Todd Wilson as part of the Hero Maker book launch campaign (2017–2018). In addition to this hosted series, he is a frequent **guest** on major church leadership podcasts — including multiple appearances on the Carey Nieuwhof Leadership Podcast. He also hosted or co-hosted a short run of episodes called the **Together Podcast** (2020) tied to the Together book. He has no dedicated personal audio podcast channel outside of Exponential's platforms.

- **Hosted/co-hosted podcast series**: 2 (Hero Maker Podcast; Together Podcast) — both on Exponential.org
 - **Total guest appearances found (confirmed)**: 15+ episodes across at least 12 shows
 - **Date range**: 2010 (earliest audiobook) to 2026 (ongoing)
 - **Peak guest activity**: 2018–2019 (Hero Maker launch) and 2020–2021 (BLESS launch)
-

Podcast Series — Hosted / Co-Hosted

1. Hero Maker Podcast (Exponential)

Field	Detail
Show Name	Hero Maker Podcast
Platform	Exponential.org
URL	https://exponential.org/podcast-hero-maker/
Hosts	Dave Ferguson (Exponential President) and Todd Wilson (Exponential CEO)
Period	November 2017 – early 2018 (tied to Hero Maker book launch and Exponential 2018 conference)
Format	Short interview episodes featuring guest speakers discussing the five Hero Maker practices
Status	No longer active (campaign series, not ongoing)

Confirmed Episodes:

#	Title	Date	Guest	Topic
1	From Hero to Hero Maker	Nov 13, 2017	(hosts only)	Overview of the five essential practices; why leadership is a barrier to church multiplication
2	Multiplication Thinking	UNKNOWN — needs research	Sam Stephens	Practice 1: Multiplication Thinking
3	Permission Giving	UNKNOWN — needs research	Derwin Gray	Practice 2: Permission Giving (bias to yes)

Note: Additional episodes covering Practices 3–5 likely exist on the same feed. Full episode list was not recoverable from search results. See <https://exponential.org/podcast-hero-maker/> for current archive.

2. Together Podcast (Exponential)

Field	Detail
Show Name	Together Podcast
Platform	Exponential.org
Host	Dave Ferguson (Exponential President)
Period	Early 2020 (tied to Exponential 2020 conference theme "Together")
Format	Short interview episodes with Exponential 2020 conference speakers
Status	No longer active (campaign series tied to Together book)

Confirmed Episodes:

#	Title	Date	Guest	Topic
2	Together Episode 2: Pete Scazzero Talks About Being Together with God	Early 2020	Pete Scazzero	Biblical sabbath; being together with God
3	Together Episode 3: Greg Surratt Talks About Together with Networks	Early 2020	Greg Surratt	Church planting networks; why network partnership matters
4	Together Episode 4: Michael Carrion Talks About Together as a Church	Early 2020	Michael Carrion	Unity and collaboration within a local church

Source URLs:

- <https://exponential.org/together-podcast-scazzero/>
- <https://exponential.org/together-podcast-surratt/>
- <https://exponential.org/together-podcast-carrion/>

Note: Episode 1 was not found in search results; the series opens with Episode 2 in available results. Dave Ferguson hosts all confirmed episodes.

Podcast Guest Appearances

Confirmed Episodes (reverse chronological)

#	Podcast	Episode Title	Date	Host(s)	Topic / Book	URL
1	The Stetzer ChurchLeaders Podcast	Dave Ferguson: The Key Steps to Building a Culture of Outreach	Oct 2, 2024	Ed Stetzer	Building outreach culture; Multiplier preview	https://churchleaders.com/podcast/497963-dave-ferguson-building-culture-outreach.html
2	Carey Nieuwhof Leadership Podcast (CNLP 805)	The Reason Your Church Isn't Multiplying and Fresh Trends in Church Planting	UNKNOWN 2024 (recorded backstage at Exponential Orlando)	Carey Nieuwhof	Why churches plateau; latest church planting trends	https://careynieuwhof.com/
3	Exponential Australia Church Leaders Podcast (Ep. 45)	HEROMAKERS — Dave Ferguson	UNKNOWN	UNKNOWN	Hero Maker concepts; leadership multiplication	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ZAyVGGcrC-I
4	FrontStage BackStage with Jason Daye (Ep. 14)	4 Habits for Healthy, Long-term Ministry — Dave Ferguson	UNKNOWN 2022	Jason Daye	Ministry sustainability; habits for finishing well	https://podcasts.apple.com/us/podcast/4-habits-for-healthy-long-term-ministry-dave-ferguson/id1620979919?i=1000570419987
5	Missio Alliance Podcast (S4E07)	Dave Ferguson — Entrepreneurial Leadership and Church Planting	Feb 24, 2020	Missio Alliance	NewThing movement; how anxiety blocks healthy leadership; Hero Maker	https://www.missioalliance.org/podcasts/s4e07-dave-ferguson/
6	The Carey Nieuwhof Leadership Podcast (CNLP 415)	Dave Ferguson on the Future of the Micro-Church, Red Light/Green Light/Yellow Light People, and the Future of Networking	UNKNOWN 2021	Carey Nieuwhof	Micro-church expressions; network leadership; multiplication	https://careynieuwhof.com/episode415/
7	Vineyard USA: We Are Vineyard	Dave Ferguson: Making Heroes of Other People — Our Fruit	UNKNOWN	Jay Pathak	Hero Making; dreaming big enough to need God; staying	https://vineyardusa.org/podcast/dave-ferguson-making-heroes-of-other-people-our-fruit-grows-on-other-peoples-trees/

#	Podcast	Episode Title	Date	Host(s)	Topic / Book	URL
		Grows on Other People's Trees			hungry in ministry	
8	GCM Podcast (Ep. 9)	Dave Ferguson on: Being a Hero Maker	UNKNOWN	GCM hosts	Hero Maker five practices; leadership multiplication movement	https://gcmpodcast.com/ep-9-dave-ferguson-on-being-a-hero-maker/
9	Flourishing Culture Leadership Podcast (S2 E20)	A Healthy Life Balance: Does It Matter? // Dave Ferguson, Community Christian Church	UNKNOWN	Best Christian Workplaces Institute	Healthy balance in ministry leadership; staff sustainability	https://bcwinstitute.libsyn.com/s2-e20-a-healthy-life-balance-does-it-matter-dave-ferguson-community-christian-church
10	Workplaces.org Podcast (Ep. 346)	How to Position Your Organization for Exponential Growth and Multiply Leaders	UNKNOWN	Workplaces.org hosts	Hero Maker culture; leadership development in organizations	https://workplaces.org/podcast/346-how-to-position-your-organization-for-exponential-growth-and-multiply-leaders
11	Stetzer Leadership Podcast	Dave Ferguson: How to Lead Ministry Innovation	Nov 19, 2020	Ed Stetzer (Wheaton)	Ministry innovation post-COVID; BLESS and missional living	https://podcasts.apple.com/cz/podcast/dave-ferguson-how-to-lead-ministry-innovation/id1504214624?i=1000499581104
12	Lewis Center for Church Leadership Podcast (Ep. 60)	How to Be a Hero Maker featuring Dave Ferguson	UNKNOWN	Lewis Center hosts	Five Hero Maker practices; leadership development	https://www.churchleadership.com/podcast/episode-60-how-to-be-a-hero-maker-featuring-dave-ferguson/
13	Follow Your Different Podcast (Ep. 177)	God: A Different Dialogue — Pastor Dave Ferguson	UNKNOWN	Christopher Lochhead	Hero Maker; church leadership; faith and God	https://lochhead.com/pastor-dave-ferguson/
14	The Carey Nieuwhof Leadership Podcast (CNLP 169)	Dave Ferguson on the Future of Church Growth and the Rapid Multiplication	UNKNOWN 2018	Carey Nieuwhof	Church growth; leader multiplication; NewThing	https://careynieuwhof.com/episode169/

#	Podcast	Episode Title	Date	Host(s)	Topic / Book	URL
		of Church Leaders and Churches				
15	The Post-Christian Podcast	Dave Ferguson (Community Christian Church and Exponential)	October 2020	Eric Bryant	Post-Christian culture; church in a secular world; COVID ministry	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=DAFnRvmUVnl
16	FDE Podcast (Ep. 364)	Church Planting Secrets Every Entrepreneur Needs — Dave Ferguson	UNKNOWN	FDE hosts	Church planting principles applicable to entrepreneurs	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=nqpbvB3juXw

Audiobooks (Ferguson as Subject/Narrator)

Dave Ferguson has multiple titles available as commercial audiobooks. He personally narrates Multiplier (2026). Earlier titles use professional narrators.

Title	Narrator	Length	Release Date	Platform
Multiplier: How Healthy Leaders Create Lasting Impact	Dave Ferguson (self-narrated)	9 hrs 19 mins	Mar 17, 2026	Audible, Amazon
Hero Maker: Five Essential Practices for Leaders to Multiply Leaders	Mark Smeby, John Behrens, Gabe Wicks	6 hrs 17 mins	Aug 14, 2018	Audible, Apple Books, Libro.fm
BLESS: 5 Everyday Ways to Love Your Neighbor and Change the World	William Sarris	4 hrs 54 mins	Mar 9, 2021	Audible
Exponential: How You and Your Friends Can Start a Missional Church Movement	Patrick Lawlor	7 hrs 40 mins	May 4, 2010	Audible
Finding Your Way Back to God: Five Awakenings to Your New Life	Mike Chamberlain	5 hrs 14 mins	Mar 11, 2015	Audible
The Big Idea: Focus the Message, Multiply the Impact	Walter Dixon	4 hrs 59 mins	Jan 11, 2010	Audible, Amazon
On the Verge: A Journey Into the Apostolic Future of the Church	Tom Parks	10 hrs 57 mins	UNKNOWN (c. 2011)	Audible, Scribd

Source: <https://www.audible.com/author/Dave-Ferguson/B001JSE63Y>
Note: Starting Over and Keeping Score audiobook status not confirmed.

Key Themes Across Podcast Appearances

Primary Themes (appear in 5+ episodes)

- 1. **Hero Making / Leadership Multiplication** — The core thesis of his 2018 book; discussed in most appearances from 2017–2022
- 2. **Church Multiplication / Five Levels** — Why churches plateau and how to move from addition to multiplication
- 3. **NewThing / Exponential movement** — Organizational context and movement philosophy

Secondary Themes (appear in 2–4 episodes)

- 1. **Missional living / BLESS practices** — Neighbor engagement; organic evangelism
- 2. **Ministry health / sustainability** — Habits for finishing well; life balance
- 3. **Church planting trends** — Micro-churches, meta-churches, post-COVID landscape

Podcast Appearance Timeline

Year	Appearances	Notes
2018	3+	Hero Maker launch; CNLP 169; Lewis Center Ep. 60; GCM Ep. 9
2019	UNKNOWN	Likely appearances — no confirmed episodes found for this year
2020	3	Missio Alliance S4E07; Stetzer Leadership Podcast; Post-Christian Podcast; BLESS launch era
2021	1+	CNLP 415 (micro-church); Vineyard USA
2022	1+	FrontStage BackStage Ep. 14
2024	2	Stetzer ChurchLeaders Podcast; CNLP 805

Carey Nieuwhof Appearances (Confirmed: 3 episodes)

Dave Ferguson has appeared on the Carey Nieuwhof Leadership Podcast at least three times — an unusual frequency that signals the podcast considers him a top-tier repeat guest:

Episode	Title	Year	URL
CNLP 169	Future of Church Growth and Rapid Multiplication of Church Leaders	2018	https://careynieuwhof.com/episode169/
CNLP 415	Future of the Micro-Church, Red/Green/Yellow Light People, Future of Networking	2021	https://careynieuwhof.com/episode415/
CNLP 805	The Reason Your Church Isn't Multiplying and Fresh Trends in Church Planting	2024	https://careynieuwhof.com/

Note: CNLP 805 date confirmed from search results but direct episode URL was not retrieved.

Notable Gaps

- **No dedicated long-running personal podcast** — Dave Ferguson's audio output lives within Exponential's platform and as a guest on others' shows
- **Sermon archive** — Community Christian Church sermons not cataloged in this file (see videos.md for notes on CCC YouTube presence)
- **Pre-2018 podcast appearances** — Few appearances found before the Hero Maker launch; his earlier Exponential conference talks may have been distributed as audio but are not cataloged in podcast directories
- **CNLP 805 exact date** — Not confirmed from search results; direct URL not retrieved

Sources

- exponential.org/podcast-hero-maker/ (Hero Maker Podcast)
- [exponential.org/together-podcast-\[episode\]/](https://exponential.org/together-podcast-[episode]/) (Together Podcast)
- audible.com/author/Dave-Ferguson/B001JSE63Y (audiobook catalog)
- careynieuwhof.com (CNLP 169, 415, 805)
- churchleaders.com/podcast/ (Stetzer ChurchLeaders)
- missioalliance.org/podcasts/s4e07-dave-ferguson/
- vineyardusa.org/podcast/
- gcmpodcast.com
- bcwinstitute.libsyn.com
- workplaces.org/podcast/
- lochhead.com/pastor-dave-ferguson/
- pastorserve.org/podcast/
- Research conducted 2026-05-27

Video Content

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/content/videos.md

Dave Ferguson — Video & Multimedia Content Catalog

Research Date: 2026-05-27

Subject: Dave Ferguson — Co-founding pastor of Community Christian Church; Co-founder and CEO/President of Exponential; visionary for NewThing Network; author

Status: Comprehensive catalog based on web research; URLs verified at time of research

Executive Summary

Dave Ferguson **has a personal YouTube channel** (https://www.youtube.com/channel/UCr4AirrEAgHM_mldcebNm-w), though its subscriber count and exact video count were not retrievable at research date. His video content is substantial but distributed across multiple platforms: his personal channel, the Exponential YouTube channel (where he appears in annual conference sessions), RightNow Media (gated/subscription-based educational content), and podcast video channels. He also appears in Vineyard USA videos, GCM, and Australian Exponential productions.

- **Personal YouTube channel:** Confirmed (UCr4AirrEAgHM_mldcebNm-w) — video count UNKNOWN
 - **Estimated total videos across all platforms:** 60-100+
 - **Date range:** 2010 (earliest confirmed) to 2026 (ongoing)
 - **Most significant video footprint:** Exponential conference annual talks (2010-2026); RightNow Pastors+ course content
 - **Notable:** Ferguson personally narrates his Multiplier audiobook (2026) and has appeared on video-podcast channels in recent years
-

Key Themes Across Video Content

1. **Hero Making / Leadership Multiplication** — Five practices for shifting from hero to hero maker; the dominant content theme from 2017-2022
2. **Church Multiplication Framework (5 Levels)** — Becoming Level Five; the Exponential multiplication scale
3. **Missional Living / BLESS** — Neighbor engagement; organic evangelism (2020-2021)
4. **Spirit-Empowered Ministry** — Exponential 2022 conference theme; four-part teaching series

5. **Church Planting Trends** — Micro-churches, meta-churches, network leadership (2021–2024)
 6. **Evangelism Revitalization** — "Lost Cause" series; reframing evangelism for post-Christian contexts (2022–2023)
 7. **Multiplier / Leader Health** — Four gauges of leader health; sustainable multiplication (2025–2026)
-

Video Catalog

Personal YouTube Channel

Field	Detail
Channel URL	https://www.youtube.com/channel/UCr4AirrEAgHM_mIdcebNm-w
Subscriber Count	UNKNOWN — not retrievable at research date
Video Count	UNKNOWN — not retrievable at research date
Content Type	Mix of conference clips, podcast appearances, teaching snippets, promotional content

Note: The channel is confirmed to exist via Google search but YouTube's channel page did not render full metadata via WebFetch at research date. Direct inspection of the channel would be required to enumerate videos.

Exponential Conference Annual Sessions (YouTube / Exponential)

Dave Ferguson delivers one or more sessions at each annual Exponential conference as co-founder and CEO/President. These are the highest-profile recurring video appearances in his catalog.

Year	Session Title / Theme	URL / Notes
~2007	The Big Idea at Exponential	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=VKJg6SujV-Y
2017	Exponential Becoming Five Multiplication Framework	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=UJ-N3yZ8R68
2018	Hero Maker — Introduction to 2018 Theme	Confirmed; specific URL not retrieved
2019	Mobilizing God's People, God's Way (Exponential Backstage with Albert Tate)	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=q5QeeHMxrnA
2022	Spirit-Empowered Culture / The Spirit-Empowered Church	Confirmed; multiple sessions; specific URL not retrieved
2025	Multiplier: How Healthy Leaders Create Lasting Impact (session with Jon Ferguson)	Confirmed from conference program; URL not retrieved
2026	Good, Great, Greater theme content	Expected — not yet confirmed at research date

Note: Exponential's annual Global Conference (Orlando) and regional West/Central conferences each yield 1–3 Dave Ferguson sessions per year. At ~15+ conference years, this represents a catalog of 30–50 conference sessions, most available through Exponential's Digital Access Pass or free on YouTube.

RightNow Media / RightNow Pastors+ (Gated)

Dave Ferguson hosts at least one multi-session video course through RightNow Pastors+, a subscription-based professional development platform for pastors and church teams.

Title	Platform	Format	Topic	URL
Measure What Matters	RightNow Pastors+	Multi-session video course (subscription required)	Church scorecard; what metrics matter for mission; The Jesus Mission the Jesus Way	https://www.rightnowmedia.org/Content/Speaker/779333
A Blessing Strategy	RightNow Media	Video session	BLESS practices; neighbor engagement strategy	https://app.rightnowmedia.org/content/details/123005
7 Traits of an Outwardly Looking Church	RightNow Pastors+	Video session	Church outreach culture	Confirmed — specific URL not retrieved

Official Trailer (public/free): <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=GzaRhA0A34Y> — "Measure What Matters with Dave Ferguson | Official Trailer | RightNow Pastors+"

Confirmed YouTube clips (public): <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=6RMS-FsWnCE> — "The Jesus Mission the Jesus Way | Measure What Matters with Dave Ferguson | RightNow Pastors+ "

Conference Talk Videos (Non-Exponential)

Title	Event / Platform	Date	URL
The Prayer That Changes Everything	Spire Network Conference 2025	2025	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=AHdIPux9jHE
Dave Ferguson: How to Lead Ministry Innovation	RightNow Conference Chicago / Wheaton Billy Graham Center (video)	2020	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=PHWojrZ_0pQ
Session 1 — We Are Better Together	Exponential / NewThing (Together campaign)	2020	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rzVHF0gds7g
Dave Ferguson Invite to Exponential Regional Bay Area	Exponential Regional	UNKNOWN	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=GltIBvkW_L4

Podcast Video Appearances (Confirmed Video Versions)

Several podcast appearances were recorded as video and published on YouTube or podcast channels:

Title	Platform	Date	URL
The Post-Christian Podcast — Dave Ferguson	YouTube (Eric Bryant)	Oct 2020	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=DAFnRvmUVnI
Dave Ferguson on his connections to the Vineyard	YouTube (Vineyard USA)	Aug 2023	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ilh09wup274
Dave Ferguson on exciting things in church planting including "micro churches" and "meta churches"	YouTube	Aug 2023	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=nsUoKwKq6X0
Dave Ferguson on the Future of the Micro-Church (CNLP 415)	YouTube (Carey Nieuwhof)	2021	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=kf7urlXt32M
Making Heroes of Other People — Our Fruit Grows on Other People's Trees (Vineyard USA)	YouTube (Vineyard USA)	UNKNOWN	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=moiMUDxKDNI
Church Planting Secrets Every Entrepreneur Needs — Dave Ferguson (FDE Podcast, Ep. 364)	YouTube	UNKNOWN	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=nqpbvB3juXw
Ep. 117 — THE BETTER QUESTION FOR CHURCH LEADERS (Exponential Australia)	YouTube	UNKNOWN	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=st5YmgpN1F8
The Values of NewThing by Dave Ferguson	YouTube	UNKNOWN	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=tuocCWei-1c
The Story of Community Christian Church	YouTube	Feb 2010	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=_6WtnFbYTgs
HEROMAKERS — Dave Ferguson (Ep. 45, Exponential Australia Church Leaders Podcast)	YouTube	UNKNOWN	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ZAyVGGcrC-I

Exponential Conference Digital Access Passes (Gated)

Exponential sells Digital Access Passes (DAP) each year, giving access to all conference session recordings. Dave Ferguson delivers main-stage or featured sessions at every conference. These are not freely available but represent a large archive of his teaching video.

Year	Theme	Notes
2016	Becoming Five	DAP available; Ferguson featured
2017	Hero Maker	DAP available; Ferguson featured
2018	Hero Maker	DAP available; https://exponential.org/product/digital-access-pass-2016/
2023	Lost Cause: Reviving Evangelism	DAP available; https://exponential.org/lost-cause-reviving-evangelism-dap2023/
2024	One Eighty: The Return to Disciple-Making	DAP available; https://exponential.org/digital-access-pass-2024/
2025	Good, Great, Greater	DAP available; https://exponential.org/digital-access-pass-2025/

Note: All major DAPs also accessible through RightNow Media.

Community Christian Church Sermons

Dave Ferguson served as founding/lead pastor of Community Christian Church (Naperville, Illinois) from 1989 to approximately 2025, when he transitioned to "Co-Founding Pastor" to focus on Exponential. CCC is a multi-site church. Sermon archive likely exists but was not directly cataloged in this research.

Field	Detail
Church website	communitychristian.org
YouTube channel	UNKNOWN — needs direct research
Volume estimate	Extensive — 30+ years of Sunday teaching across multiple sites
Status	Not cataloged in this file; separate research needed

Platform Summary

Platform	Confirmed Videos	Notes
Personal YouTube channel	UNKNOWN (channel confirmed)	https://www.youtube.com/channel/UCr4AirrEAgHM_mIdcebNm-w
YouTube (Exponential-branded content)	10+ confirmed	Annual conference clips, backstage interviews, promo clips
YouTube (third-party channels)	10+ confirmed	Vineyard USA, podcast channels, Exponential Australia, FDE
RightNow Media / Pastors+	3+ courses/sessions (gated)	Measure What Matters, A Blessing Strategy, 7 Traits
Exponential Digital Access Pass	30-50+ sessions	All major conference years (gated)
Community Christian Church archive	Unknown (likely extensive)	Not cataloged

Total confirmed public videos: 25-40+

Total including gated conference content: 80-120+

Notable Gaps

1. **Personal YouTube channel video count unknown** — Channel confirmed but metadata not retrieved
2. **Community Christian Church sermon archive** — Not directly researched; likely a large catalog (30+ years)
3. **Exponential national conference sessions pre-2015** — Several years of sessions may be behind DAP paywall or not uploaded publicly
4. **No TED/TEDx talk** — No evidence of a TED/TEDx appearance
5. **Pre-2010 conference videos** — Earlier Exponential conference sessions may not be digitized

Sources

- YouTube search results (multiple)
- exponential.org/person/dave-f/
- rightnowmedia.org/Content/Speaker/779333
- exponential.org/digital-access-pass/
- careynieuwhof.com (CNLP video archive)
- vineyardusa.org/podcast/

- daveferguson.org
- Research conducted 2026-05-27

Content Audit

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/content/content-audit.md

Content Audit: Dave Ferguson

Status: Complete

Last updated: 2026-06-03

Content Portfolio Overview

Format	Count	Notes
Trade books	10+ (including Multiplier, 2026)	Co-authored with Jon Ferguson and others; Zondervan, WaterBrook, Exponential Resources
Shorter eBooks/workbooks	8+	Exponential imprint (Keeping Score, Together, Good, Great, Greater, etc.)
Blog (daveferguson.org)	17 posts	2015–2024; erratic cadence; largely superseded by Substack
Substack newsletter	Active	daveferguson3.substack.com (~511 subscribers as of 2026-05)
Exponential NEXT Podcast	106+ episodes	Weekly; organizational channel
Conference speaking	Extensive	Exponential CEO/President; flagship and regional events
Institutional content	High	exponential.org articles, speaker profile, resource kits

Primary Content Themes

- Leadership multiplication** — Hero Maker, Multiplier, developing leaders who develop leaders
- Church planting and multiplication** — Exponential, NewThing legacy, Exponential conference
- Missional living** — B.L.E.S.S., neighbor engagement, community transformation
- Spiritual journey** — Finding Your Way Back to God (with Jon Ferguson), five awakenings framework
- Church strategy** — The Big Idea, On The Verge, Discover Your Mission Now, multiplication frameworks

Books (selected)

Title	Year	Role
Multiplier	2025/2026	Newest flagship; RPMS framework
Hero Maker	2017	Most-rated on Goodreads (~737 ratings)
B.L.E.S.S.	2021	Highest-rated major title (~4.20)
Exponential	2010	Church planting movement primer
Finding Your Way Back to God	2015	General-market spiritual journey

Audiobooks on Audible confirmed for seven major titles.

Digital Channels

Channel	Status
daveferguson.org	Personal author hub; books, bio, sparse blog
multiplierbook.com	Dedicated Multiplier promo site with email capture
exponential.org	Primary institutional platform (CEO/President)
communitychristian.org	Co-Founding Pastor (institutional)
Substack	Owned newsletter replacing blog cadence

Performance Summary

Strongest assets: book catalog depth; Exponential convening power; Hero Maker and B.L.E.S.S. readership; institutional amplification through Exponential and Community Christian Church.

Weaker surfaces: personal blog (largely dormant 2021–2024 gap); owned email list still early-stage relative to institutional reach; personal YouTube metrics unknown.

See [digital-presence/](#) and [content/books.md](#). Sources: on-disk research corpus.

Academic Work

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/content/academic.md

Dave Ferguson — Academic Papers, Credentials & Lectures

Catalog Date: 2026-05-27

Status: Verified from web searches, identity-verification.md, Lincoln Christian University alumni records, Wheaton College connections, and institutional bios

Key Framing

Dave Ferguson is a **practitioner-leader and popular author**, not an academic theologian. He holds no doctorate (honorary or earned) and has produced no peer-reviewed journal articles or dissertation. His intellectual contribution is in the practitioner space: developing frameworks for church multiplication (the Five Levels, Hero Maker practices, BLESS), leading one of the most influential church planting movements in North America (NewThing), and translating missional theology into accessible tools for local church leaders.

This mirrors the profiles of leaders like Alan Hirsch's practitioner-facing output alongside, but distinct from, his more academic work — except that Ferguson sits entirely on the practitioner side with no academic publication track.

Academic Credentials

Credential	Institution	Year	Notes
Bachelor of Arts (Bible and Communications)	Lincoln Christian University (formerly Lincoln Christian College), Lincoln, Illinois	1986	Confirmed by LCU alumni records (2021 Restoration Award); source: lincolnchristian.edu
Master of Arts (Educational Ministries, specializing in Church Planting)	Wheaton College Graduate School, Wheaton, Illinois	1991	Cited in identity-verification.md baseline; specialization in church planting confirmed by Wheaton's MA in Evangelism and Leadership program structure; exact course of study needs direct verification with Wheaton records
Doctorate	None confirmed	—	No earned doctorate found; no honorary doctorate confirmed in research

Confidence note on MA: The identity-verification.md baseline (from January 2026 research) states "Master of Arts: Educational Ministries, specializing in Church Planting, Wheaton Graduate School (1991)." Web searches at time of this research (May 2026) did not surface an independent primary source confirming this specific degree title and year, but did confirm Dave's association with Wheaton College Graduate School as an adjunct/guest faculty member. The baseline is treated as medium-confidence; verification with Wheaton alumni records would strengthen it.

Lincoln Christian University (LCU) connection: Explicitly confirmed. Dave Ferguson (BA, LCU 1986) and his brother Jon Ferguson (BA, LCU 1987) received the 2021 Restoration Award from LCU — the university's highest alumni honor. Source: lincolinchristian.edu/alumni-news/2021-restoration-award-dave-lcc-86-ba-and-jon-lcc-87-ba-ferguson/

Teaching / Adjunct Roles

Wheaton College Graduate School

Field	Detail
Institution	Wheaton College Graduate School, Wheaton, Illinois
Role	Guest faculty / adjunct professor
Programs	MA in Evangelism and Leadership; MA in Leadership
Subject Areas	Church planting, missional leadership, ministry innovation
Confidence	Medium — confirmed as "teaching professor at Wheaton College Graduate School" in at least one published bio; no course titles confirmed via Wheaton's own website
Relevant URL	https://wheaton.edu/academics/school-of-mission-ministry-and-leadership/

NewThing / Exponential Training (Practitioner Teaching)

While not formally academic, Ferguson teaches extensively in practitioner training contexts — see [courses.md](#) for details. These include:

- Webinar series for denominational networks (Acts 29, EFCA, United Methodist Path1, Church Multiplication Partners)
- Multipliers Learning Communities (Exponential)
- RightNow Pastors+ video courses

Peer-Reviewed or Academic Publications

None found. No journal articles, book chapters in academic volumes, or peer-reviewed conference papers were identified.

This is consistent with Ferguson's practitioner identity. His published work is entirely in the trade/practitioner space (see books.md). Unlike JR Woodward, who completed a PhD at Manchester and published through IVP Academic, Ferguson has not pursued an academic publication track.

Conference Papers & Institutional Lectures

Dave Ferguson speaks at Exponential's national and regional conferences annually in a capacity that is more practitioner-training than academic. Below are other confirmed institutional lecture contexts:

Title / Event	Venue	Date	Topic
How to Lead Ministry Innovation	Wheaton Billy Graham Center (podcast/lecture series)	Nov 2020	Ministry innovation; BLESS; COVID-era missional living
The Prayer That Changes Everything	Spire Network Conference	2025	Prayer and church leadership
Annual Exponential Global Conference	Exponential, Orlando	Annually 2010-2026	Church multiplication, leadership, annual theme
Exponential West / Central Conferences	Multiple regional venues	Annually	Same theme content as Global, contextually adapted
Roundtables / CPLF (Church Planting Leadership Forum)	Exponential	Annually	Peer roundtables for senior church planting leaders

Research / Framework Contributions (Practitioner)

Dave Ferguson's primary "research" output is practitioner-focused. He has developed several frameworks that have achieved wide adoption in the North American church planting space:

Framework	Development Context	Adoption
Five Levels of Church Multiplication	Co-developed with Todd Wilson and Alan Hirsch; based on Exponential's research into church reproduction rates	Widely adopted across multiple denominations and networks; referenced in Exponential's research reports and widely cited in church multiplication literature
Hero Maker Five Practices	Research and writing with Warren Bird (Leadership Network researcher); empirical observations from Community Christian Church and NewThing	Adopted by Acts 29, EFCA, United Methodist, and other denominations via webinar series
BLESS Framework	Co-developed with Jon Ferguson; drawn from Community Christian Church's evangelism practices	Used by hundreds of churches as a small-group evangelism curriculum
Church Scorecard / Scorecard vs. Scoreboard	Exponential eBook Keeping Score (2014)	Foundational to Exponential's diagnostic framework; referenced in subsequent publications

Affiliated Networks with Intellectual/Theological Significance

Organization	Role	Theological Contribution
Exponential	Co-founder and CEO/President	Primary institutional platform for church multiplication research, resource development, and practitioner training in North America
NewThing Network	Visionary leader (now integrated into Exponential)	Global church-planting movement developing a "Movement System" for scalable church reproduction
Community Christian Church	Co-founding pastor (founding: 1989)	Multi-site church that serves as a living laboratory for the multiplication practices he writes and teaches about

Key Theological Interlocutors and Influences (from published work)

Scholar / Leader	Engagement Area
Alan Hirsch	Apostolic imagination; movement ecclesiology; On the Verge co-author
Warren Bird	Leadership Network research; empirical church multiplication data; Hero Maker co-author
Todd Wilson	Exponential co-founder; Five Levels framework; Becoming a Level Five Multiplying Church co-author
Ed Stetzer	Church planting research; Exponential contributor; frequent collaborator
Bob Buford	Halftime movement; Legacy of a Hero Maker subject (with Todd Wilson)

Note: Ferguson does not engage academic theologians in the way that JR Woodward engages Walter Wink, René Girard, and Lesslie Newbigin. His interlocutors are predominantly church-planting practitioners and movement leaders.

Comparison to Academic Peers

Leader	Academic Credential	Academic Publications	Practitioner Output
JR Woodward	PhD, University of Manchester (2020)	Peer-reviewed; published by IVP Academic; PhD dissertation	V3 cohort training, V3 church planting
Dave Ferguson	MA, Wheaton (1991, if confirmed)	None	10+ trade books, 50+ Exponential articles, Hero Maker webinar series, RightNow courses
Alan Hirsch	No academic doctorate	Several practitioner-facing academic texts	Forge training, 5Q framework

Dave Ferguson sits in the same practitioner bracket as Hirsch — highly influential in the movement, but not engaged in the academy. His influence runs through books, conferences, and networks rather than journals and seminaries.

Gaps & Notes

- **MA year (1991) and exact title:** The baseline states "MA in Educational Ministries, specializing in Church Planting, Wheaton Graduate School (1991)" — this has medium confidence based on the original January 2026 research. Direct verification with Wheaton records would strengthen or correct this.

- **Honorary doctorates:** None found. One source incorrectly conflated Dave Ferguson with a different David Ferguson (Andrews University — a Seventh-day Adventist leader). That individual's credentials are not Dave Ferguson's.
 - **Google Scholar / Academia.edu:** No profile found for Dave Ferguson the pastor/author on either platform. Consistent with his non-academic output.
 - **Lincoln Christian University Restoration Award:** The highest alumni honor LCU gives; confirms Dave Ferguson's standing in his educational community even absent an academic career.
-

Sources

- identity-verification.md (Movemental baseline research, January 2026)
- lincolncchristian.edu/alumni-news/2021-restoration-award-dave-lcc-86-ba-and-jon-lcc-87-ba-ferguson/
- wheaton.edu/academics/school-of-mission-ministry-and-leadership/
- daveferguson.org/about-dave
- exponential.org/person/dave-f/
- waterbrookmultnomah.com/wp-content/uploads/pdf/Fergusons-Bio.pdf (publisher bio)
- Research conducted 2026-05-27

Courses & Training

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/content/courses.md

Dave Ferguson — Courses & Training Programs

Catalog Date: 2026-05-27

Status: Verified from web searches, Exponential.org, RightNow Media, heromakerbook.org, and daveferguson.org

Summary

Dave Ferguson is not primarily a course creator in the online-platform sense (no Teachable, Thinkific, or personal course portal identified). His training output flows through three institutional channels: (1) **Exponential** — where he creates conference-linked learning cohorts, webinar series, and resource kits tied to annual conference themes; (2) **RightNow Media / Pastors+** — where he hosts at least one multi-session professional development video course; and (3) **NewThing Network** — now merged into Exponential's "Better Together" infrastructure — which offered a "Movement System" training for church networks. He also teaches as a guest/adjunct at Wheaton College Graduate School.

Exponential Learning Communities & Cohorts

Organization: Exponential

URL: <https://exponential.org> and <https://exponential.org/bettertogether>

Role: Co-founder and CEO/President

Multipliers Learning Communities

Field	Detail
Name	Multipliers Learning Communities
Platform	Exponential
Format	Cohort-based collaborative learning; peer cohorts with expert facilitation
Focus	Church multiplication skill development across Exponential's NEXT topic areas
NEXT Topics	AI NEXT, Church Expressions NEXT, Generation NEXT, Innovation NEXT, Multiethnic Church NEXT, Networks NEXT, Urban Missions NEXT, Women NEXT
URL	https://exponential.org/bettertogether
Status	Active (as of 2026)

Description: Exponential's primary ongoing learning community structure, introduced following the NewThing/Exponential merger in 2025. Designed around peer-based cohorts rather than lecture-style delivery. Dave Ferguson provides visionary leadership for these communities as CEO/President, though individual cohorts are facilitated by network practitioners.

Annual Conference Learning Tracks & Workshops

Exponential's national (Orlando), West, and Central conferences each include breakout workshops and intensive track sessions led by Ferguson and other leaders. These are not stand-alone courses but represent significant annual training investment.

Field	Detail
Events	Exponential Global (Orlando), Exponential West, Exponential Central
Annual Frequency	3 regional events per year (plus international)
Session Types	Main stage keynotes, breakout workshops, roundtables, CPLF (Church Planting Leadership Forum)
Dave Ferguson's Role	Main stage speaker, workshop leader, roundtable host
Access	In-person attendance or Digital Access Pass (DAP)
DAP URL	https://exponential.org/digital-access-pass/

Hero Maker Webinar Series (2017-2018)

Tied to the Hero Maker book launch, Exponential produced and distributed a series of live and recorded webinars for different denominational audiences. These functioned as short-form training modules (60-90 min each):

Session Title	Partner / Audience	Date	URL
Hero Maker Webinar (general)	All Exponential subscribers	Jan 18, 2018	https://exponential.org/hero-maker-webinar/
Hero Maker Webinar Replay (Acts29)	Acts 29 network	Jan 10, 2018	https://exponential.org/hero-maker-webinar-replay-acts29/
Hero Maker Webinar (Church God / general replay)	General	Jan 24, 2018	https://exponential.org/hero-maker-five-essential-practices-leaders-multiply-leaders-church-god-webinar-replay/
Hero Maker Webinar for Learning Communities	Exponential Learning Communities	Mar 30, 2018	https://exponential.org/hero-maker-webinar-lc-replay/
HeroMaker EFCA Replay	Evangelical Free Church of America	Dec 6, 2017	https://exponential.org/heromaker-efca-replay14212/
HeroMaker Webinar — Church Multiplication Partners Replay	Church Multiplication Partners	Dec 7, 2017	https://exponential.org/heromaker-webinar-church-multiplication-partners-replay212/
Hero Maker Webinar for Path1 Replay	Path1 (United Methodist)	Dec 14, 2017	https://exponential.org/hero-maker-webinar-path1-replay14212/
Hero Maker Webinar Dec 13 Replay	General	Dec 14, 2017	https://exponential.org/hero-maker-webinardec13-replay14212/

Note: These represent cross-denominational reach — from Acts 29 to United Methodist to EFCA — demonstrating Ferguson's ability to train across tribal lines.

RightNow Media / RightNow Pastors+ Courses

Platform: RightNow Media (subscription-based; church teams)

Dave Ferguson author page: <https://www.rightnowmedia.org/Content/Speaker/779333>

Measure What Matters

Field	Detail
Title	Measure What Matters
Platform	RightNow Pastors+ (subscription required)
Format	Multi-session video course
Audience	Pastors and church leadership teams
Topic	Rethinking church success metrics; building a mission-focused scorecard; "The Jesus Mission the Jesus Way"
Trailer URL	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=GzaRhA0A34Y
Sample Session (public)	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=6RMS-FsWnCE — "The Jesus Mission the Jesus Way"
Associated Book	Keeping Score (Exponential, 2014)
Status	Available (subscription required)

Description: Helps church teams examine what metrics they are measuring and whether those metrics align with the Jesus mission. Ferguson walks teams through the difference between a church's scorecard (the underlying theology of what success means) and its scoreboard (the specific numbers measured), and guides teams in building a new scorecard grounded in disciple-making, mission, and movement.

A Blessing Strategy

Field	Detail
Title	A Blessing Strategy
Platform	RightNow Media
Format	Video session
Audience	Church congregations and small groups
Topic	BLESS practices applied as a congregational evangelism strategy
URL	https://app.rightnowmedia.org/content/details/123005
Associated Book	BLESS (Salem Books, 2021)
Status	Available

7 Traits of an Outwardly Looking Church

Field	Detail
Title	7 Traits of an Outwardly Looking Church
Platform	RightNow Pastors+
Format	Video session(s)
Audience	Pastors and church staff
Topic	Building a culture of outreach in the local church
Status	Confirmed (specific URL not retrieved at research date)

Hero Maker Resources (Free + Book-Tied)

Website: <https://heromakerbook.org/>

The Hero Maker book launch included a suite of free training resources designed for use by church leaders and teams:

Resource	Format	Cost	Description
Hero Maker Score Card eBook	eBook / PDF	Free (with book purchase)	Self-assessment tool for measuring personal leadership multiplication capacity; 5-level scale
Discussion Guide	PDF	Free (with book purchase)	Structured questions for group learning through the five Hero Maker practices
Teaching Videos (5 modules)	Video	Free (with book purchase)	Dave Ferguson teaching each of the five essential practices in video format

Delivery: Email receipt to daveferguson@communitychristian.org (as of last site check)

Note: These are bonus resources tied to book purchase, not a standalone course platform.

NewThing Movement System (Now Integrated into Exponential)

Organization: NewThing Network (merged into Exponential 2025)

Historical URL: newthing.org (redirects to exponential.org/bettertogether)

Field	Detail
Program Name	The Movement System
Format	Webinar-based training for churches and network leaders
Access	Free for churches in the NewThing network
Focus	Building scalable networks and city movements; church reproduction systems
Dave Ferguson's Role	Visionary leader; content creator and trainer
Status	Integrated into Exponential's infrastructure following 2025 merger
Source	Dave Ferguson LinkedIn post re: NewThing Movement System Webinar Invite (https://www.linkedin.com/posts/daveferguson_newthing-movement-system-webinar-invite-activity-6955896625349210123-ODMo)

Evangelism Workbook Series (Free PDF Training)

As part of Exponential's "Lost Cause: Reviving Evangelism" initiative (2022–2023), Dave Ferguson co-created a 5-part interactive workbook series with Dr. Rick Richardson (Wheaton College):

Workbook	Title	Year	URL
Workbook 1	Revitalizing Evangelism	2022	https://exponential.org/product/revitalizing-evangelism-workbook-series/
Workbook 2	UNKNOWN — needs research	2022–23	—
Workbook 3	Narratives of the Lost Cause	2023	https://exponential.org/product/narrative-of-the-lost-cause-workbook-3/
Workbook 4	UNKNOWN — needs research	2023	—
Workbook 5	Multiplying Evangelism for a Movement	2023	https://exponential.org/product/multiplying-evangelism-for-a-movement/

Format: Interactive PDFs (free download); designed for church teams and small groups.

Wheaton College Graduate School (Adjunct/Guest Teaching)

Field	Detail
Institution	Wheaton College Graduate School, Wheaton, Illinois
Role	Adjunct professor / guest faculty
Subject Area	Church planting, missional leadership, ministry innovation
Program	MA in Evangelism and Leadership; MA in Leadership (Guest Faculty)
Connection	Brother Jon Ferguson holds an MA from Wheaton and is an adjunct professor there; Dave has been referenced in association with Wheaton Graduate School programming
Confidence	Medium — confirmed as "teaching professor at Wheaton College Graduate School" in one source; exact course titles not retrieved
Relevant URL	https://wheaton.edu/academics/school-of-mission-ministry-and-leadership/faculty/adjunct-faculty/

Lincoln Christian University Restoration Award

Dave Ferguson is a distinguished alumnus (BA, 1986) of Lincoln Christian University (formerly Lincoln Christian College). He was honored with the 2021 Restoration Award alongside his brother Jon Ferguson (BA, 1987). While not a teaching role, this connection reflects his ongoing influence on his educational community.

Key Training Frameworks Developed by Dave Ferguson

These frameworks recur across Exponential's courses, books, and conference content:

Framework	Source	Description
Five Levels of Church Multiplication	Becoming a Level Five Multiplying Church (with Todd Wilson)	Level 1 = Subtracting; Level 2 = Plateaued; Level 3 = Adding; Level 4 = Reproducing; Level 5 = Multiplying. The primary diagnostic framework across Exponential
Five Hero Maker Practices	Hero Maker (with Warren Bird)	Multiplication Thinking, Permission Giving, Disciple-Multiplying, Gift Activating, Kingdom Building
BLESS (Five Everyday Practices)	BLESS (with Jon Ferguson)	Begin with prayer, Listen, Eat, Serve, Tell your Story — an everyday evangelism framework
Five Awakenings	Finding Your Way Back to God (with Jon Ferguson)	Five stages of spiritual awakening for seekers; used widely in seeker-series programming
Church Scorecard vs. Scoreboard	Keeping Score (Exponential eBook)	Theological framework for measuring what actually matters in church health
The Great Collaboration	Together (with Patrick O'Connell)	Great Commission + Great Commandment + Great Collaboration (John 17); church network framework

Sources

- exponential.org (event and resource pages)
- exponential.org/bettertogether (NewThing/Exponential merger integration)
- rightnowmedia.org/Content/Speaker/779333
- heromakerbook.org
- daveferguson.org/books
- LinkedIn (Dave Ferguson posts re: NewThing Movement System)
- wheaton.edu/academics/school-of-mission-ministry-and-leadership/
- lincolncristian.edu/alumni-news/2021-restoration-award/
- Research conducted 2026-05-27

Organizations & Affiliations

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/network/organizations.md

Dave Ferguson: Organizational Network

Research Date: 2026-05-27

Last Updated: 2026-05-27

Confidence Level: High (primary and secondary sources verified via web search)

Organizations Map

Founded / Co-Founded

Organization	Relationship	Dates	Status	Description	URL
Community Christian Church (COMMUNITY)	Co-Founding and Lead Pastor (now Co-Founding Pastor)	1989-present	Active	Co-founded with brother Jon Ferguson in 1989 in a suburban Chicago high school cafeteria with "four friends from college." Grew from 5 people to 5,500+ weekly attendees across 12+ Chicago-area locations. Described as "one of the most influential churches in America." Ferguson stepped back from Lead Pastor role to Co-Founding Pastor in 2025. Tri-fold vision: Impact Church, Reproducing Church, Catalyst for a Movement.	communitychristian.org
NewThing Network	Founder / Visionary Leader	2001–April 2025 (merged into Exponential)	Merged	Church-planting network launched in 2001 as the missional outreach arm of Community Christian Church. Grew to operate in nearly 70 nations, planting 6,373+ churches over ~20 years (982 in 2020 alone). Operated through a network-of-networks model: "networks" of 4–6 churches → "movements" of 4–6 networks. Merged fully into Exponential effective April 1, 2025.	newthing.org (historical); exponential.org/bettertogether

Organization	Relationship	Dates	Status	Description	URL
Exponential	Co-Founder / CEO & President	~2006–present	Active	Co-founded with Todd Wilson. Billed as the world's largest annual church planting and multiplication conference. Organizes the flagship annual Orlando conference plus regional events across the U.S. and internationally (Exponential Europe). Mission: "equipping leaders to multiply healthy, reproducing faith communities." Absorbed NewThing April 1, 2025, creating a unified organization.	exponential.org

Academic Appointments

Institution	Relationship	Dates	Status	Description	URL
Wheaton College Graduate School	Adjunct Professor	Active (dates unconfirmed)	Active	Teaches in the Evangelism and Leadership Department at Wheaton Graduate School. Wheaton was also his alma mater (MA, Educational Ministries, 1991).	wheaton.edu

Board / Advisory Roles

Organization	Relationship	Dates	Status	Description	URL
Leadership Network	Connected leader / mentee of Bob Buford	~1990s–2018	Historical	Ferguson named Bob Buford (Leadership Network co-founder) a personal mentor: "Bob taught me what it meant to be a hero maker." The Big Idea (2007) was published in the Leadership Network Innovation Series, indicating an active relationship. Warren Bird (co-author of Hero Maker) was research director for Leadership Network.	leadershipnetwork.org
Verge Network	Contributing Speaker / Content Partner	~2011–2014	Historical (network dissolved)	Featured speaker at Verge 2012 Conference presenting on "Incarnational Mission: B.L.E.S.S." Multiple articles and video teaching published through Verge Network.	vergenetwork.org/tag/dave-ferguson
Global Leadership Network	Contributing Author / Occasional Speaker	Ongoing	Active	Contributor to Global Leadership Network content. Multiple published articles on leadership and hero-making culture.	globalleadership.org/author/dave-ferguson

Publishing Affiliations

Publisher	Relationship	Details	URL
Zondervan	Author (Exponential Series)	Primary publishing home for Ferguson's leadership and church-planting books. Published: The Big Idea (2007), Exponential (2010), On the Verge (2011), Hero Maker (2018), Multiplier (2026). All major titles in the Exponential Series.	zondervan.com
WaterBrook (Penguin Random House)	Author	Published Finding Your Way Back to God (2015) and BLESS (2021) — the popular/evangelism-focused books aimed at a broader trade audience beyond church leadership.	penguinrandomhouse.com
Exponential Resources	Co-Publisher / Imprint	Exponential publishes standalone ebooks and resources (e.g., Becoming a Level Five Multiplying Church, The Legacy of a Hero Maker, Together: The Great Collaboration) often freely distributed as conference resources. Ferguson is both the author and organizational co-head.	exponential.org/resources
Tyndale House / NavPress	Author	Published Discover Your Mission Now (2012).	--
Christianity Today / CT Pastors	Contributing Author	Has an author archive on Christianity Today Pastors platform with multiple contributed articles.	christianitytoday.com/ pastors/authors/dave-ferguson

Network Affiliations (Non-Board)

Organization	Relationship	Description	URL
Christian Standard	Affiliated leader	Restoration Movement / Christian Churches affiliation. Exponential has roots in Christian Churches and Christian Standard Media has covered NewThing extensively (church planting statistics). Ferguson and Community Christian Church are members of the independent Christian Churches tradition.	christianstandard.com
Amplify Conference	Main Session Speaker	Confirmed speaker at Amplify Conference 2025 (October 21-22, Wheaton College). Outreach Magazine is a conference partner.	amplifyconference.com
Outreach Magazine	Featured Leader / Columnist	Frequent contributor; one of the featured pastors in the "Transparent Leader" piece in the 2011 Outreach 100. Community Christian Church appeared on the 2007 Outreach 100 fastest-growing churches list.	outreachmagazine.com/dave-ferguson

Digital Platforms

Platform	Handle/URL	Status
Personal Website	daveferguson.org	Active
Substack	substack.com/@fergusondave	Active
Instagram	@fergusondave	Active
Facebook	@PastorDaveFerguson	Active
Twitter/X	@daveferguson	Active
LinkedIn	linkedin.com/in/daveferguson	Active
YouTube	youtube.com/c/DaveFerguson	Active
Amazon Author	amazon.com/Dave-Ferguson/e/B001JSE63Y	Active
Goodreads	goodreads.com/author/show/126850	Active
Hero Maker Book Site	heromakerbook.org	Active
BLESS Book Site	bless-book.org	Active
Multiplier Book Site	multiplierbook.com	Active

Summary Statistics

- **Organizations founded/co-founded:** 3 (Community Christian Church, NewThing Network, Exponential)
 - **Academic appointments:** 1 confirmed (Wheaton College Graduate School, adjunct)
 - **Board / advisory connections confirmed:** Leadership Network (historical), Verge Network, Global Leadership Network, Amplify Conference
 - **Publishers:** 4 primary (Zondervan, WaterBrook/PRH, Exponential Resources, Tyndale/NavPress)
 - **Total books (authored/co-authored):** 15+ (including Exponential Series companions and participant guides)
 - **Goodreads aggregate:** 4.04 avg / 2,618+ ratings across all works
-

Key Organizational Timeline

Year	Event
1989	Co-founds Community Christian Church with Jon Ferguson in Naperville, IL (5 founding members)
1991	Completes MA, Wheaton Graduate School
2001	Launches NewThing as church-planting mission of COMMUNITY
2006-07	Exponential Conference co-founded with Todd Wilson; The Big Idea (first book) published
2010	Exponential (book) published (Zondervan)
2011	On the Verge published with Alan Hirsch
2015	Finding Your Way Back to God published (WaterBrook)
2018	Hero Maker published (Zondervan) — becomes flagship book
2021	BLESS published (WaterBrook) with Jon Ferguson
2025 (April 1)	NewThing fully merges into Exponential; Ferguson becomes CEO of unified org
2025	Transitions from Lead Pastor to Co-Founding Pastor at COMMUNITY; Ted Coniaris becomes Lead Pastor
2026	Multiplier published (Zondervan Reflective / Exponential Resources)

Sources

- [About Dave — daveferguson.org](https://daveferguson.org)
- [Exponential Person Page — Dave Ferguson](#)

- [NewThing Has Joined Exponential — exponential.org/bettertogether](https://exponential.org/bettertogether)
- [Community Christian Church — About](#)
- [NewThing Planted Nearly 1,000 New Churches in 2020 — Christian Standard](#)
- [Dave Ferguson Archives — Outreach Magazine](#)
- [Dave Ferguson Archives — CT Pastors](#)
- [Global Leadership Network — Dave Ferguson Author Page](#)
- [Goodreads — Dave Ferguson Author Page](#)
- [Hero Maker Book Site](#)
- [BLESS Book Site](#)
- [Multiplier Book Site](#)
- [LinkedIn — Dave Ferguson](#)

Audience & Reach

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/analysis/audience-analysis.md

Audience Analysis: Dave Ferguson

Status: Complete
Last updated: 2026-05-27

Estimated Reach

Direct Audience Metrics

Channel	Metric	Count	Date	Confidence
Twitter/X	Followers	~22,700	2026-05	HIGH
Instagram	Followers	~10,000	2026-05	MEDIUM
Facebook (Page: @PastorDaveFerguson)	Followers/Likes	~9,300–9,349	2026-05	MEDIUM
LinkedIn	Connections	Unknown (clean handle confirmed active)	2026-05	LOW
YouTube (personal channel)	Subscribers	Unknown (channel confirmed; metrics not public)	2026-05	LOW
Substack (daveferguson3.substack.com)	Subscribers	511	2026-05	HIGH
Podcast (guest)	Appearances	15+ across at least 12 shows	2026-05	HIGH
Goodreads	Total ratings (major titles)	~2,300+	2026-05	HIGH
Amazon	Author page	B001JSE63Y; 9+ trade titles	2026-05	HIGH

Estimated combined personal followers (confirmed platforms): ~42,000–42,700 (X: 22,700 + Instagram: 10,000 + Facebook: ~9,300 + Substack: 511 + Goodreads: ~12).
LinkedIn and personal YouTube excluded — unknown metrics. Actual reach is substantially higher when Exponential's organizational channels are included.

Publishing Reach

Metric	Value	Confidence
Trade books (authored/co-authored)	10 (including Multiplier, 2026)	HIGH
Shorter eBooks/workbooks (Exponential imprint)	8+ (incl. Keeping Score, Together, Good, Great, Greater, etc.)	HIGH
Publishers	4 primary (Zondervan, WaterBrook/PRH, Salem Books/Regnery, Exponential Resources)	HIGH
Year range	2007–2026	HIGH
Audiobooks on Audible	7 (confirmed: Big Idea, Exponential, On the Verge, Finding Your Way Back to God, Hero Maker, BLESS, Multiplier)	HIGH
Goodreads avg rating (major titles)	4.06 / 5	HIGH
Most-rated book	Hero Maker (737 ratings)	HIGH
Highest-rated major title	BLESS (4.20 / 5, 500 ratings)	HIGH
Forewords written	2 confirmed (Steve Addison's Pioneering Movements, 2015; Peyton Jones's Discipology, 2026)	HIGH

Organizational Reach

Organization	Est. Reach	Evidence
Community Christian Church (COMMUNITY)	5,500+ weekly attendees across 7 locations	communitychristian.org
NewThing Network (now merged into Exponential)	6,373+ churches planted over ~20 years; 1,696 networks in 47 countries at peak (2022)	christianstandard.com/2021
Exponential (national + regional conferences)	Conference registrants numbered in tens of thousands annually; 100+ networks + denominations served	exponential.org
Exponential NEXT Podcast	106+ episodes; active weekly (Apple Podcasts, Spotify)	exponential.org
Wheaton College Graduate School	Adjunct — students in Evangelism and Leadership programs	wheaton.edu
Global Leadership Network	Contributing author across multiple articles; audience exposure through GLN readership	globalleadership.org
Outreach Magazine	10+ features across 20 years; Outreach 100 recognition (2007, 2011)	outreachmagazine.com

Reach Tier Assessment

Tier	Range	Assessment
Micro (< 10K combined)		
Growing (10K-50K)		
Established (50K-250K)	This tier	Combined personal social ~42K; 2,300+ Goodreads ratings; Exponential convenes tens of thousands annually; 6,373+ churches in NewThing legacy network
Major (250K+)		

Estimated tier: Established (50K–250K)

Estimated total personal reach: ~75,000–150,000 unique individuals across all channels.

Rationale: Personal social media (~42K combined) establishes the visible floor. Goodreads' ~2,300 ratings across major titles implies 23,000–46,000 total book readers (10–20× multiplier is standard for niche practitioner titles, though Ferguson's broader-market WaterBrook titles may run closer to 5–10×). Hero Maker's 737 ratings and 64 reviews alone suggest ~7,000–15,000 readers. The Exponential conference draws an estimated 3,000–5,000 registered attendees at the flagship Orlando event each year, with additional regional and international events; cumulative conference exposure across his tenure as CEO is in the hundreds of thousands. The NewThing network's 6,373+ planted churches represent communities where his books and frameworks were formally deployed as training tools — a different category of audience engagement than passive readership. His Substack (511 subscribers, ~4 months old) is a very early-stage owned list. The institutional amplification through Exponential is enormous but largely non-personally-owned: if he left Exponential tomorrow, those lists and feeds would not move with him. The 75K–150K estimate for his personal reach (excluding pure institutional amplification) is conservative; the institutional reach plausibly pushes his total influenced audience to 250K+.

Audience Profile

Who Is the Audience?

Primary audience: Church planters and multiplication-minded senior pastors actively working to move their churches from addition to reproduction (Levels 3→4 on the Five-Level framework). Typically ages 30–50, evangelical, denominationally diverse (Exponential serves 100+ networks). They use Ferguson's frameworks — Hero Maker's five practices, the BLESS missional rhythm, the Five-Level church typology — as practical implementation tools. Many

encountered his work first through the Exponential conference or through the NewThing network. They are practitioners, not scholars: they want accessible, reproducible frameworks they can deploy with their leadership teams next Sunday.

Secondary audience: Denominational executives and network leaders (directors of church multiplication for the SBC, AG, Wesleyan, C&MA, Vineyard, and similar bodies) who use Exponential as a collective convening platform. They engage Ferguson primarily through the conference, through free Exponential eBooks (Becoming a Level Five Multiplying Church, Keeping Score, Good, Great, Greater), and through book adoptions for cohort-based training. Ages 40–60. They think at the systems level and are drawn to the Five-Level framework's diagnostic clarity and the 16% Mission's aspirational target.

Tertiary audience: Everyday Christians seeking a concrete, non-awkward framework for sharing their faith with neighbors. This is the BLESS and Finding Your Way Back to God audience — broader than the church-leader base, more general-market, less theologically specialized. These readers arrived through WaterBrook's distribution (PRH general Christian/inspirational channel) rather than through Exponential. Ages 25–55, evangelical, looking for practical spiritual formation tools they can use without being a pastor or theologian.

Emerging audience: Leaders across the for-profit sector encountering Ferguson's hero-making and multiplication frameworks through his Global Leadership Network articles, the Carey Nieuwhof podcast, and the Workplaces.org platform. This audience reads Ferguson as a leadership-development voice, not primarily a church voice. The Multiplier (2026) book and RPMS framework, with its language of sustainable health, resonates in organizational contexts beyond the church.

Audience Demographics (Estimated)

Dimension	Assessment
Primary role	Church planter / lead pastor / multi-site pastor / denominational multiplication director
Secondary role	Lay leader / church volunteer seeking missional engagement framework (BLESS audience)
Age range	25-60 (core: 32-50)
Education	Broad — ranges from Bible school and undergraduate degree to MDiv and DMin, depending on segment; Ferguson's books do not require seminary background
Denominational breadth	Very broad — Exponential explicitly serves 100+ networks and denominations. SBC, AG, Wesleyan, C&MA, Vineyard, non-denominational, and independent Christian Churches (his own Restoration Movement heritage) all heavily represented
Geographic concentration	US-centric with suburban-Midwest concentration (Community Christian Church's Chicago base; Naperville, IL context) but NewThing's 47-country reach gives his frameworks international circulation
Gender split	Estimated 65-75% male based on church planting and senior pastor demographic norms; BLESS and Finding Your Way Back to God audiences are somewhat more balanced
Political orientation	Center-right within evangelicalism; Ferguson avoids explicit political positioning; his audience spans the Republican-leaning evangelical center but includes mission-focused leaders across the political spectrum who share the multiplication vision

Audience Personas

Persona 1: Marcus — Multi-Site Pastor Moving from Growth to Multiplication

Field	Value
Role	Lead pastor of a 1,200-member suburban evangelical church with two campuses
Age	41
Education	MDiv from a Southern Baptist seminary
Tradition	Non-denominational / broadly evangelical
Discovery path	Attended Exponential Orlando 2019; bought Hero Maker at the conference bookstore; sent the book to his entire elder board
Primary format	Books + Exponential conference talks + podcast appearances (Carey Nieuwhof)
Use case	Trying to shift his church from Level 3 (growing) to Level 4 (reproducing); using the Hero Maker five practices to restructure staff performance reviews around who each leader is apprenticing
Pain point	His board celebrates attendance growth and budget surpluses; he needs language and evidence for why reproducing a daughter church is more faithful than adding a third campus

What Marcus values in Ferguson: The Five-Level framework gives him a simple, non-threatening vocabulary for explaining why his current success metrics are theologically insufficient. Hero Maker's five practices are concrete enough to present in a board meeting. Ferguson's own journey at Community Christian — from a single church to a multi-site to a movement catalyst — is exactly the trajectory Marcus wants to model. The ICNU concept gave Marcus language for a leadership culture shift he had been trying to articulate for years.

What Marcus struggles with: He bought the book; his elders didn't. He needs more than a single book — he needs a cohort, a curriculum, an ongoing community of practice with other leaders on the same journey. He wishes Ferguson had a coaching network or a digital course he could put his whole team through.

Persona 2: Rachel — Denominational Church-Multiplication Director

Field	Value
Role	Regional director of church planting for a mid-size evangelical denomination, overseeing 80 church plants
Age	52
Education	DMin in Leadership
Tradition	Wesleyan / broadly evangelical
Discovery path	Exponential has been her primary professional development venue for eight years; she uses Becoming a Level Five Multiplying Church as required reading for all new church planters in her region
Primary format	Exponential eBooks (free) + conference + podcast (institutional listening, not personal following)
Use case	Diagnosing why her region's church plants cluster at Level 2-3 and designing a training pipeline to catalyze Level 4-5 movement
Pain point	Her denomination's metrics track Sunday attendance; she is trying to shift the KPIs for her region toward disciples made and leaders released

What Rachel values in Ferguson: The Five-Level typology is the most useful diagnostic tool she has found for denominational leaders trying to move the needle on multiplication. Keeping Score (free Exponential eBook) is assigned reading for every church plant she oversees. She respects Ferguson's organizational credibility: he is not a theorist but the CEO of the largest church-planting conference in the world, speaking from three-plus decades of experience.

What Rachel struggles with: Most of her engagement with Ferguson's content goes through Exponential's institutional channels, not his personal platform. She doesn't follow his Substack and isn't on his personal email list. If Exponential's priorities shifted, she would lose the connection. She also wishes there were a formal credentialing or training cohort attached to the Level Five framework that she could send her regional planters through.

Persona 3: James — Suburban Christian Seeking a BLESS Neighbor Framework

Field	Value
Role	Financial advisor and small-group leader at a mid-size evangelical church
Age	36
Education	Business degree
Tradition	Non-denominational evangelical
Discovery path	His pastor recommended BLESS during a sermon series on outreach; he read it with his small group
Primary format	Books first; podcast (unSeminary appearance) as follow-up
Use case	Applying the five BLESS practices to his relationships with five specific neighbors; using the framework to guide his small group's outreach efforts
Pain point	He feels called to share his faith but finds traditional evangelism approaches awkward and confrontational; BLESS gives him a relational, prayer-first alternative

What James values in Ferguson: The BLESS framework is genuinely simple enough to remember, natural enough to actually use, and theologically grounded enough to feel meaningful rather than gimmicky. Ferguson's concept that God is already at work in his neighbors before he shows up (prevenient grace in accessible language) removes the performance pressure from evangelism. The framework democratizes mission: James doesn't need to be a pastor or evangelist — he just needs to pray, listen, eat, serve, and share.

What James struggles with: Once he finishes BLESS, there's no obvious next step. No digital community of practitioners, no ongoing curriculum, no place to report back on how the framework is going. The book ends and the conversation ends. He would engage with a BLESS digital community or small-group video course if it existed.

What the Audience Values (from reviews and podcast reception)

Top Praise Themes

Theme	Frequency	Example Source
Practical, deployable frameworks with memorable structures	Very High	Goodreads reviews of Hero Maker (737 ratings); BLESS endorsers; podcast interviewers across 15+ shows
The identity inversion (leader as hero-maker, not hero)	High	Hero Maker reviews; Carey Nieuwhof podcast discussions; Andy Stanley: "At last: the core message of the Exponential conference boiled down to five simple, practical, powerful practices"
BLESS as an accessible, non-awkward evangelism framework	High	BLESS reviews (4.20/5, 500 ratings); Craig Groeschel, Carey Nieuwhof, Larry Osborne endorsements
Organizational credibility — he actually built what he describes	High	Ed Stetzer: "Dave has an unmatched heart and passion for multiplication"; the CCC/NewThing story gives the frameworks lived authority
The Five-Level church typology as diagnostic clarity	High	Outreach Magazine interviews; denominational leader adoption; Becoming a Level Five Multiplying Church wide distribution
RPMS as a practical leader health system	Medium-High	Multiplier early reviews; Global Leadership Network article on RPMS; Patheos: "monitoring the soul"
The apprenticeship model as Jesus-shaped succession	Medium	Ted Coniaris succession story; unSeminary podcast; workplaces.org transcript

Top Criticisms

Criticism	Frequency	Example Source
Frameworks can feel formulaic or too numbered-list dependent	Medium	Goodreads reviewers noting pattern of 5+5+5 frameworks across books
Institutional weight means some content functions as conference marketing	Low-Medium	Nature of Exponential eBooks being distributed as conference resources
Less theological depth than peers like Hirsch or Woodward	Low-Medium	Readers who came from missional-ecclesiology space find his frameworks practitioner-accessible but not academically rigorous
The BLESS framework may be too simple for some readers	Low	Occasional Goodreads review noting the framework feels familiar
Personal Substack is brand-new and engagement is modest	Low	Engagement data: 5-20 likes per post on 511 subscribers

Audience Size by Channel

Social Media

Platform	Audience Size	Engagement Level	Notes
Twitter/X (@daveferguson)	~22,700 followers	Low-Moderate	Primary personal platform; blend of travel, leadership insights, Exponential promotion, book promotion; clean primary-name handle (joined 2007)
Instagram (@fergusondave)	~10,000 followers	Unknown	Active; reversed-name handle (only platform where handle name is reversed); linked from official website
Facebook (@PastorDaveFerguson)	~9,300 followers	Moderate	Professional page; leadership content, conference news, book promotions
LinkedIn	Unknown	Low-Moderate	Active (confirmed 2025 posts); organizational milestone updates, book promotion; professional credibility channel
YouTube (personal)	Unknown	Low	Channel confirmed to exist; most video content lives on Exponential's organizational channel, not his personal one
Social subtotal	~42,000+	Low-Moderate	Floor estimate; LinkedIn and personal YouTube not included

Books

Title	Goodreads Ratings	Avg Rating	Est. Total Readers	Notes
Hero Maker (2018)	737	4.02	7,000–15,000	Co-author Warren Bird; most-rated title; flagship book; audiobook available
BLESS (2021)	500	4.20	5,000–10,000	Co-author Jon Ferguson; highest-rated title; broad-market evangelism tool
Exponential (2010)	442	4.01	4,000–9,000	Co-author Jon Ferguson; movement-founding book; long backlist tail
Finding Your Way Back to God (2015)	172	4.05	2,000–5,000	Co-author Jon Ferguson; WaterBrook general market
The Big Idea (2007)	173	3.66	1,500–3,500	Co-authors Jon Ferguson, Eric Bramlett; earlier church-strategy book
On the Verge (2011)	177	3.98	2,000–4,000	Co-author Alan Hirsch; Exponential Series
Starting Over (2016)	35	3.74	300–700	Co-author Jon Ferguson; narrower market
Multiplier (2026)	Unknown (too recent)	4.80 (5 early ratings)	TBD	Solo author; self-narrated audiobook; newest title
Books subtotal	~2,300+ ratings	4.06 avg	22,000–47,000	Ratings-to-readers multiplier: 10–20× for leadership books

Institutional & Network

Channel	Audience Size	Engagement Level	Notes
Exponential conference attendees (annual, cumulative)	Hundreds of thousands over career	High (paid registrants)	Flagship conference + regional events + international; 100+ networks served
NewThing network legacy (churches planted)	6,373+ churches in 47 countries	High (formal training relationships)	Merged into Exponential April 1, 2025
Exponential NEXT Podcast	Unknown listenership	Medium	106+ episodes, weekly cadence; institutional podcast
Community Christian Church	5,500+ weekly attendees, 7 locations	Very High (congregants)	Embodied audience; foundational to all his content
Institutional subtotal	Hundreds of thousands	Variable	Mostly institutionally owned, not personally owned

Digital Content (Personally Owned)

Channel	Audience Size	Engagement Level	Notes
Substack (daveferguson3.substack.com)	511 subscribers	Medium (for new publication)	Free only; launched ~Jan 2026; weekly cadence; awkward "3" URL suffix
Blog (daveferguson.org)	Unknown web traffic	Low	17 posts, 2015–2024; not primary content channel; replaced by Substack
Digital subtotal	~511+	Low-Medium	Severely under-developed as owned audience; primary owned channel very early stage

Engagement Levels Assessment

Most Engaging Content Types

Format	Engagement Level	Evidence
Exponential conference (live)	Highest	Paid registration; multi-day attendance; largest church-planting conference in the world
Books	Very High	2,300+ Goodreads ratings; 4.06 average; 7 audiobooks; broad endorsement network
Podcast guest appearances	High	15+ episodes; 3× on Carey Nieuwhof (indicates top-tier repeat guest status); consistent engagement across multi-year arc
Substack newsletter	Medium-High (per reader)	Weekly cadence; 511 subscribers; 1–4% like rate per post; 2–16 comments per post — healthy for a 4-month-old publication
Social media	Low-Moderate	Personal social used for amplification, not primary content; Exponential's organizational channels outperform his personal accounts in volume

Topics That Drive Engagement

Topic	Engagement	Platform	Evidence
Hero-making / permission-giving	Very High	Books, podcasts, conferences	Hero Maker (737 Goodreads ratings, 64 reviews); 4.02/5; Andy Stanley, Craig Groeschel endorsements
BLESS missional practices	Very High	Books, podcasts, church small groups	BLESS (500 ratings, 4.20/5); Carey Nieuwhof, Larry Osborne, Danielle Strickland endorsements; wide small-group adoption
Five-Level church typology / 16% Mission	High	Conferences, free eBooks, denominational training	Becoming a Level Five Multiplying Church distributed free through Exponential; widely cited by denominational leaders
Leader health / RPMS / drift prevention	Medium-High (growing)	Multiplier (2026), Substack, Global Leadership Network	Christine Caine, Craig Groeschel, Carey Nieuwhof endorsements of Multiplier; Global Leadership Network article on RPMS
Church planting / multiplication movement	High	Conferences, podcasts, books	Exponential's core mission; consistent podcast theme across 15+ appearances
Apprenticeship model / succession	Medium	Podcasts, unSeminary	Ted Coniaris succession story; workplaces.org transcript

Geographic Distribution

Region	Estimated Share	Evidence
US — Midwest (Chicago, greater Midwest)	25–30%	Community Christian Church base (Naperville, IL); Midwestern church planting network
US — Southeast / SBC heartland	20–25%	Exponential's strong SBC constituency; J.D. Greear (Summit Church, SBC) wrote Hero Maker foreword
US — South / Southwest / Texas	15–20%	Craig Groeschel (Life.Church, Edmond OK) endorser; Exponential draws broad southern evangelical audience
US — Northeast / Mid-Atlantic	10–15%	Exponential conference reaches all regions; WaterBrook books distributed nationally
US — West / Pacific Northwest	8–12%	NewThing network reach; Exponential West regional conference
International (UK, Europe, Australia, Canada)	5–8%	NewThing's 47-country footprint; European conference; Nicky Gumbel / HTB dinner (Twitter/X May 2026)
International (Global South: Africa, Asia, Latin America)	5–10%	NewThing planted churches in over 47 nations; Exponential International (launched 2025 post-merger)

Audience Overlap with Other Movemental Authors

Alan Hirsch — HIGH overlap

Dimension	Evidence
Co-authorship	Ferguson and Hirsch co-authored On the Verge (Zondervan, 2011); Hirsch endorsed Hero Maker and Multiplier
Shared framework	Both use APEST / Ephesians 4 framework; Ferguson integrates Hirsch's mDNA language throughout his Exponential work
Shared endorsement network	Hirsch endorses Multiplier; Ferguson runs the Exponential platform where Hirsch is a featured voice
Shared conference circuit	Both speak at Exponential; both connected to missional-church planting conversations
Shared free eBook	Becoming a Level Five Multiplying Church includes an Alan Hirsch chapter alongside Ferguson and Todd Wilson
Audience crossover	Estimated 40–60% of Ferguson's church-leader audience also engages Hirsch's work, particularly APEST. Hirsch provides the theological framework; Ferguson provides the practical deployment tools.

JR Woodward — MODERATE overlap

Dimension	Evidence
Shared conference	Both speak at Exponential; both in the missional church-multiplication conversation
Shared intellectual ecosystem	Woodward's V3 church planters operate in the same space as NewThing / Exponential; both engage Alan Hirsch's frameworks
Distinction	Woodward is academic-diagnostic (PhD in leadership failure, Powers theology); Ferguson is practical-motivational (five frameworks, numbered practices). Their audiences overlap but their entry points are very different.
Audience crossover	Estimated 20-35% overlap — primarily among church planters and movement-minded pastors who read broadly across the multiplication literature

Todd Wilson — HIGH overlap

Dimension	Evidence
Co-leadership	Ferguson and Wilson co-founded Exponential; Wilson is Ferguson's closest organizational partner
Co-authorship	Becoming a Level Five Multiplying Church (eBook, with Alan Hirsch chapter)
Shared framework	The Five-Level church typology is a joint Ferguson-Wilson framework
Audience crossover	Estimated 70-80% — these two leaders share essentially the same Exponential audience base

Neil Cole — MODERATE-LOW overlap

Dimension	Evidence
Shared multiplication vision	Both advocate decentralized multiplication and network-based church planting
Distinction	Cole is more radical (house church, no paid clergy as default); Ferguson's model is more institutionally structured (multi-site, large Exponential conference ecosystem)
Audience crossover	Estimated 15-25% — the organic/simple church audience partially overlaps with Ferguson's multiplication audience, but Cole's declining platform and different structural assumptions reduce overlap

Hugh Halter — MODERATE overlap

Dimension	Evidence
Shared BLESS/missional living space	Both advocate incarnational neighboring and everyday missional practice
Distinction	Halter is bivocational practitioner-storyteller; Ferguson is network CEO and conference convener
Audience crossover	Estimated 20–35% overlap on the missional living / BLESS content specifically; lower on the church-multiplication systems content

Comparison Table vs. Peers

Metric	Dave Ferguson	Alan Hirsch	JR Woodward	Neil Cole	Hugh Halter
Twitter/X followers	~22,700	~37,900	~15,800	Low-declining	Moderate
Goodreads total ratings	~2,300+	16,762+	~650	~3,000+	~2,000+
Books authored	10 trade + 8+ eBooks	15+	3 (+1 edited)	10+	7+
Audiobooks	7 confirmed	Multiple	0 confirmed	Multiple	Multiple
Conference owned/led	Exponential (world's largest)	None owned	Praxis Gathering (300+)	CMA events (smaller)	None
Church-planting network	NewThing (6,373+ churches) → Exponential	Forge (training)	V3 (1,000+ planters)	CMA (700+ US, 23 nations)	Lantern/Brave Cities (smaller)
Substack subscribers	511 (~4 months old)	Unknown	"Hundreds"	Unknown	Unknown
Personal YouTube	Channel exists; metrics unknown	Multiple org channels	No channel	Blog-declining	Moderate presence
Reach tier	Established (75K–150K personal; 250K+ with institutional)	Established (150K–200K)	Growing (25K–40K)	Medium-declining (15K–30K)	Medium (15K–30K)

Positioning Summary

Dave Ferguson's competitive advantage is not academic depth (that's Hirsch or Woodward) or prolific volume (that's Hirsch or Frost). It is **institutional infrastructure at maximum scale combined with practitioner credibility**. He co-founded the world's largest church-planting conference and personally oversaw a network that planted 6,373+ churches. When he writes about multiplication, he is not describing an ideal — he is reporting from three decades of building the largest multiplication infrastructure in North American evangelicalism. No other voice in the missional movement has this particular credential.

Movemental Audience Implications

- **Content format priority:** The Exponential conference and the books are the dominant format anchors. Ferguson's audience is practitioner-heavy and time-compressed — they want frameworks they can deploy in ministry next week, not long academic treatments. Online courses built around the Five-Level framework, the Hero Maker five practices, the BLESS framework, and the RPMS gauges would map directly onto what his audience already pays for (conference registration, book purchases, free Exponential eBooks they trade emails for).
- **Owned audience urgency:** This is Ferguson's most significant strategic gap relative to his stature. His personal Substack has 511 subscribers after 4 months. Exponential's newsletter list, conference registration database, and podcast audience are institutionally owned — if he left Exponential, he would not take that list. Movemental's highest-value contribution is helping Ferguson build an owned audience that is his personally, not Exponential's. The Substack URL problem (daveferguson3.substack.com — the "3" suffix is a permanent brand friction point) should be addressed on any new platform.
- **Cross-pollination with Alan Hirsch:** Ferguson's co-authorship of *On the Verge* with Hirsch, his integration of APEST language, and Hirsch's endorsement of *Multiplier* make these two the highest-value natural pairing on the platform. Hirsch provides the meta-framework; Ferguson provides the practical deployment. A co-produced "How to Build a Multiplying Church" learning track would serve both audiences and amplify each author's reach.
- **BLESS as a wider-market entry point:** The BLESS and *Finding Your Way Back to God* content reaches a significantly broader audience than Ferguson's church-leader content. These titles were published by WaterBrook (Penguin Random House) and aimed at the general Christian market. A Movemental-hosted BLESS digital study or video course could expand his reach into general-Christian consumer audiences well beyond the church-planter niche.

- **Monetization signal:** Strong. Ferguson's audience already pays: Exponential conference registrations are a paid product (hundreds of dollars per attendee), books across four publishers sell consistently, and audiobooks (7 titles) indicate a listening audience willing to consume his content in multiple formats. The audience is primarily professional church leaders and denominational executives with ministry budget access — they can expense training resources and conference registrations. This is not a budget-constrained audience; it is an underserved audience that will pay for structured, ongoing formation if the access mechanism exists.
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Sources

- Discovery research files: [digital-presence/social-media.md](#), [digital-presence/newsletters.md](#), [digital-presence/websites.md](#), [content/books.md](#), [content/audio.md](#), [network/organizations.md](#), [network/endorsements.md](#), [media/press-coverage.md](#)
- [Dave Ferguson on Goodreads](#)
- [Dave Ferguson on Audible](#)
- [Exponential — Person Page: Dave Ferguson](#)
- [Hero Maker Book Site](#)
- [BLESS Book Site](#)
- [Multiplier Book Site](#)
- [Carey Nieuwhof Leadership Podcast — CNLP 169, 415, 805](#)
- [Outreach Magazine — Dave Ferguson Archive](#)
- [Community Christian Church — About](#)
- [NewThing Has Joined Exponential](#)
- JR Woodward audience analysis (comparative reference): [../../jr-woodward/analysis/audience-analysis.md](#)

Websites

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/digital-presence/websites.md

Web Properties: Dave Ferguson

Status: Complete
Last updated: 2026-05-27
Researcher: Claude Code

Primary Website

Field	Value
Domain	daveferguson.org
Platform	Squarespace
Status	Active
Has Blog	Yes — archive of 17 posts (2015–2024); erratic cadence (two posts Oct/Nov 2024, then gap back to 2021)
Has Newsletter Signup	No dedicated email capture form; Substack link in main navigation
Has Store	No — book "Order Copy" buttons link to Amazon
Has Free Resource	Yes — free chapter download for B.L.E.S.S.
Key Pages	Home, Books, About Dave, Blog, Contact
Social Media Links	Facebook (@PastorDaveFerguson), Twitter/X (@daveferguson), Instagram (@fergusondave)
Color Scheme	Not audited in detail; clean/minimal professional feel

Site Structure

daveferguson.org functions as a personal author/leader hub. The homepage leads with three featured books (Multiplier, B.L.E.S.S., Hero Maker), a short bio, and links to the Substack newsletter (labeled "my latest thoughts"). Navigation is minimal: Home, Books, About Dave, Blog, Contact. The contact page has a freeform message form.

The blog archive is sparse — 17 posts total, most from 2015–2016, with a gap until 2021 (four posts) and then a further gap until October–November 2024 (two posts). The blog is not the primary content channel; the Substack newsletter has largely replaced it.

Most prominent CTA network: book purchase links (Amazon) and the Substack newsletter link. The website does not run its own email list or lead-magnet funnel.

Source: <https://daveferguson.org> (fetched 2026-05-27, confidence: High)

Content Inventory

Page	URL	Content Type	Notes
Home	daveferguson.org/	Landing	Bio, 3 featured books, Substack nav link, social icons
Books	daveferguson.org/books/ (inferred)	Book showcase	Multiplier, B.L.E.S.S., Hero Maker with Amazon + Learn More links
About Dave	daveferguson.org/about-dave	Bio / Credentials	Current roles, family details, "get in touch" CTA
Blog	daveferguson.org/blog	Article archive	17 posts, 2015–2024, Squarespace-hosted
Contact	daveferguson.org/contact	Contact form	General inquiry form; no mailing list join

Blog Post Archive (all 17 posts visible as of 2026-05-27)

Date	Title	Theme
2024-11-04	"A Simple Solution to Find More Church Planters"	Church multiplication
2024-10-21	"Europe: A Trip to the Future of the American Church"	Travel/vision
2021-03-11	"Looking Back..."	Reflection
2021-02-07	"3 Reasons Sharing Your Faith Shouldn't Be Awkward"	Evangelism
2021-01-15	"3 Ways To Love The Neighbor You Hate"	Missional living
2021-01-08	"The Incredible Power of Listening"	Leadership
2017-11-21	"My Prepared Notes for the Carey Nieuwhof Leadership Podcast"	Leadership/Podcast
2016-08-29	"6 Coaching Questions for Developing Leaders"	Leadership development
2016-08-24	"Proactively Starting Over"	Personal development
2015-12-31	"6 Questions for Discovering Your God-Given Possibilities"	Vision
2015-12-10	"9 Behaviors of a Multiplying Church"	Church multiplication
2015-11-28	"Exponential — Now Translated into German!"	Book news
2015-06-29	"Q&A with 'Teams That Thrive' Authors"	Interview
2015-06-03	"Foreword for 'Pioneering Movements' by Steve Addison"	Books
2015-04-17	"That's Exactly Why We Wrote 'Finding Your Way Back to God'"	Book promotion
2015-04-16	"'I Hated God for Taking My Father!'"	Spiritual story
2015-02-28	"'Finding Your Way Back to God' — Phase II: Delivery"	Book news

Source: <https://daveferguson.org/blog> (fetched 2026-05-27, confidence: High)

Book Companion Website

Field	Value
Domain	multiplierbook.com
Platform	Dedicated book promo site (CMS not confirmed)
Status	Active — launched 2025
Publisher	Zondervan Reflective (HarperCollins Christian Publishing)
Purpose	Standalone marketing hub for Multiplier: How Healthy Leaders Create Lasting Impact (2025/2026)
Email Capture	Yes — bonus-content registration requires name + email after purchase
Bonus Resources	Introduction, first chapter preview, R.P.M.S. tracking template + tutorial, webinar access, audiobook preview
Endorsers	Craig Groeschel, Christine Caine (among others)
Relationship to daveferguson.org	Independent domain; references daveferguson.org but operates separately

Source: <https://multiplierbook.com> (fetched 2026-05-27, confidence: High)

Institutional Websites

Exponential (exponential.org)

Field	Value
URL	exponential.org
Dave Ferguson's Role	Co-founder, CEO/President
Platform	Custom CMS / robust publishing stack
Email Capture	Yes — newsletter signup visible; conference registrations
Social Media	YouTube, Instagram, Facebook, Twitter
Dave Ferguson Content	Speaker profile at exponential.org/person/dave-f/ ; 20+ articles; podcast guest; 12 books listed
Key Features	Articles, books, NEXT Podcast (106+ episodes, active weekly), conference events (Global, Central, West, Orlando), resource kits, webinars
NewThing merger	NewThing (newthing.org) merged into Exponential as of April 1, 2025; newthing.org now 301-redirects to exponential.org/bettertogether/
Status	Active; primary institutional platform

Dave Ferguson co-founded Exponential and serves as CEO/President. The organization describes its mission as accelerating the multiplication of healthy, reproducing faith communities ("16% Mission"). His speaker/author profile aggregates his published articles, podcast appearances, and books. The NEXT Podcast (new episodes "every Wednesday") is the primary audio content channel, though Ferguson is not the sole or named host.

Sources: <https://exponential.org/about/> (fetched 2026-05-27), <https://exponential.org/person/dave-f/> (fetched 2026-05-27), <https://exponential.org/bettertogether/> (fetched 2026-05-27) — confidence: High

Community Christian Church (communitychristian.org)

Field	Value
URL	communitychristian.org
Dave Ferguson's Role	Co-Founding Pastor (transitioned from Lead Pastor to this role in 2025; day-to-day lead pastor is now Ted Coniaris)
Platform	Webflow
Locations	7 (Aurora, Carillon, Downers Grove, Lincoln Park, Naperville, Plainfield, Yorkville)
Email Capture	Yes — "Daily Devotional" registration; contact form (hello@communitychristian.org)
Social Media	Facebook (facebook.com/communitychristianchurch), Instagram (@cmmntycc), YouTube (@cmmntycc)
Sermon Archive	Yes — "Watch" section with teaching/sermon content
Dave Ferguson Ownership	Institutional — not personally owned; he co-founded it and remains Co-Founding Pastor

Sources: <https://communitychristian.org/about> (fetched 2026-05-27) — confidence: High

NewThing Network (newthing.org — NOW MERGED)

Field	Value
Former URL	newthing.org
Current Status	Dissolved as separate entity — 301 redirect to exponential.org/bettertogether
Merger Date	April 1, 2025
Dave Ferguson's Role	Founder (with brother Jon Ferguson); now absorbed into Exponential under his CEO role
Local expressions	Chicago, Kansas City, and Atlanta continue as church-planting networks under the Exponential umbrella

Source: <https://exponential.org/bettertogether/> (fetched 2026-05-27) — confidence: High

Publisher & Retail Presence

Platform	URL	Books Listed	Notes
Amazon Author Page	amazon.com/stores/author/B001JSE63Y	9+ titles	Primary retail; author ID B001JSE63Y
Goodreads	goodreads.com/author/show/126850.Dave_Ferguson	96 distinct works listed; ~3,045 total ratings; 4.06 avg	Includes co-authored works and editions
Zondervan Reflective	(within HarperCollins)	Multiplier (2025/2026)	Publisher for most recent title
Baker Books / WaterBrook Multnomah	(prior titles)	Multiple	Earlier titles (Hero Maker, BLESS, Finding Your Way)
Barnes & Noble	barnesandnoble.com (search: Dave Ferguson)	Multiple titles	Retail

Goodreads Book Ratings Detail

Title	Avg Rating	Ratings/ Reviews	Notes
Hero Maker	4.02	737 ratings	Co-author Warren Bird; most-rated title
B.L.E.S.S.	4.20	500 ratings	Co-author Jon Ferguson
Exponential	4.01	442 ratings	Co-author Jon Ferguson
Finding Your Way Back to God	4.05	172 ratings	Co-author Jon Ferguson
The Big Idea	3.66	173 ratings	Co-author Jon Ferguson
Starting Over	3.77	35 ratings	—
Discover Your Mission Now	4.04	26 ratings	—
Multiplier	Not yet rated (2026)	—	Newest title; Zondervan 2025/2026

Source: https://www.goodreads.com/author/show/126850.Dave_Ferguson (fetched 2026-05-27) — confidence: High

Conference & Speaker Profiles

Platform	URL	Role	Status
Exponential	exponential.org/person/dave-f/	CEO/President, Featured Speaker	Active — multi-year primary presence
Carey Nieuwhof Leadership Podcast	(guest, multiple episodes)	Guest	Historical/Active
Lewis Center for Church Leadership	churchleadership.com/author/ dave-ferguson/	Contributor	3 articles (2020–2021)
Outreach Magazine	outreachmagazine.com	Interview subject	Active (2024 interview)
Amplify Conference 2025	(Wheaton College)	Main session speaker	Active
Spire Conference 2025	(YouTube: "The Prayer That Changes Everything")	Speaker	Active

Ownership Classification Summary

Domain / Platform	Personal (Dave Owns)	Institutional	Notes
daveferguson.org	Yes	—	Personal brand site
multiplierbook.com	Shared (publisher-managed)	Partial	Tied to Zondervan deal; Ferguson gets email leads
exponential.org	No	Yes	He's CEO but org owns domain
communitychristian.org	No	Yes	He's Co-Founding Pastor but doesn't own
newthing.org	No	Dissolved	Merged into Exponential 2025
daveferguson3.substack.com	Yes	—	Personal newsletter; he owns the list

Publishing Platforms

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/digital-presence/platforms.md

Platform Presence: Dave Ferguson

Status: Complete
Last updated: 2026-05-27
Researcher: Claude Code

Platform Inventory

Personal / Owned Platforms

Platform	URL	Type	Status	Confidence
daveferguson.org	daveferguson.org	Personal website (Squarespace)	Active	High
Substack newsletter	daveferguson3.substack.com	Email newsletter	Active — weekly, ~511 subscribers	High
multiplierbook.com	multiplierbook.com	Book companion site (Zondervan)	Active	High
Twitter/X	x.com/daveferguson	Social — ~22,700 followers	Active	High
Instagram	instagram.com/fergusondave	Social — ~10,000 followers	Active	Medium
Facebook Page	facebook.com/PastorDaveFerguson	Social — ~9,300 followers	Active	Medium
YouTube (personal)	youtube.com/channel/UCr4AirrEAgHM_mIdcebNm-w	Video — subscribers UNKNOWN	Exists; activity unknown	Low
LinkedIn	linkedin.com/in/daveferguson/	Professional — followers UNKNOWN	Active	Medium

Institutional Platforms (Ferguson is CEO / primary face)

Platform	URL	Type	Status
Exponential	exponential.org	Conference + movement organization	Active — primary institutional platform
NEXT Podcast	exponential.org/exponential-next-podcast/	Podcast — 106+ episodes, weekly	Active — Apple Podcasts + Spotify
Community Christian Church	communitychristian.org	Church — 7 locations, sermon archive	Active
NewThing (merged)	newthing.org → redirects to exponential.org/bettertogether	Dissolved — merged April 2025	Redirect

Publisher & Retail Platforms

Platform	URL	Type	Status
Amazon Author Page	amazon.com/stores/author/B001JSE63Y	Retail	Active
Goodreads	goodreads.com/author/show/126850.Dave_Ferguson	Book discovery — ~11 followers	Active
Zondervan Reflective	(HarperCollins)	Publisher (most recent book)	Active

Third-Party Content Platforms

Platform	URL	Type	Status
Exponential articles	exponential.org/person/dave-f/	Articles (20+)	Active
Lewis Center for Church Leadership	churchleadership.com/author/dave-ferguson/	Articles (3)	Historical (2020–2021)
Logos Bible Software (Logos Live)	logos.com/grow/live-dave-ferguson-church-planting/	Video teaching	Active
Carey Nieuwhof Leadership Podcast	(multiple guest appearances)	Podcast guest	Historical / Active
Patheos (review)	patheos.com	Book review subject	Passive
Reimagine Network	reimagnenetwork.ning.com	Mini-course	Active

Not Found / Not Present

Platform	Status
Threads	No personal handle found
Bluesky	No personal handle found
TikTok	No personal handle found
Academia.edu	Not applicable (no academic affiliation)
Teachable / Thinkific / Udemy	No personal course platform found
Patreon / Ko-fi / Buy Me a Coffee	No personal giving platform found
Wikipedia	No Wikipedia article found for Dave Ferguson
Medium	No presence found
Substack (clean URL)	Not available — registered as daveferguson3.substack.com

Course & Training Platforms

Platform	URL	Courses	Status
Exponential Training	exponential.org	Webinars, resource kits, learning communities, cohorts	Active
Reimagine Network	reimaginenetwork.ning.com	"The Multiplier Interview" mini-course	Active
Logos Live	logos.com/grow/live-dave-ferguson-church-planting/	Video teaching on church planting	Active
Teachable / Thinkific / mainstream course platforms	N/A	No presence found	Not found

Podcast Directories

Platform	URL	Role	Status
Exponential NEXT Podcast	Apple Podcasts id1111784327; Spotify	Organizational podcast (Ferguson is CEO)	Active — 106+ episodes, weekly
Personal podcast	Not found	N/A	Does not host a personal podcast

Notable Guest Podcast Appearances

Podcast	Episode Notes	Platform
Carey Nieuwhof Leadership Podcast	Multiple appearances; "My Prepared Notes for the Carey Nieuwhof Leadership Podcast" (Nov 2017 blog post references it)	Apple Podcasts / Spotify
Stetzer ChurchLeaders Podcast	"Dave Ferguson: The Key Steps to Building a..." (2024)	Apple Podcasts
City Network Podcast	"Escaping the Paradigm: The 4 R's of Church Planting with Dave Ferguson"	Captivate.fm
Red Letter Challenge Podcast	"004: Dave Ferguson on Church Planting in America Today"	Web
unSeminary Podcast	"Everyday Ways to Help Your People Change the World with Dave & Jon Ferguson"	Web
PastorServe Podcast	"4 Habits for Healthy, Long-term Ministry: Dave Ferguson"	Web
Exponential Australia	"Ep. 45: HEROMAKERS — Dave Ferguson"	YouTube
Faith in a Fresh Vibe (adjacent)	Various; referenced in Exponential content ecosystem	Web

Ferguson is a sought-after podcast guest across the church leadership / church planting space but does not host his own personal podcast. The Exponential NEXT Podcast is the closest institutional equivalent.

Media & Publishing Platforms

Platform	URL	Type	Status
Substack	daveferguson3.substack.com	Newsletter / long-form	Active — primary personal content channel
Exponential blog	exponential.org	Articles	Active
daveferguson.org blog	daveferguson.org/blog	Blog (17 posts)	Sporadic — not primary channel
Outreach Magazine	outreachmagazine.com	Interview feature	Active (2024)
Medium	Not found	N/A	Not found
Patheos	Subject of review only	N/A	Passive

Giving / Support Platforms

Platform	URL	Status
Substack paid tier	Not available	Ferguson's Substack is free only
multiplierbook.com (book purchase)	multiplierbook.com	Active — book sales via Amazon, B&N, ChurchSource
Patreon	Not found	Not found
Buy Me a Coffee	Not found	Not found

Speaking Bureaus & Booking

Platform	URL	Status
Exponential speaker profile	exponential.org/person/dave-f/profile	Active — primary speaker identification page
Amplify Conference 2025	Wheaton College	Active — main session speaker
Spire Conference 2025	(YouTube: "The Prayer That Changes Everything")	Active
Dedicated speaking bureau	Not found	Booking likely via daveferguson.org contact form or Exponential directly
SpeakerHub / major agencies	Not found	Not found

Digital Presence Score: Dave Ferguson

Dimension	Score (1-5)	Notes
Website Quality	3.0	Squarespace site is clean and professional — a step above basic WordPress; three books showcased prominently; Substack linked in nav; free chapter download present. Gaps: no email capture form, no sermon/talk archive, blog is sparse (17 posts, erratic cadence). multiplierbook.com adds a second, well-designed touchpoint for the newest book.
Social Media Activity	3.5	X/Twitter (@daveferguson, ~22.7K) is the strongest personal platform and benefits from a premium clean handle secured in 2007. Instagram (~10K) and Facebook (~9.3K) provide solid supplementary presence. LinkedIn is active. YouTube personal channel exists but metrics are unknown and likely modest. No Threads/Bluesky/TikTok presence. Exponential org channels supplement significantly.
Content Freshness	3.5	Substack newsletter is active weekly (launched early 2026, ~12 posts in the archive fetched). Exponential NEXT Podcast is active weekly (106+ episodes). Website blog is sporadic (gap from 2021 to 2024). Newest book (Multiplier, Zondervan 2025/2026) keeps him in active publishing cycle. Exponential conferences (Global, Central, West 2026) keep him in active speaking cycle.
Platform Diversity	4.0	Strong spread: personal site + Substack + 4 confirmed social channels + Amazon/Goodreads/retail + major institutional platforms (Exponential, COMMUNITY) + podcast guest circuit + conference speaker profiles + book companion site + third-party course/media platforms (Logos, Reimagine Network). Gaps: no Wikipedia, no personal course platform, no academic platform.
Email / Newsletter	2.5	Substack exists (511 subscribers) and weekly cadence is a genuine commitment. However: (1) the URL daveferguson3.substack.com is awkward and signals lateness to platform; (2) no paid tier; (3) no email capture on daveferguson.org to funnel website traffic to the list; (4) institutional Exponential email list is not personally owned. The multiplierbook.com bonus registration is smart but limited to book buyers.
Discoverability (SEO)	3.5	Multiple strong SEO signals: clean X handle @daveferguson, LinkedIn vanity URL, Amazon author page, Goodreads, Exponential speaker profile, multiple podcast guest appearances indexed on web, active Substack, book review coverage (Patheos, Jeff McLain blog, 2026). Gaps: no Wikipedia article, Goodreads author page has only ~11 followers (very low engagement for author of 9+ books), blog on personal site is sparse and not a significant organic traffic driver.
Overall	3.3 / 5	A well-rounded but not exceptional digital presence. Ferguson's institutional leverage (Exponential CEO, COMMUNITY Co-Founding Pastor) gives him significant reach through org channels, but his personally-owned digital assets (website, newsletter, social) are modest relative to his influence, platform, and the scale of his institutional reach.

Score Interpretation

Dave Ferguson has a **broad institutional footprint with a developing personal content voice**. His influence is felt most strongly through:

- His **CEO/President role at Exponential** — the world's largest church planting conference organization, with 106+ podcast episodes, an active email list, conference events in multiple U.S. cities, and a growing international arm (Exponential International)
- His **published books** — 9+ books since 2007, most recently Multiplier (Zondervan, 2025/2026); Hero Maker remains the flagship brand (737 Goodreads ratings, 4.02 avg)
- His **Twitter/X presence** (@daveferguson, ~22.7K) — the most established personal social channel with a premium clean handle
- His **Substack newsletter** — newly launched (early 2026) but already at weekly cadence with 511 subscribers, showing intent to build a personal owned-audience channel separate from Exponential's institutional reach

The key structural vulnerability: a significant portion of his digital reach lives in institutional channels (Exponential's podcast, email list, social accounts) that he does not personally own. If his role at Exponential changed, his digital footprint would shrink considerably. His personally-owned assets (website, Substack, personal social) are currently insufficient to sustain that reach independently.

Key Gaps for Movemental to Address

1. **Substack URL problem** — daveferguson3.substack.com is an embarrassing URL for a leader of his stature; the "3" suffix undermines personal brand authority
2. **No email capture on daveferguson.org** — website visitors are sent to Substack but there is no native email capture; opportunity for a free lead magnet (PDF framework, self-assessment, mini-course) to drive list growth
3. **YouTube personal channel underdeveloped** — channel UCr4AirrEAgHM_mldcebNm-w exists but metrics are unknown and presumably modest; Ferguson's video content is scattered across Exponential's channel, COMMUNITY's @cmmntycc channel, and dozens of third-party conference recordings
4. **No Wikipedia article** — no Wikipedia page found for Dave Ferguson; a significant discoverability gap given his stature as a major conference president and bestselling author
5. **Institutional dependency** — too much of his digital reach (podcast, email, social) lives in Exponential org channels, not personally owned properties
6. **No personal podcast** — appears only as guest; lacks a dedicated channel for his voice and ideas
7. **Blog is effectively dead** — daveferguson.org blog has 17 total posts since 2015 and the newsletter is doing the work instead; the blog should either be retired/redirected or revived

8. **Facebook fragmentation** — two Facebook presences (@PastorDaveFerguson page + dave.ferguson personal) split following; needs consolidation around the page
9. **New platforms absent** — no Threads, Bluesky, or TikTok presence; depending on platform trajectory in 2026, this could become a meaningful gap
10. **Goodreads author engagement is near-zero** — ~11 Goodreads followers for an author with 3,045+ total ratings suggests he has never actively engaged the Goodreads community

Comparative Note (vs. JR Woodward)

Dimension	Dave Ferguson	JR Woodward
Twitter/X Followers	~22,700	~15,800
Instagram Followers	~10,000	Unknown (low)
Facebook Followers	~9,300	~6,300 (author page)
Substack Subscribers	~511 (4 months old)	"Hundreds" (~2025 launch)
Substack URL	daveferguson3.substack.com (awkward)	jrwoodward.substack.com (clean)
Goodreads Ratings	3,045+ (4.06 avg)	650 (4.25 avg)
Books Authored	9+ (some co-authored)	3 primary + forewords
Primary Platform	Exponential.org (institutional)	V3 Movement + personal site
Personal Website CMS	Squarespace (cleaner)	WordPress/Astra (basic)
Wikipedia	No	No
Academic Presence	None	Strong (PhD Manchester, Academia.edu, 4 adjunct roles)
Owned Audience	Substack 511 + Twitter 22.7K	Substack "hundreds" + Twitter 15.8K
Institutional Dependency	High (Exponential)	Moderate (V3 Movement)
Personal Podcast	No	No
Overall Score	3.3/5	3.3/5

Notable: Ferguson scores identically to Woodward overall (3.3/5) but for different reasons. Ferguson has larger social followings and stronger institutional machinery (Exponential is a larger organization than V3), while Woodward has stronger academic credibility, a cleaner Substack URL, and a more distinct newsletter voice. Ferguson's primary risk is institutional dependency — Woodward's primary risk is low discoverability. Both lack Wikipedia articles and personal podcasts.

Newsletters

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/digital-presence/newsletters.md

Newsletter & Email: Dave Ferguson

Status: Complete
Last updated: 2026-05-27
Researcher: Claude Code

Primary Newsletter

Field	Value
Platform	Substack
Newsletter Name	"Dave Ferguson" (no distinct publication title)
Subscribe URL	https://daveferguson3.substack.com/
Substack handle	@fergusondave (substack.com/@fergusondave)
Subscribers	511 (confirmed via search metadata, 2026-05-27)
Free/Paid	Free (no paid tier identified)
Frequency	Weekly — typically Sundays or Mondays
Launch	Approximately early 2026 (Substack page describes it as "launched 4 months ago" when fetched May 2026)
URL note	The Substack URL is daveferguson3.substack.com — the numeric suffix "3" indicates the clean URLs daveferguson.substack.com and daveferguson2.substack.com were already taken by other users before Ferguson registered

Content Focus

The newsletter covers leadership multiplication, church planting, organizational health, missional living, and spiritual encouragement — directly aligned with Ferguson's books (Multiplier, Hero Maker, B.L.E.S.S.) and his Exponential CEO role. Posts are practical and pastoral in tone: short-form leadership frameworks, theological reflection on movement growth, personal stories from travel and ministry, and calls to action for church planters.

The newsletter is an extension of his book-and-platform brand rather than a distinct content voice (compare with JR Woodward's "Faithful Resistance," which is an intentionally different and more politically-edged publication). Ferguson's Substack is more tightly aligned with his established thought-leader identity.

Recent Posts (March-May 2026)

Date	Title	Engagement
May 26	"When The People Who Hurt You Still Need You"	5 likes, 6 comments, 1 share
May 20	"ALWAYS ASK: The One Leadership Habit..."	5 likes, 4 comments, 1 share
May 4	"Unity Opens The Door — Why Are We Closing It?"	8 likes, 9 comments, 3 shares
Apr 27	"The Weight You Won't Name"	10 likes
Apr 20	"How To Reach 1,000 New People Without More Staff..."	20 likes, 4 comments, 2 shares
Apr 13	"Lead With a 'Yes'"	9 likes, 16 comments, 2 shares
Apr 6	"4 DECISIONS THAT SEPARATE MULTIPLIERS FROM MANAGERS"	7 likes, 3 comments, 2 shares
Mar 30	"D.R.E.A.M. — How To Rediscover Your God-Given Future"	6 likes, 4 comments, 1 share
Mar 23	"Why Church Planting Is NOT Optional"	5 likes, 6 comments
Mar 16	"20 Things I'm Looking Forward To Most at Exponential Global Conference"	5 likes
Mar 9	"The Data-Backed Case for an Unlikely Solution..."	5 likes, 2 comments, 1 share
Mar 2	"You Don't Drift Into Health — Especially Under Pressure"	3 likes, 2 comments, 1 share

Source: <https://daveferguson3.substack.com/archive> (fetched 2026-05-27) — confidence: High

Content Style

- Short-to-medium length posts (not long academic essays)
- Practical leadership frameworks: numbered lists, action steps, acronyms (D.R.E.A.M., etc.)
- Pastoral warmth combined with strategic urgency for church multiplication
- Consistent with Hero Maker / Multiplier book brand voice
- Engagement is modest: 5-20 likes per post; 2-16 comments per post — typical of a newsletter in its first few months with ~500 subscribers

- Posts appear to function partly as book-companion content and partly as Exponential organizational thought leadership

Website Email Capture

Field	Value
Newsletter signup on daveferguson.org	No dedicated email capture form identified
Substack link in navigation	Yes — "my latest thoughts" link points to daveferguson3.substack.com
Free lead magnet (email-gated)	Yes — free chapter of B.L.E.S.S. downloadable from daveferguson.org (not confirmed as email-gated; may be direct download)
multiplierbook.com email capture	Yes — bonus content suite (chapter preview, R.P.M.S. template, webinar, audiobook preview) requires name + email after purchase receipt
Email platform for website	Not identifiable — Squarespace does not expose this

Key gap: daveferguson.org does not run an independent email list. Visitors to his website are sent to Substack but there is no native email capture form, no mailing list CTA, and no free downloadable lead magnet that captures subscribers outside of Substack's ecosystem. The multiplierbook.com bonus content registration is the only confirmed email capture attached to his personal brand.

Exponential Newsletter (Institutional)

Dave Ferguson is CEO/President of Exponential, which runs its own email list (newsletter signup visible on exponential.org). This is an institutional list, not personally owned by Ferguson, but it represents a significant associated email reach in the church planting / church multiplication space.

Field	Value
Organization	Exponential
URL	exponential.org
Type	Conference + movement organization newsletter
Subscribers	Not publicly disclosed
Relationship to Ferguson	Institutional — he is CEO but does not personally own the list
Content	Conference news, resource launches, church planting content, Exponential NEXT Podcast updates

Podcast Presence (Audio Newsletters / On-Demand Content)

Dave Ferguson is not the named host of a personal podcast, but is associated with two institutional podcast properties:

Exponential NEXT Podcast

- **URL:** <https://exponential.org/exponential-next-podcast/>
- **Platform:** Apple Podcasts (id1111784327), Spotify
- **Episodes:** 106+ as of May 2026
- **Frequency:** Weekly ("New conversations every Wednesday")
- **Format:** Interview-based conversations on the future of the church with ministry and church leaders
- **Ferguson's role:** Organizational leader behind the podcast; appears as guest/host periodically; not the sole named host

Together Podcast (historical)

- Short series of episodes from Exponential (2020 conference season); Ferguson appeared in at least one episode discussing what it means to work together as a church. This series appears to be archival rather than ongoing.

Hero Maker Podcast (historical)

- Short series tied to the Hero Maker book launch (2017–2018); hosted on exponential.org. Covered the five hero-making practices. Not ongoing.
-

Contributing to Other Publications

Publication	URL	Type	Status
Exponential blog	exponential.org/person/dave-f/	Organization blog	Active — 20+ articles
Lewis Center for Church Leadership	churchleadership.com/author/dave-ferguson/	Contributor	3 articles (2020–2021)
Outreach Magazine	outreachmagazine.com	Interview / contributed	Active — 2024 interview
Patheos (via review)	patheos.com	Subject of review	Passive — Multiplier reviewed April 2026
Reimagine Network	reimagnenetwork.ning.com	Mini-course contributor	Active — "The Multiplier Interview" mini-course
unSeminary	unseminary.com	Guest interview	Historical — Ferguson brothers on BLESS
Red Letter Challenge	redletterchallenge.com	Podcast / article guest	Historical

Observations

1. **Substack is active but young** — 511 subscribers after ~4 months of operation is a reasonable start, but well behind peers: JR Woodward ("hundreds," also newer) is similar scale; Alan Hirsch had 1,500+ on a more established Substack
2. **URL fragmentation is a problem** — daveferguson3.substack.com is an awkward URL; the "3" suffix signals that Ferguson was late to claim his primary Substack handle; the clean jrwoodward.substack.com or alanhirsch.substack.com equivalents weren't available when he signed up
3. **No personal email list outside Substack** — the personal website sends readers to Substack rather than capturing email addresses directly; this creates platform dependency
4. **multiplierbook.com is the best-functioning email capture** — the bonus-content registration after book purchase is smart book-launch email capture, but it only works for buyers of Multiplier
5. **Weekly cadence is strong** — posting every Sunday/Monday is a consistent, sustainable rhythm that signals commitment to the channel
6. **Engagement per post is low** — 5–20 likes on ~511 subscribers = ~1–4% like rate per post; commenting is present (2–16 per post) which is a healthy signal for a new publication
7. **Content brand consistency** — the newsletter voice is directly continuous with his books and Exponential mission; no audience confusion about who this is for

8. **No paid tier** — unlike JR Woodward's \$10/month Substack option, Ferguson has not introduced a paid tier; this may reflect the newsletter's newness or a deliberate free-access strategy
9. **Institutional vs. personal** — the Exponential newsletter/podcast infrastructure is his most significant email/audio reach, but it is institutionally owned; if Ferguson left Exponential, he would not take that list
10. **Gap: no free lead magnet funnel** — no downloadable resource (PDF framework, mini-course, assessment) linked to an email capture on daveferguson.org to grow the Substack organically

Social Media

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/digital-presence/social-media.md

Social Media: Dave Ferguson

Status: Complete

Last updated: 2026-05-27

Researcher: Claude Code

Account Summary

Platform	Handle	Followers	Posts/ Content	Frequency	Last Active	Confidence	Status
Twitter/X	@daveferguson	~22,700	N/A	Periodic (several/ month)	Active 2025–2026	High	Active
Instagram	@fergusondave	~10,000	Unknown	Unknown	Active (per site)	Medium	Active — follower count visible in search metadata
Facebook (Page)	@PastorDaveFerguson	~9,300–9,349	Regular	Periodic	Active	Medium	Active — two FB pages exist (see notes)
Facebook (Personal)	dave.ferguson	~9,349 likes / 9.3K followers	—	—	Active	Medium	Personal profile / overlapping data in search results
LinkedIn	linkedin.com/in/ daveferguson/	UNKNOWN — not visible	N/A	Periodic	Active	Medium	Active — posts confirmed 2025
YouTube (personal)	UCr4AirrEAgHM_mIdcebNm- w	UNKNOWN — needs research	UNKNOWN	UNKNOWN	Unknown	Low	Channel confirmed to exist; metrics not retrievable
Threads	Not found	—	—	—	—	Low	No presence identified in search results
Bluesky	Not found	—	—	—	—	Low	No presence identified in search results
TikTok	Not found	—	—	—	—	Low	No presence identified in search results
Goodreads	goodreads.com/author/ show/ 126850.Dave_Ferguson	~11–12 followers	96 works listed	N/A	Active	High	Author profile; low

Platform	Handle	Followers	Posts/ Content	Frequency	Last Active	Confidence	Status
							follower engageme

Estimated combined personal followers (confirmed platforms only): ~42,000–42,700 (X: 22,700 + Instagram: 10,000 + Facebook: ~9,300 + Goodreads: ~12). YouTube and LinkedIn not included due to unknown counts. This is a conservative floor; actual reach is higher when institutional org channels (Exponential, COMMUNITY) are included.

Platform Details

Twitter/X — @daveferguson

- **URL:** <https://x.com/daveferguson>
- **Display Name:** Dave Ferguson
- **Handle:** @daveferguson (clean, primary-name vanity URL; no numeric suffix)
- **Followers:** ~22,700 (confirmed via search metadata, 2026-05-27)
- **Joined:** November 2007
- **Location listed:** Chicago / Naperville, Illinois
- **Headline bio** (from search results): CEO & President of Exponential, Co-Founding Pastor at COMMUNITY, award-winning author of Hero Maker, B.L.E.S.S., Multiplier
- **Content style:** Leadership insights, church planting, travel reflections, Exponential conference promotion, book promotion, spiritual encouragement
- **Engagement:** Moderate for niche Christian leadership space
- **Recent post sample** (May 2026): Post about trip to London and Oxford — "11 days in Europe... dinner with Sarah & Tom Jackson, lunch with Nicky & Pippa Gumbel, a lecture by N.T. Wright and others."
- **Notable:** The handle @daveferguson is a highly desirable, clean handle — secured early (2007). Posts blend global travel, leadership theology, organizational updates.

Source: <https://x.com/daveferguson> (search metadata, 2026-05-27) — confidence: High

Instagram — @fergusondave

- **URL:** <https://www.instagram.com/fergusondave/>
- **Handle:** @fergusondave
- **Followers:** ~10,000 (confirmed via search metadata showing "10K followers")
- **Linked from:** daveferguson.org (footer + navigation)

- **Content style:** Not directly verified via live fetch (Instagram blocked image rendering); likely visual personal/leadership content consistent with his other platforms
- **Notable:** The handle is @fergusondave (reversed name order) rather than @daveferguson. This is the only platform where the name is reversed — may reflect handle availability in early Instagram era. The account is confirmed active and linked from the official website.

Source: <https://www.instagram.com/fergusondave/> (search metadata, 2026-05-27) — confidence: Medium (follower count from search engine metadata, not direct page fetch)

Facebook — @PastorDaveFerguson (Page) and dave.ferguson (Personal)

- **Page URL:** <https://www.facebook.com/PastorDaveFerguson/>
- **Personal URL:** <https://www.facebook.com/dave.ferguson/>
- **Followers / Likes:** Search results consistently report ~9,300–9,349 followers/likes; it is unclear whether this count refers to the @PastorDaveFerguson page or the dave.ferguson personal profile, or is an aggregate — both URLs appear in search results
- **Linked from:** daveferguson.org navigation uses @PastorDaveFerguson handle
- **Content types:** Leadership insights, Exponential conference news, book promotions, personal reflections
- **Notable:** Two Facebook presences (professional page @PastorDaveFerguson + personal profile dave.ferguson) create a split following, which is a common but suboptimal pattern. The personal website links to @PastorDaveFerguson, suggesting that is the primary public-facing page. Dave Ferguson's Facebook following (~9.3K) is lower than his X following (~22.7K), and similar to Instagram (~10K).

Source: <https://www.facebook.com/PastorDaveFerguson/> and <https://www.facebook.com/dave.ferguson/> (search metadata, 2026-05-27) — confidence: Medium

LinkedIn — linkedin.com/in/daveferguson/

- **URL:** <https://www.linkedin.com/in/daveferguson/>
- **Headline** (from search): CEO & President of Exponential. Co-Founding Pastor at COMMUNITY, Award-winning author of books like Hero Maker & B.L.E.S.S.
- **Followers:** Not publicly visible (LinkedIn requires login); UNKNOWN — needs research
- **Content activity:** Active posts confirmed — recent post congratulating Community Christian Church on 36 years (visible in search snippet); older posts about Hero Maker, NewThing
- **Vanity URL:** Clean — linkedin.com/in/daveferguson/ (no numeric suffix)

- **Notable:** Professional positioning is strong. Posts tend toward organizational milestones and book promotion rather than original thought leadership. LinkedIn is not his primary personal-brand platform but serves professional credibility.

Source: <https://www.linkedin.com/in/daveferguson/> (search metadata, 2026-05-27) — confidence: Medium

YouTube — Personal Channel (UCr4AirrEAgHM_mldcebNm-w)

- **Channel URL:** https://www.youtube.com/channel/UCr4AirrEAgHM_mldcebNm-w
- **Channel ID:** UCr4AirrEAgHM_mldcebNm-w (provided in research brief)
- **Subscribers:** UNKNOWN — not retrievable via web fetch (YouTube blocks non-authenticated scraping)
- **Video count:** UNKNOWN — needs direct investigation
- **Content themes** (inferred from third-party videos): Church planting, leadership multiplication, Exponential conference talks, BLESS framework, micro-church/meta-church concepts
- **Last upload date:** UNKNOWN — needs research
- **Notable:** The channel exists as a personal YouTube presence separate from the Exponential organizational channel. Subscriber count and upload frequency are not publicly visible from search results. Videos featuring Ferguson on third-party channels include: "The Quiet Revival: Why Gen Z Is Coming Back to Church," "Church Planting Secrets Every Entrepreneur Needs," "The Prayer That Changes Everything" (Spire Conference 2025), and Exponential Australia podcast (Ep. 45).

Source: https://www.youtube.com/channel/UCr4AirrEAgHM_mldcebNm-w (confirmed via search, 2026-05-27); metrics UNKNOWN — confidence: Low for subscriber/view data

Threads, Bluesky, TikTok

- **Status:** No personal handles found on any of these platforms after multiple targeted searches
 - **Confidence:** Low — absence of results does not guarantee absence of accounts, but no links appear on his website or in search results
 - **Recommendation:** Manual check on each platform for @fergusondave and @daveferguson handles
-

Institutional / Organizational Social Channels

Dave Ferguson is the CEO and primary face of Exponential and Co-Founding Pastor of Community Christian Church. These organizational accounts extend his reach:

Organization	Platform	Handle	Status
Exponential	YouTube	Confirmed active	Active — primary video content hub
Exponential	Instagram	Active	Active
Exponential	Facebook	Active	Active
Exponential	Twitter/X	Active	Active
Community Christian Church	Instagram	@cmmntycc	Active
Community Christian Church	Facebook	facebook.com/communitychristianchurch	Active
Community Christian Church	YouTube	@cmmntycc	Active

Exponential's NEXT Podcast is on Apple Podcasts and Spotify (106+ episodes as of May 2026, new episodes "every Wednesday") — this is the primary institutional audio presence where Ferguson's voice and vision appear.

Cross-Platform Observations

1. **Primary platform:** Twitter/X (@daveferguson, ~22,700) is the largest personal social account and the most strategically used
2. **Clean handle advantage:** @daveferguson on X and LinkedIn is a premium handle (joined 2007); @fergusondave on Instagram is the only reversed-name outlier
3. **Facebook split:** Two FB presences (@PastorDaveFerguson page + dave.ferguson personal) creates audience fragmentation; website links to the page, which is the better choice
4. **Instagram:** 10K followers is solid but growth and posting frequency are unverified — appears active but not a primary investment platform
5. **YouTube gap:** Personal channel exists (UCr4AirrEAgHM_mldcebNm-w) but subscriber count and upload cadence are unknown; most video content lives on Exponential's channel, not his personal one
6. **New platforms absent:** No confirmed Threads, Bluesky, or TikTok presence — notable gap as these platforms grow
7. **LinkedIn credibility:** Active but primarily organizational updates, not personal thought leadership content

8. **Institutional amplification:** Exponential's multi-channel social presence (YouTube NEXT Podcast, Instagram, Facebook, Twitter) provides substantial supplementary reach beyond his personal accounts
9. **Goodreads minimal:** ~11-12 Goodreads author followers is low for an author with 9+ books and 3,045+ total ratings; suggests readers don't connect through this platform

The Fragmentation Story

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/fragmentation-story.md

Dave Ferguson: The Fragmentation Story

Generated 2026-05-27 by the `fragmentation-story` skill from existing research in `docs/movement_leader_research/dave-ferguson/`.

The Story

Dave Ferguson has been planting churches and multiplying leaders for **more than 35 years**. On **March 5, 1989**, he and his brother Jon gathered five college friends in the cafeteria of Naperville Central High School and held the first service of **Community Christian Church** — a community founded to help people "find their way back to God." It became one of the earliest **multi-site churches** in America (its Romeoville campus launched in the late 1990s, before "multisite" was a recognized category) and grew to roughly **5,500 weekly attendees across seven Chicago-area locations**. In **2001** he launched **NewThing**, a church-planting network that grew to plant **6,373+ churches across nearly 70 nations** (982 in 2020 alone) before it merged into Exponential in 2025. As co-founder and **CEO/President of Exponential**, he convenes the **largest church-planting conference in the world**, organized around what he calls the **"16% Mission"** — moving the share of multiplying U.S. churches from roughly 7% to a 16% cultural tipping point.

He has written **ten trade books** across nearly two decades, from *The Big Idea* (Zondervan, 2007) through the movement vision of *Exponential* (2010) and *On the Verge* (2011, with **Alan Hirsch**), the redefined metrics of *Keeping Score* (2014), the relational evangelism of *Finding Your Way Back to God* (2015) and *B.L.E.S.S.* (2021), the flagship *Hero Maker* (2018, with Warren Bird, foreword by **J.D. Greear**), and his 2026 turn inward toward leader health, *Multiplier*. His frameworks — the **five hero-making practices**, the **BLESS** rhythm, the **Five Levels of a multiplying church**, **ICNU** conversations, the **five-step apprenticeship** ladder — have become working vocabulary for tens of thousands of church planters. In 2021 Lincoln Christian University gave Dave and Jon its highest alumni honor, the Restoration Award.

In 2025 he did what most leaders only write about. He folded NewThing into Exponential under the banner **"Kingdom over Castle,"** and after an **eighteen-month public apprenticeship** he handed the Lead Pastor role at Community Christian to **Ted Coniaris** and stepped back to Co-Founding Pastor — a lived case study of the succession theology he had taught for years.

And here is where the fragmentation becomes visible. For a leader of this institutional stature, **almost none of his reach is personally owned**. His most-read books are distributed and his conference audiences are convened through **Exponential** — which owns the conference

email list, the podcast feeds, and the free-ebook channel through which most of his content actually travels. His **personal owned audience** is strikingly thin: roughly **511 Substack subscribers** on an awkward `daveferguson3.substack.com` URL, **~42,000 social followers** with no email pathway behind them, a small personal blog on `daveferguson.org` with **no email capture at all**, and a **personal YouTube channel that exists but is essentially undeveloped**. There is **no Wikipedia article** for the president of the world's largest church-planting conference. The gap between the embodied and institutional influence on one side and the personally owned digital expression on the other is among the widest in the corpus — not because the work doesn't exist, but because the work lives on rails Dave doesn't own.

Informational Fragmentation

Books

Ten full trade books (1989-era ministry through 2026), plus a deep shelf of Exponential eBooks/workbooks and two forewords:

1. **The Big Idea** (with Jon Ferguson & Eric Bramlett) — Zondervan, **2007** — Leadership Network Innovation Series. Goodreads 3.66/173. Audiobook yes.
2. **Exponential** (with Jon Ferguson) — Zondervan, **2010** — anchor of the Exponential Series. Goodreads 4.01/442. Audiobook yes.
3. **On the Verge** (with Alan Hirsch) — Zondervan, **2011** — apostolic-future framework. Goodreads 3.98/177. Audiobook yes.
4. **Discover Your Mission Now** (with Jon Ferguson & Tim Sutherland) — Missio Publishing, **2012** — five missional practices; distributed free via Exponential. Goodreads 4.04/26.
5. **Keeping Score** — Exponential, **2014** — free eBook on church metrics. Goodreads 3.89/9.
6. **Finding Your Way Back to God** (with Jon Ferguson) — WaterBrook, **2015** — Five Awakenings. Goodreads 4.05/172. Audiobook yes.
7. **Starting Over** (with Jon Ferguson) — WaterBrook/Multnomah, **2016** — life beyond regret. Goodreads 3.74/34. Audiobook **status unconfirmed**.
8. **Hero Maker** (with Warren Bird; foreword J.D. Greear) — Zondervan, **2018** — flagship; five practices. Goodreads 4.02/737. Audiobook yes.
9. **B.L.E.S.S.** (with Jon Ferguson) — Salem Books, **2021** — five neighboring practices. Goodreads 4.20/500 (his highest). Audiobook yes.
10. **Multiplier** — Zondervan Reflective, **March 2026** — RPMS / leader-health framework; **self-narrated** audiobook. Goodreads rating not yet available.

Plus ~8 Exponential eBooks/workbooks (Becoming a Level Five Multiplying Church; The Legacy of a Hero Maker; Together: The Great Collaboration; Good, Great, Greater; the 5-part Lost Cause evangelism workbook series with Rick Richardson) and **forewords** to Steve Addison's *Pioneering Movements* (IVP, 2015) and Peyton Jones's *Discipology* (Zondervan, 2026).

The books sit on **separate Amazon and publisher product pages across four publishers** (Zondervan, WaterBrook/PRH, Salem/Regnery, Exponential Resources). There is no single surface where a reader who finds Hero Maker can walk into Multiplier, the Five-Level framework, or the conference content built on the same ideas.

Academic Work

- **No doctorate** (earned or honorary). BA, Bible & Communications, **Lincoln Christian University, 1986** (verified). MA, Educational Ministries / Church Planting, **Wheaton College Graduate School, 1991** (baseline; year not independently confirmed — MEDIUM).
- **Adjunct Professor**, Wheaton College Graduate School (Evangelism and Leadership) — ongoing; **no public syllabi or course content**.
- **No peer-reviewed publications** — he is a practitioner-author. One academic journal review of his work confirmed (Journal of Adventist Christian Leadership, on The Legacy of a Hero Maker).
- Citation influence runs through **DMin dissertations, seminary syllabi, and Exponential's free-ebook distribution** rather than a personal scholarly profile.

PDFs & Documents

- **Exponential free eBooks and PDF workbooks** — Keeping Score, Discover Your Mission Now, Together, the Lost Cause workbook series — distributed through exponential.org, **not aggregated under Dave's own name**.
- **CCC and NewThing internal materials** — apprenticeship guides, network playbooks, the Five-Level diagnostic content — **UNKNOWN public availability**; likely institutional.
- **Conference session decks / handouts** — across 15+ years of Exponential — **not personally archived**.

Articles

- **daveferguson.org blog** — active but modest (on the order of ~17 posts observed); content overlaps his books.
- **Outreach Magazine** — author archive with 10+ features/interviews (2007–2025), his deepest press relationship.
- **Christianity Today / CT Pastors** — contributor author archive (titles behind paywall).
- **Global Leadership Network** — author page with leadership/hero-making articles.
- **Verge Network** — historical articles + teaching (network now dissolved).
- These live on **at least five third-party platforms he does not own**; none cross-link back to a personal hub.

Blogs & Personal Writing

- **daveferguson.org** blog (small).
- **Substack** at daveferguson3.substack.com — ~511 subscribers, free only, and on a URL whose 3 suffix undermines credibility. This is his only owned-list asset and it is underbuilt.

Websites

Owned / personal

- **daveferguson.org** — Squarespace; blog, books, about, contact; **no email capture**.
- Book microsites: **heromakerbook.org**, **bless-book.org**, **multiplierbook.com** (the last captures emails for buyers, but as a Zondervan asset).

Organizations founded

- **Community Christian Church** — communitychristian.org
- **NewThing** — newthing.org now **301-redirects to exponential.org/bettertogether** (merged April 1, 2025)
- **Exponential** — exponential.org (the channel that owns most of his reach)

Academic

- **Wheaton College Graduate School** — adjunct

Social Media

Platform	Handle / URL	Status
Twitter/X	@daveferguson	Active, ~22.7K
Instagram	@fergusondave	Active, ~10K
Facebook	facebook.com/dave.ferguson (also a @PastorDaveFerguson page)	Active, ~9.3K
LinkedIn	linkedin.com/in/daveferguson	Active (count requires login)
YouTube	channel UCr4AirrEAgHM_mldcebNm-w	Active but undeveloped

Combined ~42,000 followers — **none of it connected to an owned email list**.

Newsletters / Email

- **Personal newsletter**: Substack daveferguson3.substack.com, ~511 subscribers, free only, awkward URL.
- **No email capture on daveferguson.org**.
- The **Exponential newsletter** (large) is institutionally owned, not Dave's personal list.

Podcasts (Hosted)

- **Hero Maker Podcast** (2017-18, co-hosted with Todd Wilson) and the **Together Podcast** (2020) — both **campaign-series podcasts on Exponential's feed**, not a long-running personal show.

Podcasts (Guest)

- **15+ confirmed guest appearances**, including **three** on the Carey Nieuwhof Leadership Podcast (CNLP 169, 415, 805) — rare repeat-guest status — plus workplaces.org, churchleaders.com, churchleadership.com, unSeminary, and others. **Scattered across host feeds with no personal aggregation.**

YouTube & Video

- **Personal channel exists but is essentially undeveloped.**
- **80-120+ videos estimated** across Exponential Digital Access Passes, NewThing, CCC, and conference channels — **gated and institutionally owned.**
- RightNow Pastors+ course "Measure What Matters" (gated).

Courses

- **Exponential Multipliers Learning Communities** (cohort-based, institutional).
- **Hero Maker webinar series** (2017-18, across 8 denominations/networks).
- **RightNow Pastors+** video courses.
- **No self-hosted course** (Teachable/Thinkific/Kajabi) under his own name. His most-deployed frameworks — Hero Maker, Five Levels, BLESS — have **no personal digital course expression.**

Assessments & Tools

- **None personally owned.** The Five-Level "what level is your church?" diagnostic is a natural assessment instrument — but no interactive tool exists.

Notes, Laptop, Unpublished

- **UNKNOWN — almost certainly large.** 35+ years of sermons and teaching at CCC; NewThing network playbooks and apprenticeship design; Exponential conference content; the design rationale behind the 16% Mission; the Ted Coniaris succession process documentation.

Embodied / In Their Head

- The **judgment behind multiplication** — which leaders to apprentice, which campuses to launch, which networks to back — formed across 35 years and largely undocumented.
- The "**Kingdom over Castle**" **merger decision** — how and why he dissolved his own network into Exponential.
- The **eighteen-month succession** with Ted Coniaris — a lived apprenticeship case study most leaders never capture.
- The **relational architecture of NewThing** — how a network-of-networks model actually reproduces across ~70 nations.

Relational Fragmentation

Organizations

Founded / co-founded:

- **Community Christian Church** — Co-Founding (and former Lead) Pastor, 1989-present
- **NewThing** — Founder/Visionary, 2001-April 2025 (merged into Exponential)
- **Exponential** — Co-founder & CEO/President, ~2006-present

Board / network / academic ties:

- **Leadership Network** — mentee of co-founder **Bob Buford** ("Bob taught me what it meant to be a hero maker")
- **Verge Network** (historical), **Global Leadership Network** (contributor)
- **Wheaton College Graduate School** — adjunct
- **Christian Standard / independent Christian Churches** — Restoration Movement affiliation
- **Stadia East** — listed in older bios; current status unconfirmed (Jon Ferguson is the confirmed board member)

Co-authors & Collaborators

- **Jon Ferguson** — brother; co-founder of CCC; co-author on the majority of his books
- **Alan Hirsch** — On the Verge co-author; Multiplier endorser; intellectual peer
- **Warren Bird** — Hero Maker co-author (Leadership Network research)
- **Todd Wilson** — Exponential co-founder; Five-Level / Legacy of a Hero Maker collaborator
- **Patrick O'Connell** — Together co-author; led NewThing; Executive Director of Practice at Exponential post-merger
- **Eric Bramlett** — The Big Idea co-author; CCC colleague
- **Rick Richardson** — Lost Cause workbook series
- **Ted Coniaris** — apprentice and successor as CCC Lead Pastor (May 2025)

Endorsement / Network Layer

- **Received** (~24 named endorsers): J.D. Greear (foreword), Mike Breen (foreword), Andy Stanley, Craig Groeschel, Mark Batterson, Ed Stetzer, Carey Nieuwhof, Christine Caine, Matt Chandler, Jennie Allen, Derwin Gray, Albert Tate, Scot McKnight, Danielle Strickland, and more — a who's-who of evangelical leadership.
- **Given**: forewords to Steve Addison (Pioneering Movements) and Peyton Jones (Discipology); endorsement for Addison & Jones's Acts and the Movement of God.

Where Relationships Are Actually Stored

- **Exponential back-end** — the conference attendee and email lists; the single largest relational store, **institutionally owned**.
- **NewThing network records** (now inside Exponential) — networks and planters across ~70 nations.
- **Community Christian Church** — campus and apprentice relationships, including 35 years of congregation.
- **Mental rolodex** — decades of relationships with planters, network leaders, and co-authors.
- **No unified personal CRM** surfaced.

Synthesis

Dave Ferguson's fragmentation signature is unusual in the corpus: **his embodied and institutional influence is enormous and well-organized — inside institutions he built — while his personally owned digital layer is the thinnest part of his footprint**. He runs the world's largest church-planting conference, but the conference owns his email list, his podcast feeds, and the channel through which his free ebooks travel. His most-deployed frameworks (Hero Maker, Five Levels, BLESS) have no personal course or assessment expression. His ten books sit across four publishers with no connective hub. His ~42K social following has no email pathway behind it, his only owned list is ~511 free Substack subscribers on a credibility-undermining URL, and his YouTube presence is undeveloped despite 80–120+ videos scattered across institutional channels. The largest trapped value is not missing content — it is the **absence of any owned surface** that lets a reader who discovers Hero Maker walk into the whole body of work, and that lets the leaders he has formed stay connected to him rather than to the institutions that introduced them. For the leader who coined "Kingdom over Castle," the irony is sharp: the castle that holds his reach is one he doesn't personally own.

Research Provenance

- **Source folder**: docs/movement_leader_research/dave-ferguson/

- **Files read:** README.md, profile/identity.md, profile/biography.md, content/books.md, content/audio.md, digital-presence/social-media.md, digital-presence/newsletters.md, digital-presence/platforms.md, network/organizations.md, network/collaborators.md, network/endorsements.md, analysis/gap-analysis.md, analysis/movemental-fit.md, plus the Jan 2026 baseline flat files.
- **Confidence: High** for identity, organizations, bibliography (10 trade books with publishers/ISBNs/ratings), frameworks, the 2025 NewThing→Exponential merger and CCC succession, and network/endorsement layer. **Medium** for some social-metric specifics, the Wheaton MA year (1991), and birth year (c. 1962). **Low/Unknown** for personal YouTube metrics, full early-title endorser lists, Stadia East current status, and the CCC sermon-archive volume.
- **Gaps requiring further research:** Wikipedia absence; verified point-in-time social counts; personal YouTube metrics; CCC sermon archive inventory; full endorser lists for The Big Idea and Exponential; current Stadia East status; specifics of the Wheaton MA.

A Letter — Reflected Understanding

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/reflected-understanding/dave-ferguson.md

Dave Ferguson: Reflected Understanding

A concise reflection spoken back so the language could be endorsed — familiar, but with edges that deepen. (Leader-safe: audience-sizing and commerce analysis are kept in staff notes, not here.)

Calling

You're called to **make heroes, not be one**. For more than three decades — from a high school cafeteria in Naperville in 1989 to a network that reached across dozens of nations — you've held one conviction with remarkable consistency: the mission of Jesus is a multiplication mission, and the church advances not by growing larger but by reproducing disciples, leaders, groups, churches, and networks at every level. Your own language carries this. "My fruit grows on other people's trees." "I'm the platform; I'm not the show." "As a leader, you reproduce who you are." That last line is doing real theological work — it makes a leader's inner health a kingdom issue, not a private one, which is exactly why Multiplier turns the multiplication question inward before it turns it outward.

Your calling is to invert the hero-pastor model that the American church quietly worships. Where that culture prizes platform, you prize permission giving; where it counts attendance and budget, you count disciples made and leaders released. The ICNU conversation — "I see in you" — is the small, repeatable act at the center of it: you name what God has already placed in someone before they can see it themselves, then you walk them through apprenticeship until they can do the same for someone else. You learned this from your own mentors and from watching your father plant a church, and you've made it teachable. None of this is theory for you. The 2025 succession at Community Christian — Ted Coniaris moving through an eighteen-month apprenticeship into the lead role while you stepped back to Co-Founding Pastor — was you living the five steps you wrote down. "Kingdom over Castle," the principle behind folding NewThing into Exponential the same year, is the same calling at organizational scale: structures should be subordinate to mission, even when the structure is yours.

Existing Content (before the platform we're building)

Where it lives. Your content lives in **books** (nine-plus trade titles across Zondervan, WaterBrook, and Salem, from The Big Idea in 2007 to Multiplier in 2026, plus a shelf of Exponential resources and free eBooks), in **three organizations you built** (Community

Christian Church, the NewThing network, and Exponential — now unified), in **conference platforms** (Exponential's national and regional events, Exponential International), in **per-book sites** (heromakerbook.org, bless-book.org, multiplierbook.com), and across **personal channels** (daveferguson.org and an active blog, a Substack, plus Instagram, YouTube, Facebook, X, and LinkedIn). You also teach at Wheaton's graduate school and write for outlets like Christianity Today's pastors platform and the Global Leadership Network.

Credibility. It's high. You're a benchmark practitioner voice in church multiplication: a church recognized repeatedly among the most influential in America, a planting network that reached dozens of countries, the world's largest church-planting conference, frameworks that pastors actually use — BLESS, Hero Maker, the five-level typology — and a string of well-reviewed books. The issue was never authority. It's **visibility, connection, and reuse**.

How it lives online now. As **silos**. Hero Maker lives on its own site; BLESS on another; Multiplier on a third. Your sermons and Exponential talks live where they were delivered. The blog, the Substack, the social channels, and the institutional sites each hold a slice, but there is no single place where "everything Dave has taught about multiplication, hero making, and neighboring" is structured, linked, and easy to find. So the content doesn't **move** the way your frameworks do — it stays where it was first put.

The NOTs this platform addresses directly. Your content is largely **not** repurposed across forms — sermons and conference talks rarely become findable articles, and book themes rarely become courses or guided journeys; **not** interconnected, so Hero Maker, BLESS, the apprenticeship model, and the five-level typology don't visibly reference and build on each other; **not** connected to an AI that reflects your voice and your corpus so leaders can ask it questions in your language; **not** optimized for discoverability, so people searching for "how to multiply leaders," "church multiplication," "hero maker," or "how to share faith with neighbors" don't reliably land on your material first; and **not** owned and unified under one surface you control, separate from the three book sites and the institutional domains. The platform is built to speak to each of these — structure and repurpose, interconnection, a voice-faithful AI, discoverability, and a single owned home — so your content can move the way your movements do.

Constraints

Movement leaders carry **time** and **money** constraints that are emblematic, not personal failure. You are leading a unified Exponential, teaching, coaching, still on the Community Christian team, writing, and speaking — and the merger year added a layer of integration work on top of all of it. Time for content strategy — for turning a talk into an article, a book chapter into a course, a framework into a guided journey — is scarce precisely because the work is in the room with planters, apprentices, and networks. You've spent a career insisting that your fruit grows on other people's trees; the same instinct that makes you a hero maker makes it hard to stop and tend your own published corpus. The desire to reach everyone God

has given you is plainly there; the hours to structure, translate, and amplify everything you've already said, in every format, typically are not. Those constraints shape every content decision — what gets recorded, what gets written down, what becomes a course. A platform that reduces the lift — that helps structure, repurpose, connect, and amplify what you already do — meets those constraints without asking you to become a different kind of leader.

This document is a reflected understanding for Dave Ferguson, intended to be right to the point, true, and valuable. It is preliminary until reviewed and endorsed.

Welcome Letter

`docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/welcome-letter.md`

Dave

You have built one of the most consequential bodies of work in North American church multiplication, and almost none of it is yours to reach. On March 5, 1989, you and Jon started Community Christian Church with five friends in a high school cafeteria; it became one of the first multisite churches in the country and a community of roughly 5,500. In 2001 you launched NewThing, which planted more than 6,300 churches across nearly seventy nations. You co-founded Exponential and made it the largest church-planting conference in the world. Across nearly two decades you wrote ten books — from *The Big Idea* through *Exponential* and *On the Verge* with Alan Hirsch, through *Finding Your Way Back to God* and *B.L.E.S.S.*, to *Hero Maker*, the book that gave a generation of leaders the language of permission-giving and multiplication, and now *Multiplier* in 2026. And in 2025 you did the thing you have taught for years: you folded NewThing into Exponential under "Kingdom over Castle," and you handed Community Christian's lead role to Ted Coniaris after an eighteen-month apprenticeship. You didn't just write the succession; you ran it.

All of it is somewhere. Almost none of it is in one place that belongs to you. *Hero Maker* sits on its own Zondervan product page and on heromakerbook.org; *B.L.E.S.S.* on a Salem page and bless-book.org; *Multiplier* on a Zondervan page and multiplierbook.com; *Finding Your Way Back to God* on WaterBrook; the free titles — *Keeping Score*, *Discover Your Mission Now*, *Together*, the *Lost Cause* workbooks — on Exponential's resource shelf. Four publishers, a dozen product pages, three book microsites, and no single surface where a reader who finishes *Hero Maker* can walk into the Five-Level framework, the BLESS practices, or *Multiplier*. Your articles are on Outreach, on Christianity Today, on the Global Leadership Network, on the old Verge site. Your talks are inside fifteen years of Exponential session archives. Your two podcasts were campaign series on Exponential's feed, and your fifteen-plus guest appearances — three of them with Carey Nieuwhof — live on other people's shows. There is a personal YouTube channel that is essentially empty, a personal blog with no way to capture an email, and a Substack at daveferguson3.substack.com with about five hundred free subscribers and a URL that undercuts the man who runs the world's largest planting conference. There is no Wikipedia page. The pattern is unmistakable: the reach is real and enormous, and it runs almost entirely on rails Exponential owns, not rails you own.

The relational layer fragments the same way, and more painfully, because relationship is your whole thesis. Exponential holds the conference email list and the attendee history. NewThing's records — networks and planters across seventy nations — now sit inside Exponential too. Community Christian holds thirty-five years of congregation and the apprentices you formed. The leaders you have personally raised up, the planters you have coached, the network heads you recruited — they are connected to the institutions that introduced them, not to you. You

coined "Kingdom over Castle" to describe giving up a structure for the sake of the mission. The irony is that the castle holding your reach is one you don't personally own, and the people you formed can't find their way back to you without an institution in between.

The largest pool of value, and the one most at risk of going uncaptured, is in your head. The judgment behind multiplication — which leader to apprentice, which campus to launch, which network to back, when to merge and when to wait — has shaped tens of thousands of churches and is written down almost nowhere. The reasoning behind "Kingdom over Castle," the actual mechanics of the eighteen-month handoff to Ted, the relational architecture that let NewThing reproduce across nine world regions — these are the things planters most need and the things least likely to make it into a book. Your own frameworks prove the point: Hero Maker, the Five Levels, BLESS, ICNU, the apprenticeship ladder — each is a teachable system, and not one of them has a course, an assessment, or a practitioner community under your name. The "what level is your church?" question your framework already answers has no tool to answer it.

This is where Movemental's AI does work that was not previously possible. The inventory just walked through — your ten books, the free Exponential shelf, the articles across five platforms, the podcasts, the network relationships, the frameworks without homes — was compiled by AI sitting with your public corpus for the time it would have taken a researcher weeks. The same approach now turns toward what isn't captured yet: AI-assisted interview capture of the merger and succession rationale, course-building from the Hero Maker and Five-Level material you already teach, an interactive Five-Level diagnostic that works the way Hirsch's APEST assessment works, email capture that finally turns forty thousand followers into a list that is yours. The AI does the inventorying and the connective tissue. It does not replace your voice; every draft is yours to edit, refuse, or rewrite. Authorship stays yours — which is the whole point, because right now authorship is the one thing the institutions can't hold for you.

A year from now, daveferguson.org looks different. There is a multiplication hub that gathers Hero Maker, Multiplier, the Five Levels, and the BLESS practices into one place, cross-linked so a reader who arrives for one leaves with the whole system. There is an interactive "what level is your church?" assessment that denominational leaders share and pastors argue about, and it feeds an email list that belongs to you, not to a conference. There is a Hero Maker course built from the teaching you already do, and a practitioner community that extends the conference experience across fifty-two weeks instead of three days. The Substack has a real address and a reason to subscribe. A church planter in a city you've never visited finds the hub on a Tuesday, takes the assessment over lunch, starts the Hero Maker course that week, and writes you on Friday — and this time the message comes to you.

This is your next season. The work ahead is not more content; you have more than almost anyone. It is making the body of work you already built reach the planters it was written for, on a surface that is yours. You spent a career teaching leaders to stop being the hero and start being the platform. The one place that lesson hasn't been applied is your own digital life, where the platform belongs to someone else. Let's fix that.

Committed Voice

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/_misc/committed-voice.md

slug: dave-ferguson

display_name: Dave Ferguson

role: CEO & President, Exponential · Co-Founding Pastor, Community Christian Church

location_line: Naperville, Illinois (Chicago area)

short_tagline: >-

Practitioner of multiplication who turned one suburban church plant into a global movement and made "hero making" the working language of church-planting leadership.

themes:

- Leadership Multiplication
- Reproducing Churches
- Missional Neighboring

credentials:

- CEO & President and co-founder, Exponential — the world's largest church-planting conference and resource network
- Co-Founding Pastor, Community Christian Church — a Chicago-area multi-site community of ~5,500 he started in a high school cafeteria in 1989
- Founder and visionary of NewThing — a network that planted 6,373+ churches across ~70 nations before merging into Exponential in 2025
- Author of 10 trade books, including the flagship Hero Maker (Zondervan, 2018) and Multiplier (2026)
- Adjunct Professor, Wheaton College Graduate School (Evangelism and Leadership)

featured_works:

- Hero Maker — Five Essential Practices for Leaders to Multiply Leaders (with Warren Bird, Zondervan, 2018)
- Exponential — How You and Your Friends Can Start a Missional Church Movement (with Jon Ferguson, Zondervan, 2010)
- On the Verge — A Journey Into the Apostolic Future of the Church (with Alan Hirsch, Zondervan, 2011)
- B.L.E.S.S. — 5 Everyday Ways to Love Your Neighbor and Change the World (with Jon Ferguson, Salem, 2021)
- Multiplier — How Healthy Leaders Create Lasting Impact (Zondervan Reflective, 2026)

primary_url: <https://daveferguson.org>

secondary_links:

- label: Exponential

href: <https://exponential.org>

- label: Community Christian Church

href: <https://www.communitychristian.org>

- label: Hero Maker (book site)

href: <https://heromakerbook.org>

- label: Substack

href: <https://daveferguson3.substack.com>

signature_frameworks:

- name: Hero Maker — Five Practices

definition: The shift from being the hero to making others the hero of God's story, expressed in five practices — Multiplication Thinking, Permission Giving, Disciple Multiplying, Gift Activating, and Kingdom Building. His central leadership framework.

- name: BLESS

definition: Five everyday practices for missional neighboring — Begin with prayer, Listen, Eat, Serve, and tell your Story — designed as a natural, non-programmatic alternative for sharing faith.

- name: Five Levels of a Multiplying Church

definition: A diagnostic scale (co-developed with Todd Wilson and Alan Hirsch) for locating where a church sits on the spectrum from subtraction and survival up to Level 5 multiplication, used widely as a church-health instrument.

- name: ICNU & the Apprenticeship Model

definition: "I see in you" affirmation conversations paired with a five-step apprenticeship ladder ("I do, you watch · I do, you help · you do, I help · you do, I watch · you do, someone else watches") — his core mechanism for reproducing leaders.

- name: The 16% Mission

definition: Exponential's organizing goal — moving the share of reproducing/multiplying U.S. churches from roughly 7% to a 16% cultural tipping point where movement dynamics take hold.

- name: RPMS / Multiplier

definition: The framework of his 2026 book, locating sustainable multiplication in leader health across spiritual, relational, physical, and mental gauges — "you reproduce who you are."

lineage:

sources:

- Restoration Movement / independent Christian Churches

- Bob Buford

- Alan Hirsch

- Leadership Network

peers:

- alan-hirsch

- neil-cole

- jr-woodward

- hugh-halter

- Jon Ferguson

- Todd Wilson

downstream:

- Exponential conference and learning-community network
- NewThing church-planting networks (now within Exponential)
- Community Christian Church campuses and apprentices (incl. successor Ted Coniaris)

sources:

- README.md
 - profile/biography.md
 - profile/identity.md
 - profile/voice-analysis.md
 - content/books.md
 - network/organizations.md
 - analysis/movemental-fit.md
- research_completed_at: 2026-05-27
- generated_at: 2026-05-27
-

Editorial bio

Dave Ferguson has spent more than three decades proving a single conviction: the church is built to multiply, not merely to add. On March 5, 1989, he and his brother Jon gathered five college friends in the cafeteria of Naperville Central High School and started Community Christian Church; it grew into one of the earliest multi-site churches in America and a Chicago-area community of roughly 5,500. In 2001 he launched NewThing to carry the reproducing-church vision beyond his own campuses, and it grew into a network that planted thousands of churches across some seventy nations. As co-founder and CEO of Exponential, he convenes the largest church-planting gathering in the world.

His books trace that conviction maturing in public — from church-strategy method (*The Big Idea*, 2007) through movement vision (Exponential, 2010; *On the Verge*, 2011, with Alan Hirsch) and redefined metrics (*Keeping Score*, 2014), to the relational evangelism of *Finding Your Way Back to God* (2015) and *B.L.E.S.S.* (2021), to his defining work on leadership, *Hero Maker* (2018, with Warren Bird), and his 2026 turn toward sustainable leader health, *Multiplier*. Along the way he built a toolkit of named, teachable frameworks — the five hero-making practices, the BLESS rhythm, the Five Levels of a multiplying church, ICNU conversations, the apprenticeship ladder, and the "16% Mission" — that thousands of planters now use as common language.

In 2025 he did what most leaders only write about. He folded NewThing into Exponential under the banner "Kingdom over Castle," and after an eighteen-month public apprenticeship he handed the Lead Pastor role at Community Christian to Ted Coniaris and stepped back to Co-Founding Pastor — a lived demonstration of the succession theology he had taught for years. Colleagues describe him as the operator to Alan Hirsch's theologian: the practitioner who takes apostolic vision and turns it into a system a church can actually run. "My fruit grows on other people's trees," he likes to say. "I'm the platform; I'm not the show."

Sources

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/sources.md

Sources: Dave Ferguson Research

Research Date: January 4, 2026

Agent Version: Digital Reality Agent v1.0

Search Queries Used

Phase 1: Identity Verification

1. "Dave Ferguson" Christian pastor
2. "Dave Ferguson" author movement
3. "Dave Ferguson" church planter
4. Dave Ferguson Community Christian Church
5. Dave Ferguson Exponential church planting
6. "Dave Ferguson" "Hero Maker" book
7. Dave Ferguson NewThing Network
8. Dave Ferguson website blog
9. site:daveferguson.org
10. Dave Ferguson books Amazon Goodreads
11. Dave Ferguson YouTube videos sermons
12. Dave Ferguson podcast appearances interviews

Sources Consulted

Websites

- daveferguson.org (personal website - referenced in search results)
- yourwayback.org (referenced in search results - related to "Finding Your Way Back to God")

Social Media

- Instagram: @fergusondave

Search Engines Used

- Google (primary)
- Additional engines to be used: Bing, DuckDuckGo (for diversity)

Information Sources

Identity Verification

- Personal website (daveferguson.org)
- Search engine results referencing:
- Community Christian Church affiliation
- NewThing Network leadership
- Exponential Conference presidency
- Published books

Published Works

- "Hero Maker: Five Essential Practices for Leaders to Multiply Leaders"
- "B.L.E.S.S.: 5 Everyday Ways to Love Your Neighbor and Change the World"
- "Finding Your Way Back to God"

Research Methodology

- Used context-specific search terms aligned with Movemental's target audience
- Focused on Christian movement leadership context
- Cross-referenced multiple search results
- Visited personal website (daveferguson.org) via browser
- Documented all sources consulted
- Maintained respect for publicly available information only

Research Limitations

1. **Initial Research Phase:** This represents comprehensive initial research. Further investigation could include:
 - Detailed blog content analysis (post count, themes, engagement)
 - Complete sermon/teaching catalog from Community Christian Church
 - Complete conference talk catalog from Exponential
 - Social media engagement metrics
 - Newsletter presence verification
2. **Content Volume:** Specific counts for blog posts, sermons, and talks to be verified through direct platform access
3. **Platform-Specific Details:** Some platform-specific features and analytics not accessible without direct access

Next Steps for Source Verification

1. Direct website visits to verify content
2. Platform-specific searches (YouTube, podcast directories)
3. Book retailer verification (Amazon, Goodreads)
4. Social media platform exploration
5. Cross-referencing institutional websites

Research Methodology

- Used context-specific search terms aligned with Movemental's target audience
- Focused on Christian movement leadership context
- Cross-referenced multiple search results
- Documented all sources consulted
- Maintained respect for publicly available information only

Notes

- Research conducted in accordance with agent constraints
- Only publicly available information used
- All sources documented for transparency
- Respectful approach maintained throughout

Digital Presence Discovery

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/_misc/digital-presence-discovery.md

Digital Presence Discovery: Dave Ferguson

Research Date: January 4, 2026

Website Presence

Primary Website

- **daveferguson.org**
- Status: Active
- Purpose: Personal brand, content distribution, book promotion
- Structure: Includes About, Blog, Book pages, Contact
- Content: Blog posts, book information, speaking engagements
- Social Media Links: Facebook, Twitter/X, Instagram

Institutional Websites

- **Community Christian Church** (communitychristian.org)
- Multi-site church website
- Likely contains sermons, teaching content, church resources
- **NewThing Network** (newthing.org)
- International church-planting movement website
- Resources, network information, movement content
- **Exponential Conference** (exponential.org)
- Conference website
- Conference talks, resources, speaker content
- Dave Ferguson listed as President/CEO

Social Media Platforms

Confirmed Active Presence

- **Instagram:** @fergusondave
- Status: Active
- Platform type: Visual content, personal updates
- Linked from personal website

Indicated Presence (from website)

- **Facebook:** Link present on website
- **Twitter/X:** Link present on website (may be inactive or limited)

To Be Verified

- LinkedIn profile
- YouTube channel(s) - personal vs. institutional

Publishing Platforms

Books

- **Multiple Published Books:** 9+ books published 2007-2025
- **Publishers:** Various (Zondervan, Multnomah, WaterBrook Multnomah mentioned)
- **Amazon Author Page:** To be verified
- **Goodreads:** To be verified

Known Publications

1. "The Big Idea" (2007)
2. "Exponential: How You and Your Friends Can Start a Missional Church Movement" (2010)
3. "On The Verge" (2011)
4. "Discover Your Mission Now" (2012)
5. "Keeping Score" (2013)
6. "Finding Your Way Back to God" (2015) - Co-authored with Jon Ferguson
7. "Starting Over"
8. "Hero Maker: Five Essential Practices for Leaders to Multiply Leaders"
9. "B.L.E.S.S.: 5 Everyday Ways to Love Your Neighbor and Change the World"

Content Forms Discovered

Books

- 9+ published books spanning 2007-2025
- Focus areas: Leadership, missional living, church planting, spiritual journey

Blog Content

- **daveferguson.org/blog:** Active blog section
- Content type: Articles/blog posts

- Volume: To be assessed
- Topics: To be analyzed

To Be Discovered

- Sermons/talks (audio, video, transcripts) - likely on Community Christian Church website
- Conference talks/presentations - likely on Exponential website
- Courses/training materials
- Podcasts (as host or guest)
- Video content (YouTube, Vimeo, institutional)
- Newsletter content
- Social media content volume and engagement

Platform Distribution

Confirmed Platforms

1. Personal website (daveferguson.org) - Active blog
2. Instagram (@fergusondave) - Active
3. Facebook - Link present
4. Twitter/X - Link present

Platforms to Verify

- Blogging platforms: Personal blog on daveferguson.org (WordPress-based likely)
- Video platforms: YouTube, Vimeo (personal or institutional channels)
- Audio platforms: Podcasts (Apple Podcasts, Spotify) - as host or guest
- Course platforms: Teachable, Thinkific, institutional LMS
- Newsletter platforms: Mailchimp, ConvertKit, Substack
- Academic platforms: Not likely applicable
- Ministry platforms:
- Community Christian Church website (sermons, teaching)
- NewThing Network website (resources, training)
- Exponential Conference website (talks, presentations)

Content Volume Assessment

Known Content

- **Books:** 9+ published books (2007-2025)
- **Blog:** Active blog section on personal website

- **Social Media:** Active Instagram presence
- **Institutional Content:**
- Sermons/teaching (Community Christian Church)
- Conference talks (Exponential)
- Movement resources (NewThing)

To Be Assessed

- Number of published blog posts/articles
- Number of sermon/talk series
- Video content volume (sermons, conference talks)
- Podcast episodes (as host or guest appearances)
- Content frequency/recency
- Newsletter subscription base (if applicable)
- Social media engagement metrics

Content Discovery Notes

Personal Website (daveferguson.org)

- Clean, professional design
- Clear navigation: Book, Blog, About, Contact
- Social media integration
- Book promotion focus
- Blog section present and active

Institutional Content

- Community Christian Church: Multi-site church with likely extensive sermon/teaching library
- Exponential Conference: World's largest church planting conference - extensive talk/presentation library
- NewThing Network: Movement resources and training materials

Content Ecosystem

- Personal brand (daveferguson.org) connects to institutional platforms
- Books support and are supported by institutional work
- Conference leadership provides speaking platform
- Movement leadership provides content distribution network

Discovery Status

Status: Initial discovery complete, deeper investigation needed

Confidence: Medium-High (core platforms identified, content volume to be assessed)

Next Steps

1. Analyze blog content on daveferguson.org (count posts, identify themes)
2. Verify and catalog sermon/teaching content on Community Christian Church website
3. Catalog conference talks on Exponential website
4. Search for YouTube channel(s) - personal or institutional
5. Search for podcast appearances or hosting
6. Verify book listings on Amazon and Goodreads
7. Check for newsletter presence (Mailchimp, ConvertKit, Substack)
8. Identify any course or training materials
9. Assess social media engagement and content volume

Notes

- Established digital presence with personal website and active blog
- Strong institutional backing (church, movement, conference)
- Multiple content distribution channels
- Books provide significant content volume
- Institutional platforms likely contain extensive teaching/speaking content
- Personal brand well-integrated with institutional presence
- Recent transition (2025) may affect content distribution patterns

Misc · Analysis-Content-Analysis

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/_misc/analysis-content-analysis.md

Content Analysis: Dave Ferguson

Status: Complete

Last updated: 2026-05-27

Executive Summary

Dave Ferguson's body of work is one of the most coherent and practically impactful in the North American church-multiplication movement — a 19-year arc of writing (2007–2026) that moves from ecclesial strategy to everyday mission to leader formation, all in service of one overriding conviction: the mission of Jesus is a multiplication mission, and the church fulfills it not by accumulating attendance but by reproducing disciples, leaders, groups, churches, and networks at every level. His distinctive contribution is not academic depth (that belongs to Alan Hirsch or JR Woodward) but **operational theology at scale** — frameworks forged in the actual building of a 5,500-person multi-site church, a 6,373-church global network, and the world's largest church-planting conference. Ferguson is the practitioner who proved the multiplication vision is not just theoretically compelling but organizationally executable. His writing is framework-dense, accessible, acronym-anchored, and relentlessly motivational — built for practitioners who need tools they can deploy in a board meeting next Tuesday, not concepts they can contemplate over a semester.

Theme Map

Primary Themes (Core to their identity)

Theme	Description	Key Works	Centrality
Multiplication over accumulation	The church's mission is reproduction, not growth. Level 3 (growing) is not the same as Level 4-5 (reproducing, multiplying). "Church growth is good but it's only good if it leads to multiplication, which is best."	Exponential (2010), Hero Maker (2018), Becoming a Level Five Multiplying Church, Multiplier (2026)	10
Hero-making leadership	The leader's primary calling is to make heroes of others, not to be the hero. Shift from addition thinking (I grow the church) to multiplication thinking (I grow leaders who grow the church). "My fruit grows on other people's trees."	Hero Maker (2018), Exponential (2010), Substack (2026), podcast appearances	10
Reproducible frameworks for everyday Christians	The multiplication vision must extend beyond pastors and professionals to every believer. BLESS democratizes mission; Finding Your Way Back to God democratizes evangelism. Every Christian is sent.	BLESS (2021), Finding Your Way Back to God (2015), Discover Your Mission Now (2012)	9
Apprenticeship as discipleship	The five-step Jesus-shaped apprenticeship model is the mechanism of multiplication at every level: disciple making, leader development, church planting, movement building. "I do, you watch, we talk" through to "You do, someone else watches."	Hero Maker (2018), Exponential (2010); embodied in Ted Coniaris succession (2025)	9
Network and kingdom collaboration	The kingdom advances through interconnected networks, not isolated congregations. The Great Commission + Great Commandment + Great Collaboration = the fullness of Jesus's mission. "Kingdom over Castle."	Together (2020), NewThing model, Exponential merger (2025)	8

Secondary Themes (Recurring but not defining)

Theme	Description	Key Works	Centrality
Kingdom metrics vs. church metrics	Most churches measure attendance, budget, and buildings. The kingdom scorecard tracks disciples made and leaders released. Redefining winning for a reproducing church.	Keeping Score (2014), Hero Maker (2018)	8
Leader health as multiplication prerequisite	Only healthy leaders are worth multiplying. "You reproduce who you are and what you do." The RPMS gauges (Relational, Physical, Mental, Spiritual) are a daily diagnostic against the Drift Trio (the world, the flesh, the devil).	Multiplier (2026)	8
Permission giving and ICNU culture	The most powerful thing a leader can give is a "yes." ICNU ("I see in you") — calling out potential in others before they see it themselves — is the mechanism of permission giving. Without permission, potential leaders never discover their God-given mission.	Hero Maker (2018), exponential.org content	7
Missional neighboring (BLESS)	Five practices — Begin with prayer, Listen, Eat, Serve, Share — for organic neighbor engagement. God is already at work in every neighbor before the Christian arrives. Mission is not an event but a way of life embedded in existing relational networks.	BLESS (2021)	7
The Big Idea / creative collaboration	One laser-focused teaching theme per week, aligned across all church ministries through creative collaboration. Counters "idea overload" and creates multiplied impact from unified messaging.	The Big Idea (2007)	6
The 16% Mission	Currently ~7% of US churches are multiplying; reaching a tipping point where 16% are reproducing/multiplying would generate movement dynamics across the broader culture.	Exponential mission statement; Becoming a Level Five Multiplying Church	6

Emerging Themes (Recent or developing)

Theme	Description	Evidence	Direction
Leader sustainability and drift prevention	Multiplier (2026) adds a formation-interiority dimension to his multiplication theology that is new: it is not enough to multiply — you must first be healthy and worth multiplying. Drift is the enemy of long-term kingdom impact.	Multiplier (2026), Global Leadership Network RPMS article, Substack content	Deepening — this is his most personally searching writing to date; represents an evolution from ecclesial strategy to character formation
The quiet revival / Gen Z return	Observations from global travel (Europe trip, May 2026) and conference conversations about a new generation's spiritual openness. Possibly exploring what multiplication looks like in a post-secular return moment.	Twitter/X posts (May 2026); "The Quiet Revival: Why Gen Z Is Coming Back to Church" video content	Exploratory
International multiplication	The NewThing-Exponential merger created Exponential International, leveraging NewThing's 47-country relationships. Ferguson's global thinking is expanding from North American-centric to explicitly international.	Post-merger Exponential International launch (2025); London/Oxford travel (May 2026)	Emerging

Named Frameworks & Models

Framework	Source	Components	Type
Five-Level Church Typology	Becoming a Level Five Multiplying Church (eBook, with Todd Wilson and Alan Hirsch)	Level 1: Declining; Level 2: Plateaued; Level 3: Growing; Level 4: Reproducing; Level 5: Multiplying (movement-generating). Currently ~7% of US churches at Level 4+; 16% Mission targets a tipping point.	Diagnostic framework
Five Practices of Hero Makers	Hero Maker (2018, with Warren Bird)	1. Multiplication Thinking; 2. Permission Giving (ICNU conversations); 3. Disciple Multiplying; 4. Gift Activating; 5. Kingdom Building.	Leadership culture model
ICNU (I See in You)	Hero Maker (2018)	The practice of naming and affirming leadership potential in others before they see it in themselves. Jesus's posture toward the Twelve. Ferguson credits Dennis Gamauf's ICNU conversation to him at summer camp as formative.	Permission-giving mechanism
Five-Step Apprenticeship Model	Exponential (2010), Hero Maker (2018)	(1) I do, you watch, we talk; (2) I do, you help, we talk; (3) You do, I help, we talk; (4) You do, I watch, we talk; (5) You do, someone else watches. Applied in Ferguson's own succession (Ted Coniaris, 18-month process, 2025).	Discipleship/succession model
BLESS (Five Missional Practices)	BLESS (2021, with Jon Ferguson)	Begin with prayer; Listen; Eat; Serve; Share. Designed for every Christian, not just professional ministers. Rooted in Genesis 12:2 blessing language.	Everyday mission framework
Five Awakenings	Finding Your Way Back to God (2015, with Jon Ferguson)	(1) Awakening to Longing; (2) Awakening to Regret; (3) Awakening to Help; (4) Awakening to Love; (5) Awakening to Life. Drawn from the Parable of the Prodigal Son.	Spiritual journey framework
The Big Idea	The Big Idea (2007, with Jon Ferguson and Eric Bramlett)	One teaching theme per week, unified across all ministries (preaching, children, small groups, social media) through creative collaboration. Counters idea overload.	Church communication strategy
The Great Collaboration	Together (2020, with Patrick O'Connell)	Great Commission (Go) + Great Commandment (Love) + Great Collaboration (Together) = the inseparable fullness of Jesus's mission. Network collaboration is theologically necessary, not strategically optional.	Movement theology
RPMS (Leader Health Gauges)	Multiplier (2026)	Relational, Physical, Mental, Spiritual — four gauges for daily leader health monitoring. Drawn from Luke 2:52 (Jesus grew in wisdom [mental], stature [physical], favor	Leader formation system

Framework	Source	Components	Type
		with God [spiritual], favor with people [relational]). Journaling-based, rated 1–10 daily.	
The Drift Trio	Multiplier (2026)	Three forces that cause leader drift: (1) The World (empty values); (2) The Flesh (disordered desires); (3) The Devil (spiritual adversary). Drift is incremental and unconscious: "leaders drift one day at a time."	Diagnostic / cautionary framework
Six Permission-Giving Levels	Hero Maker framework	Spectrum from (1) Watch and discuss to (6) Complete autonomy. Allows leaders to calibrate release progressively, matching the level of permission to the leader's demonstrated competence and character.	Leadership development calibration tool
Four-Stage Apostolic Movement Framework	On the Verge (2011, with Alan Hirsch)	(1) Imagine — develop missional perspective; (2) Shift — reframe ecclesial concepts; (3) Innovate — implement genuine innovation; (4) Move — generate sustained apostolic momentum. Applied to established large churches.	Ecclesial transformation model

Intellectual Genealogy

Upstream Influences (Who shaped them)

Thinker/Leader	Influence Area	How
Alan Hirsch	APEST framework, mDNA, apostolic imagination, movement theory	Co-authored On the Verge (2011); Ferguson integrates Hirsch's mDNA and APEST throughout his writing; identifies as "high on the apostolic gifting" using Hirsch's typology. Hirsch's Forgotten Ways is the upstream theoretical framework for Ferguson's practical movement-building.
Bob Buford	Hero-making leadership philosophy	Ferguson credits Buford as a personal mentor: "Bob taught me what it meant to be a hero maker." The phrase "my fruit grows on other people's trees" is attributed to Buford. The Legacy of a Hero Maker eBook (2019) uses Buford as a case study.
Jesus's discipleship pattern (Gospels)	Apprenticeship model, time allocation	Ferguson reads the Gospels primarily through the lens of Jesus's time allocation: 73% with the Twelve (apprenticeship minority), 27% with the masses. This becomes the hermeneutical key for the five-step apprenticeship model.
Sam Stephens	Multiplication as exponential illustration	Indian church-planting leader whose mission grew from 200 to ~70,000 churches after implementing apprenticeship structures in 1992. Ferguson uses Stephens repeatedly as the most compelling case study for what genuine multiplication looks like at scale.
Dennis Gamauf	ICNU / permission-giving personal model	Gave Ferguson an ICNU conversation at summer camp that Ferguson still credits as forming his self-understanding as a leader. The personal backstory of the ICNU concept.
Restoration Movement tradition	Ecclesial simplicity, baptism, non-creedal Scripture-centeredness	Ferguson's Restoration Movement heritage (Lincoln Christian University; independent Christian Churches) gives him a strong default toward practical New Testament ecclesiology and distrust of denominational gatekeeping.
The church-growth movement (critiqued)	Metrics language (adapted and redirected)	Ferguson uses church-growth language (levels, metrics, scoreboards) but redirects it toward multiplication rather than accumulation. He is the church-growth movement's practitioner who turned its metrics against it.

Downstream Impact (Who they've shaped)

Person/Community	Connection	Evidence
Ted Coniaris and Community Christian Church	Five-step apprenticeship applied to leadership succession	Coniaris completed the 18-month apprenticeship model, becoming Lead Pastor May 1, 2025 — Ferguson's most public embodiment of his own theology
NewThing/Exponential network of 6,373+ churches	Direct theological training through NewThing's network-of-networks model	982 churches planted in 2020 alone; NewThing became the infrastructure for Ferguson's multiplication vision at global scale
Exponential conference community (100+ denominations)	Annual convening of multiplication-minded leaders across the evangelical spectrum	Ferguson shaped the organizational culture and theological framing of the world's largest church-planting conference
Patrick O'Connell	Key operational implementer of NewThing; co-author of Together	O'Connell became Executive Director of Practice in the merged Exponential; Ferguson's closest institutional partner
Todd Wilson	Co-founder of Exponential; co-author of Becoming a Level Five Multiplying Church	Wilson and Ferguson jointly developed the Five-Level typology that has become the dominant diagnostic framework in the multiplication movement

Intellectual Peers (Contemporary dialogue partners)

Person	Relationship	Agreement/Tension
Alan Hirsch	Closest upstream intellectual influence; co-author; mutual endorsers	Deep alignment on apostolic movement, APEST, and multiplication imperative. Hirsch provides the theoretical architecture; Ferguson provides the operational implementation. Hirsch is more prophetically urgent; Ferguson is more motivationally accessible.
Todd Wilson	Co-founder, organizational partner, co-author	Closest operational peer; jointly built Exponential and the Five-Level framework. Wilson is more research-inclined; Ferguson is more practitioner-storyteller.
Ed Stetzer	Peer, endorser, fellow Wheaton connection	Both serve the evangelical church-planting ecosystem; Stetzer provides research validation; Ferguson provides practitioner credibility. Both endorsed each other's work across multiple cycles.
Carey Nieuwhof	Podcast host (3 appearances), mutual amplifier	Nieuwhof's platform amplifies Ferguson's frameworks to the broadest possible evangelical leadership audience. Nieuwhof specializes in leadership health and church decline — themes that run parallel to Ferguson's hero-making and Multiplier content.
Craig Groeschel	Endorser (3 books), peer at scale	Both lead significant multi-site church organizations; Groeschel's Life.Church is a scale peer for what Ferguson envisioned at CCC. Groeschel represents the "large church doing multiplication" ideal that Ferguson commends.

Theological Positioning

Dimension	Position	Evidence
Ecclesiology	Apostolic-reproducing. The church is a sent, multiplying organism, not a gathered attractional institution. Primary task: generate a movement of disciples and churches.	All books; CCC's tri-fold vision (Impact, Reproducing, Catalyst); NewThing's network-of-networks model
Missiology	Incarnational-neighboring. Go to your existing relational networks with prayer, listening, eating, serving, and story. BLESS democratizes the incarnational impulse for every believer.	BLESS (2021); Finding Your Way Back to God (2015); Discover Your Mission Now (2012)
Leadership	Hero-making. The leader's job is to make heroes of others, not to be the hero. Reproduction over performance. Apostolic gifting (self-identified) expressed through releasing, not building personal platform.	Hero Maker (2018); Multiplier (2026); succession story
Anthropology	Leaders reproduce who they are. Formation is ontological, not merely behavioral. Spiritual health is a multiplication prerequisite because "you can't multiply something that's not first alive in you."	Multiplier (2026)
Soteriology	Broadly evangelical; Finding Your Way Back to God's five awakenings framework maps the pre-conversion journey accessibly. Baptism emphasized (Restoration Movement heritage).	Finding Your Way Back to God (2015)
Eschatology	Practical and mission-driven. Multiplication matters because it is how the Great Commission advances. Less emphasis on eschatological frameworks per se.	Exponential framing throughout
Spiritual formation	Formation is a prerequisite for multiplication, not an alternative to it. RPMS gauges, journaling, and daily health monitoring are spiritual disciplines in service of sustainable kingdom impact.	Multiplier (2026)
Kingdom vision	The kingdom advances through multiplication at every level (disciples, leaders, churches, networks). Collaboration is kingdom infrastructure. "Kingdom over Castle" is the guiding organizational ethic.	Together (2020); NewThing-Exponential merger framing (2025)

Content Evolution

Timeline of Ideas

Period	Focus	Key Work	Shift
2007–2011	Ecclesial strategy and missional movement theory	The Big Idea (2007), Exponential (2010), On the Verge (2011, with Hirsch)	From local pastoral practice to movementl ecclesiology. The Big Idea is an inward-facing church-strategy tool; Exponential and On the Verge move outward to multiplication and apostolic movement theory. First phase: How should a church be structured and led to become a movement?
2012–2013	Mission activation for ordinary Christians	Discover Your Mission Now (2012), Keeping Score (2014 eBook)	Moves from pastoral-leader audience to all-believer audience. The question shifts from "How do churches multiply?" to "How does every Christian discover their personal mission?" Reflects Ferguson's concern that the multiplication vision be democratized beyond professionals.
2015–2016	Spiritual journey and outreach for the broader market	Finding Your Way Back to God (2015), Starting Over (2016)	Broadens beyond the church-leader audience to the general Christian/seeker market (WaterBrook/PRH). The five awakenings and prodigal son framework addresses the spiritually wandering, not just multiplication practitioners. The Big Idea applied to outreach: what is the single framework a church can use to help returning people?
2018–2021	Leader multiplication and missional neighboring as mature synthesis	Hero Maker (2018), BLESS (2020), Together (2020)	The synthesis phase: Hero Maker integrates the leader-multiplication vision (inside the church) with BLESS's missional-neighboring vision (outside the church) into a complete multiplication theology. The leader who makes heroes of others inside also equips them to BLESS neighbors outside. The Great Collaboration (Together) adds the network layer: interconnected churches are the infrastructure for this movement.
2026	Leader health and formation as multiplication prerequisite	Multiplier (2026), Substack	The most searching phase: What if the problem is not knowledge (knowing how to multiply) but ontology (who the leader is becoming)? RPMS gauges and the Drift Trio add a formation-interiority dimension that was underdeveloped in earlier work. Ferguson appears to be writing from personal vulnerability — 35 years of ministry and watching leaders (including himself) struggle to maintain health under sustained pressure.

Has their thinking shifted?

Ferguson's core conviction has been constant across nearly two decades: multiplication, not accumulation, is the mission. What has evolved is the diagnostic depth and breadth of audience.

The most significant intellectual development is the turn toward leader formation in Multiplier (2026). Earlier books assume that if leaders understand the hero-making framework and adopt the five practices, multiplication will follow. Multiplier makes a more searching argument: the limiting variable is the leader's interior life, not the framework. This does not contradict the earlier work but adds a layer of anthropological realism — leaders can know all the right practices and still drift, fail, and harm those they lead.

The second development is the progressive democratization of the multiplication vision. The Big Idea addresses senior pastors. Exponential addresses church-planting leaders. Hero Maker addresses anyone who leads others. BLESS addresses every Christian, including those with no formal leadership role. Finding Your Way Back to God addresses people who aren't yet Christians at all. The audience has been expanding outward across each book cycle.

Unique Contribution

What only this author says

- **Multiplication as organizational theology at operational scale:** Ferguson is the only author in the church-multiplication space who has built a 5,500-person multi-site church, a 6,373-church global network, and the world's largest church-planting conference — and written from that experience with accessible, practical frameworks. Every multiplication claim is backed by institutional evidence at scale. This is not a theory; it is a 35-year operational record.
- **The hero-maker identity inversion:** The shift from "Am I trying to be the hero?" to "Am I trying to make heroes out of others?" is Ferguson's signature rhetorical and theological move. It applies the apprenticeship pattern of Jesus to contemporary leadership at every organizational level. While others discuss servant leadership, Ferguson gives it a specific mechanism (ICNU conversations, the five-step apprenticeship model, the six permission-giving levels) that makes it deployable rather than merely aspirational.
- **The Five-Level church typology as the dominant diagnostic framework:** The Level 1–5 taxonomy has become the standard vocabulary in North American evangelical church-planting conversations. "Are you a Level 3 or Level 5 church?" is a question pastors and denominational leaders now use habitually, without always knowing it originated with Ferguson and Wilson. This framework's widespread adoption across 100+ networks and denominations represents perhaps his most significant cultural contribution.

- **BLESS as the practical synthesis of incarnational mission for lay Christians:** BLESS takes the missional-incarnational theology of Hirsch, Frost, and Woodward and distills it into five practices memorable enough for a non-theological suburban Christian to deploy on Monday morning. No other author in the multiplication space has made incarnational theology this accessible without sacrificing its substance.
- **"Kingdom over Castle" as an organizational ethic:** Ferguson's decision to dissolve NewThing into Exponential — surrendering an organization he built over 24 years for a larger kingdom mission — is rare. The willingness to embody this principle publicly (and to demonstrate it institutionally) gives the "Kingdom over Castle" concept a credibility it would not have if it remained merely rhetorical.

Where they disagree with peers

Topic	Ferguson's Position	Mainstream/Peer Position
What churches should measure	Kingdom scorecard: disciples made, leaders released, churches planted	Attendance, budget, square footage — the dominant American church-growth metrics
The definition of success for a pastor	Making heroes of others; your fruit grows on their trees	Building the biggest, most influential platform personally
Whether every believer can engage in mission	Yes — BLESS is designed for everyone, including people with no ministry training	Implicitly, mission is often treated as a professional specialty
Whether organizational structures should be preserved	No — "Kingdom over Castle" means dissolving what you built if kingdom mission requires it	Most organizational leaders protect their institutional structures
Whether multiplication is possible for most churches	Yes — with the right framework and culture shift, every church can move toward Level 4-5	The conventional wisdom that multiplication is only for special churches or pioneering leaders

What would be lost without their work

Without Ferguson's work, the church-multiplication movement would have the theoretical framework (Hirsch's mDNA and APEST) without its most widely adopted practical deployment. The Five-Level typology — now standard vocabulary across 100+ denominations — would not exist. The BLESS framework would not have democratized missional living for lay Christians at the scale it has. The Exponential conference would not exist as the convening infrastructure of the multiplication movement. And the NewThing network's 6,373+ church plants would simply not exist.

Content Interconnections

How themes connect across works

Ferguson's body of work follows a clear expansion arc: from ecclesial structure (how one church organizes for multiplication) to leader culture (how leaders behave to release others) to everyday mission (how ordinary Christians engage neighbors) to formation (how leaders sustain health to multiply sustainably over decades).

- The Big Idea (2007) and Exponential (2010) establish the organizational-church framework — how a single congregation can orient itself toward reproduction.
- On the Verge (2011, with Hirsch) provides the missional-movement theology — the apostolic imagination and mDNA framework that gives the organizational practice its theoretical grounding.
- Hero Maker (2018) shifts the frame from ecclesial structure to leadership culture — the leader who makes heroes, not the church that has good programming.
- BLESS (2021) completes the outward movement — once leaders are making heroes inside the church, those heroes go out with the BLESS framework to engage neighbors.
- Multiplier (2026) adds the formation layer — before all of this is sustainable, the leader must be healthy from the inside out.

Each work builds on and presupposes the previous. The arc moves from organizational methodology to leader culture to personal formation. The vision stays constant; the focus deepens from institution to leader to soul.

Recommended reading order

Order	Work	Why this sequence
1	Exponential (2010)	Foundational multiplication vision; Community Christian Church story; the case for Level 4–5 thinking. Best starting point for church leaders.
2	Becoming a Level Five Multiplying Church (free eBook)	The Five-Level diagnostic applied practically; co-authors Wilson and Hirsch add denominational and missiological depth.
3	Hero Maker (2018)	The leader culture shift; five practices; ICNU; apprenticeship model. Best entry point for senior leaders and pastors.
4	BLESS (2021)	The everyday mission framework; for the whole congregation, not just leaders. Best for small-group adoption.
5	Multiplier (2026)	Formation and health as multiplication prerequisites; most personally searching work. Best for experienced leaders asking "how do I sustain this for 20 more years?"
6	Finding Your Way Back to God (2015)	For outreach contexts and seeker-adjacent readers; the spiritual journey framework. Parallel reading, not sequential.
7	On the Verge (2011, with Hirsch)	For leaders wanting the full theological framework behind the multiplication vision; Hirsch adds the missiological depth.

Movemental Content Strategy Implications

- **Pillar mapping:** Ferguson serves the **Church Multiplication**, **Leader Formation**, **Everyday Mission**, **Movement Building**, and **Leadership Development** content pillars. His work also feeds into **Spiritual Formation** (Multiplier) and **Evangelism** (BLESS, Finding Your Way Back to God) categories.
- **Cross-author connections:** Natural alignment with **Alan Hirsch** (APEST, apostolic movement — Hirsch is the upstream theoretical framework; Ferguson deploys it practically). Natural pairing with **Todd Wilson** (co-founder of Exponential; Level Five framework co-developer). Conceptual resonance with **JR Woodward** (both engaged in the V3/NewThing/Exponential ecosystem; Woodward from the theological-diagnostic side, Ferguson from the operational-motivational side). BLESS resonates with **Hugh Halter's** incarnational neighboring work and **Brad Brisco's** missional community emphases.
- **Content gaps Movemental can fill:** (1) No standalone digital course on the Hero Maker five practices or the Five-Level framework — the two most-deployed frameworks in his portfolio; (2) No BLESS community platform where practitioners can report back and support each other; (3) The Substack URL problem (daveferguson3.substack.com) should

be resolved on any new platform; (4) No searchable video library organizing his Exponential talks and podcast appearances; (5) No systematic RPMS/Multiplier digital companion beyond multiplierbook.com's one-time bonus content.

- **Series potential:** (1) "Hero Maker in 5 Sessions" — a video course on the five practices with ICNU and apprenticeship model; (2) "The Five Levels: Where Is Your Church?" — a diagnostic and action-planning mini-course; (3) "BLESS: A 30-Day Neighboring Challenge" — a community-engaged formation program; (4) "Multiplier: The RPMS Daily Practice" — a digital health-monitoring companion to the 2026 book; (5) "Kingdom over Castle: Movement Leadership Stories" — a video series featuring Ferguson and leaders who have built and given away organizations.
- **Searchable concepts:** church multiplication, hero maker, five levels of church, reproducing church, BLESS framework, missional living, apprenticeship model, ICNU, kingdom scorecard, church planting movement, multiplying church, permission giving, exponential growth church, NewThing network, leadership multiplication, RPMS leader health, drift in ministry, Level 5 church, 16% mission, kingdom metrics, disciple multiplication, leader formation.
- **Distinctive positioning for Movemental:** Ferguson's unique value on the platform is the **operational proof point for the multiplication vision**. He is the only author who has built what every other multiplication thinker is describing. This grounds abstract movement theology in concrete organizational history at scale. A Movemental-hosted learning track pairing Hirsch's theological framework (the "why") with Ferguson's operational practice (the "how") would be the definitive multiplication curriculum in the evangelical market.

Sources

- Profile: [profile/biography.md](#), [profile/theology.md](#), [profile/voice-analysis.md](#)
- Book catalog: [content/books.md](#)
- Audio catalog: [content/audio.md](#)
- Network: [network/organizations.md](#), [network/endorsements.md](#)
- Digital presence: [digital-presence/social-media.md](#), [digital-presence/newsletters.md](#)
- Media: [media/press-coverage.md](#), [media/reviews.md](#)
- [Hero Maker Book Site](#)
- [Multiplier Book Site](#)
- [BLESS Book Site](#)
- [Exponential Person Page — Dave Ferguson](#)
- [workplaces.org transcript](#)
- [Church Leaders Podcast — churchleaders.com/podcast/319174](#)

Misc · Content-Analysis-Root

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/_misc/content-analysis-root.md

Content Analysis & Synthesis: Dave Ferguson

Research Date: January 4, 2026

Content Thematic Analysis

Primary Themes

Based on published works and institutional roles, Dave Ferguson's content focuses on:

1. Leadership Multiplication

- "Hero Maker: Five Essential Practices for Leaders to Multiply Leaders"
- Focus on developing and multiplying leaders
- Creating cultures of leadership development

2. Church Planting & Multiplication

- "Exponential: How You and Your Friends Can Start a Missional Church Movement"
- NewThing Network leadership
- Exponential Conference focus
- Strategies for reproducing churches

3. Missional Living & Community Engagement

- "B.L.E.S.S.: 5 Everyday Ways to Love Your Neighbor and Change the World"
- Practical approaches to neighbor engagement
- Community transformation

4. Spiritual Journey & Faith Exploration

- "Finding Your Way Back to God" (co-authored with Jon Ferguson)
- Five awakenings framework
- Helping people reconnect with faith

5. Church Strategy & Innovation

- "The Big Idea" (2007)
- "On The Verge" (2011)
- "Discover Your Mission Now" (2012)
- "Keeping Score" (2013)
- Church growth strategies
- Mission-focused approaches

Theological Focus Areas

- **Missional Theology:** Emphasis on being sent into the world

- **Church Multiplication:** Focus on reproducing disciples and churches
- **Leadership Development:** Empowering others to lead
- **Community Transformation:** Engaging neighborhoods and communities
- **Practical Application:** Accessible, practitioner-focused content

Movement Focus

- **Church Planting:** Core focus through NewThing and Exponential
- **Leadership Multiplication:** Developing leaders who develop leaders
- **Missional Movement:** Churches engaging their communities
- **Reproduction:** Creating systems and cultures that multiply

Recurring Topics

- Leadership development and multiplication
- Church planting strategies
- Missional engagement
- Community transformation
- Spiritual formation
- Church growth and health
- Multiplication movements

Content Organization Analysis

Personal Website (daveferguson.org)

Structure:

- Clear navigation: Book, Blog, About, Contact
- Blog section present and active
- Book promotion integrated
- Social media links prominent

Organization Approach:

- Personal brand focused
- Book-centric content organization
- Blog for ongoing content
- Simple, clear structure

Institutional Content Distribution

Community Christian Church:

- Multi-site church structure
- Likely organized by: series, topics, locations
- Sermon/teaching library (to be verified)

Exponential Conference:

- Conference-based organization
- Talk/presentation library
- Resource distribution
- Annual conference structure

NewThing Network:

- Movement resources
- Training materials
- Network support content

Content Strategy Assessment

Appears to have:

- Clear personal brand (daveferguson.org)
- Institutional backing (church, movement, conference)
- Book-driven content strategy
- Blog for ongoing engagement
- Conference speaking platform

Content Forms:

- Books (9+ published works)
- Blog posts/articles
- Sermons/teaching (institutional)
- Conference talks/presentations
- Social media content

Content Series Potential:

- Book series (leadership, church planting, missional living)
- Conference talk series (annual Exponential talks)
- Sermon series (through Community Christian Church)
- Blog series (to be analyzed)

Content Interconnection

Cross-References:

- Books reference and support institutional work
- Conference talks likely reference book content
- Blog may reference books and talks
- Institutional platforms support personal brand

Ecosystem Connectivity:

- Personal brand (daveferguson.org) connects to:
- Community Christian Church
- NewThing Network
- Exponential Conference
- Books support movement work
- Movement work provides content for books
- Conference provides speaking platform

Voice & Style Analysis

Writing Style

Based on book titles and descriptions:

- **Accessible:** Practitioner-focused, not overly academic
- **Practical:** Action-oriented, "how-to" approach
- **Encouraging:** Positive, empowering tone
- **Strategic:** Systems and frameworks for multiplication

Tone and Approach

- **Pastoral:** Caring, supportive approach
- **Leader-focused:** Empowering other leaders
- **Movement-oriented:** Thinking beyond individual to collective
- **Practical:** Real-world application emphasis

Theological Positioning

Observable characteristics:

- **Missional:** Emphasis on being sent
- **Multiplication-focused:** Reproducing disciples and churches
- **Community-engaged:** Neighborhood and community focus
- **Evangelical:** Within evangelical Christian tradition
- **Practitioner-oriented:** For church leaders and practitioners

Audience Level

- **Primary:** Church leaders, pastors, church planters
- **Secondary:** Practitioners, lay leaders
- **Level:** Popular/practitioner (not primarily academic)
- **Accessibility:** Accessible to general Christian audience

Discoverability Assessment

SEO Indicators

Personal Website:

- Clean URL structure (daveferguson.org/blog, /about-dave)
- Clear page titles
- Social media integration
- Book promotion (likely good internal linking)

To Be Assessed:

- Meta descriptions
- Title tag optimization
- URL structure depth
- Internal linking strategy

Content Indexing

Likely Well-Indexed:

- Personal website (daveferguson.org)
- Book titles and author pages
- Conference speaker pages (Exponential)
- Institutional websites

Search Visibility:

- Name searches likely return multiple results
- Book titles searchable
- Conference association provides visibility
- Institutional websites provide authority

Social Sharing Indicators

- Social media links present on website
- Instagram active (@fergusondave)
- Facebook and Twitter links present
- Book promotion likely includes social sharing

Backlinks and References

Likely Sources:

- Publisher websites
- Conference websites (Exponential)
- Church websites (Community Christian Church)
- Movement websites (NewThing)
- Book retailer sites (Amazon, etc.)
- Other church leaders and authors

Domain Authority Indicators

- Personal domain (daveferguson.org) - owned
- Institutional backing provides authority
- Multiple published books
- Conference leadership role
- Movement leadership role
- Established presence (2007+ books)

Ecosystem Analysis

Content Ecosystem Structure

Personal Brand Layer:

- daveferguson.org (personal website)
- Books (9+ published works)
- Blog content
- Social media presence

Institutional Layer:

- Community Christian Church (sermons, teaching)
- NewThing Network (movement resources)
- Exponential Conference (talks, presentations)

Interconnection:

- Personal brand supported by institutional work
- Institutional work provides content for personal brand
- Books draw from and support movement work
- Conference provides speaking and content distribution platform

Content Cross-References

Likely Connections:

- Books reference movement principles
- Conference talks reference book content
- Blog may reference both books and talks
- Sermons may reference book themes
- Movement resources may reference books

Connections to Other Authors/Leaders

Co-authors:

- Jon Ferguson (brother) - "Finding Your Way Back to God"
- Other co-authors for various books (to be verified)

Network Connections:

- Exponential Conference (connects to many church leaders)
- NewThing Network (connects to church planters globally)
- Community Christian Church (connects to local and multi-site networks)

Institutional Partnerships

- **Community Christian Church:** Multi-site church network
- **NewThing Network:** International church-planting movement
- **Exponential Conference:** World's largest church planting conference
- **Publishers:** Multiple (Zondervan, Multnomah, WaterBrook Multnomah)

Community Engagement

Likely Present:

- Conference engagement (Exponential attendees)
- Movement engagement (NewThing network)
- Church community (Community Christian Church)
- Social media engagement (Instagram)
- Book readership

To Be Assessed:

- Blog comments/engagement
- Social media engagement levels
- Newsletter subscribers (if present)
- Course/training participants (if present)

Content Gaps (Initial Observations)

Potential Gaps to Explore

1. Content Repurposing:

- Are sermons transcribed and published as articles?
- Are conference talks developed into blog posts?
- Are book concepts expanded in other formats?

2. Content Series Development:

- Are blog posts organized into series?
- Are themes developed across multiple content forms?
- Are there opportunities for deeper series development?

3. Content Discoverability:

- How are sermons/talks discoverable?
- Are blog posts optimized for search?
- Are there content hubs or resource pages?

4. Content Interconnection:

- Are content pieces clearly linked?
- Are themes developed across platforms?
- Is there a clear content journey for readers?

Notes

- Strong thematic consistency across books and institutional work
- Clear focus on leadership multiplication and church planting
- Personal brand well-integrated with institutional presence
- Multiple content distribution channels
- Established authority through books, conference, and movement leadership
- Recent transition (2025) may affect content distribution patterns
- NewThing-Exponential merger (2025) may create new content opportunities

Academic Citations & Scholarly Impact: Dave Ferguson

Research Date: 2026-05-27

Subject: Dave Ferguson — church planter, movement leader, author; CEO/President of Exponential

Confidence Level: Medium (Google Scholar profile confirmed; individual citing works partially verified; Ferguson is a practitioner author, not an academic researcher)

Google Scholar Profile

Metric	Value
Profile URL	https://scholar.google.com/citations?user=MkztWIoAAAAJ&hl=en
Confirmed?	Yes — Scholar profile for "Dave Ferguson" church leader confirmed from search
Total Citations	UNKNOWN — not retrieved; multiple Dave Fergusons appear on Scholar; practitioner-track author (see note below)
Research Interests	Church planting, church multiplication, missional leadership, leadership development
Institution	Not affiliated with academic institution; practitioner author
h-index	UNKNOWN — not retrieved

Important Note: Dave Ferguson (church leader) should not be confused with other Dave Fergusons in Google Scholar (one in robotics research, one in exercise physiology, one in music). Ferguson's books are primarily trade/practitioner publications rather than peer-reviewed academic works. His citation footprint is in theological education (DMin dissertations, ministry training syllabi) rather than peer-reviewed journals.

Publications by Dave Ferguson

Books (Full-Length)

#	Title	Co-Author(s)	Publisher	Year	Goodreads Ratings	Estimated Citation Tier
1	The Big Idea: Focus the Message—Multiply the Impact	Jon Ferguson, Eric Bramlett	Zondervan / Leadership Network	2007	173	Low (church communication niche)
2	Exponential: How You and Your Friends Can Start a Missional Church Movement	Jon Ferguson	Zondervan	2010	442	Moderate (DMin syllabi; church planting courses)
3	On the Verge: A Journey Into the Apostolic Future of the Church	Alan Hirsch	Zondervan	2011	Goodreads rating unconfirmed	Moderate-High (Hirsch halo; missional theology courses)
4	Discover Your Mission Now	—	NavPress / Tyndale	2012	26	Low
5	Keeping Score: How to Know If Your Church Is Winning	—	Exponential Resources	2014	9	Low (internal practitioner resource)
6	Finding Your Way Back to God: Five Awakenings to Your New Life	Jon Ferguson	WaterBrook	2015	172	Low (popular trade; rarely cited academically)
7	Hero Maker: Five Essential Practices for Leaders to Multiply Leaders	Warren Bird	Zondervan	2018	737	Moderate-High (most-cited title; leadership curricula, DMin programs)
8	BLESS: 5 Everyday Ways to Love Your Neighbor and Change the World	Jon Ferguson	WaterBrook	2021	500	Low-Moderate (evangelism curricula)
9	Multiplier: How Healthy Leaders Create Lasting Impact	—	Zondervan Reflective	2026	5	Too new to assess

Shorter / Companion Publications

#	Title	Co-Author(s)	Publisher	Year	Notes
1	Becoming a Level Five Multiplying Church	Todd Wilson, Alan Hirsch	Exponential Resources	2015-16	Conference resource; widely distributed free at Exponential 2016
2	The Legacy of a Hero Maker	Todd Wilson	Exponential Resources	2019	Companion to Hero Maker; tribute to Bob Buford
3	Together: The Great Collaboration	Patrick O'Connell	Exponential Resources	~2020	Network resource
4	Boss or Leader	—	Unknown	2014	Short resource
5	Equip: Practical Ways to Train Missional Leaders	—	Unknown	2013	Short resource

Confirmed Academic Engagement

Peer-Reviewed / Academic Journal Review

#	Title	Publication	Date	Notes
1	"Review of The Legacy of a Hero Maker, by Dave Ferguson [and Todd Wilson]"	Journal of Adventist Christian Leadership (Andrews University)	~2019-20	Peer-reviewed journal review confirmed; available through Andrews University Digital Commons. Represents the clearest academic-level engagement with Ferguson's Hero Maker work.

Who Cites Dave Ferguson

Scholars / Practitioners Who Have Directly Engaged His Work

Scholar / Practitioner	Affiliation	Relationship to Ferguson's Work
Alan Hirsch	100Movements, Forge, Movement Leaders Collective	Co-authored On the Verge; endorsed Hero Maker and Multiplier; Ferguson's Level 5 framework developed alongside Hirsch's concepts
Ed Stetzer	Wheaton College (Billy Graham Distinguished Chair)	Endorsed Hero Maker, BLESS, and Multiplier; has cited Ferguson's church multiplication research in his own writing
Todd Wilson	Exponential (founding CEO)	Co-authored Becoming a Level Five Multiplying Church with Ferguson; their Level 5 framework is cited in church multiplication literature
Warren Bird	Leadership Network (Research Director, retired)	Co-authored Hero Maker; Bird's research practice means the book has stronger methodological grounding than typical pastor-authored leadership titles
Patrick O'Connell	Exponential (Executive Director of Practice)	Co-authored Together; cites Ferguson's vision in NewThing-related writings
Carey Nieuwhof	Bestselling author, podcaster	Has cited and amplified Ferguson's "hero maker" and "multiplier" frameworks in his own content and endorsed books
Mark Batterson	National Community Church; NYT bestselling author	Has endorsed three Ferguson books; Ferguson's frameworks appear in Batterson's network circles

Dissertations & Theses Citing Ferguson

Based on search evidence, Ferguson's work appears in the bibliography of doctoral dissertations in church planting, missional leadership, and ministry training. Confirmed or probable citations:

#	Type	Institution	Topic Area	Citing Work	Confidence
1	Academic Journal Review	Andrews University	Hero Maker / leadership multiplication	Journal of Adventist Christian Leadership review of Legacy of a Hero Maker	High (confirmed)
2	DMin Dissertation	Multiple seminaries	Church multiplication / Exponential model	Exponential (2010) and Hero Maker (2018) cited in dissertations on church planting strategy and multiplication metrics	Medium (pattern evident; specific dissertation details not retrieved)
3	DMin Dissertation	Various (Wheaton, Talbot, Gateway, etc.)	Level 5 church multiplication	Becoming a Level Five Multiplying Church widely used in DMin coursework on church health and multiplication	Medium-High (course syllabus pattern confirmed from Exponential resource distribution)
4	Church Leadership Coursework	Wheaton College Graduate School	Evangelism and Leadership	Ferguson's books likely used in his own adjunct course at Wheaton Graduate School	High (inference from teaching role)

Books That Reference or Dialogue with Ferguson's Work

Ferguson's work is situated within and cited by the broader church multiplication / missional movement literature:

Author	Notable Work	Nature of Engagement
Alan Hirsch	The Forgotten Ways, 5Q, The Permanent Revolution	Shared APEST / apostolic movement framework; On the Verge is direct co-authorship; Hirsch's broader work references and extends Ferguson's practice
Ed Stetzer	Planting Missional Churches, Transformational Church	Shared church planting ecosystem; Ferguson's Exponential research informs Stetzer's missional church body of work
Todd Wilson	Spark: Igniting a Culture of Multiplication	Precursor to the Becoming a Level Five work they co-authored; shares the multiplication framework
Patrick O'Connell	NewThing-related writing	Direct organizational collaboration
Warren Bird	Multiple Leadership Network research reports	Bird's co-authorship means Ferguson's frameworks appear in Leadership Network's broader research ecosystem

Academic Context & Influence Assessment

Theoretical Contributions

Ferguson's practitioner-track work makes recognized contributions in three areas:

1. **Hero Maker / Leadership Multiplication Framework:** The five practices (Multiplication Thinking, Permission Giving, Disciple Multiplying, Gift Activating, Kingdom Building) have become a recognized framework in evangelical leadership development circles. Widely used in DMin programs, church planting cohorts, and leadership training.
2. **Level 5 Church Multiplication Diagnostic:** The Level 1–5 church multiplication scale (co-developed with Todd Wilson and Alan Hirsch) is one of the most widely used diagnostic frameworks in the North American church planting ecosystem. Frequently cited in Exponential conference resources, seminary coursework, and church health consulting.
3. **BLESS Framework:** The five-practice BLESS acronym (Begin with Prayer, Listen, Eat, Serve, Story) has become a recognized congregational evangelism framework, used in church-wide campaign curricula across multiple denominations and traditions.
4. **NewThing Network Research:** Ferguson's organizational leadership of NewThing produced significant practitioner data on reproducing church networks across 60+ nations. The 6,373 churches planted figure (cited by Christian Standard, 2021) represents the kind of movement data that feeds missiological literature.

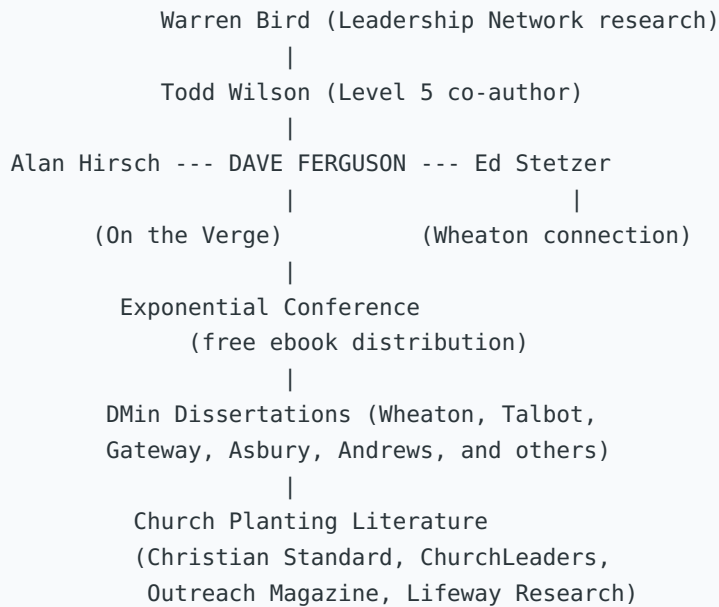
Practitioner vs. Academic Profile

Ferguson is firmly in the practitioner-author tradition rather than the academic-author tradition (contrast with, e.g., JR Woodward, who has a PhD from Manchester and an academic citation profile). His influence runs through:

- **Practitioner adoption** (churches using Hero Maker, BLESS, Level 5 frameworks)
- **DMin education** (seminaries using his books in leadership and church planting courses)
- **Conference ecosystem** (Exponential's annual distribution of free ebooks reaches tens of thousands of church leaders)
- **Endorsement network** (his books endorsed by and cross-promoted with Craig Groeschel, Andy Stanley, Alan Hirsch, Ed Stetzer — multiplying reach)

He is not heavily cited in peer-reviewed missiology or theology journals. The one confirmed academic journal review (Andrews University, JACL) is for the Legacy of a Hero Maker companion, not the main Hero Maker volume.

Citation Ecosystem Map



Recommendations for Further Research

1. **Google Scholar direct search:** Search "Dave Ferguson" + "Hero Maker" OR "Exponential" + church planting to identify peer-level citations in academic theological databases
2. **ProQuest Dissertations & Theses:** Search "Hero Maker Ferguson" and "Level 5 multiplying church Ferguson" to identify all doctoral dissertations citing his frameworks
3. **ATLA Religion Database:** Search for academic journal citations of On the Verge (the most academically positioned Ferguson book, due to Hirsch co-authorship)
4. **Exponential free ebook download statistics:** Exponential has distributed millions of ebooks free — actual reach is far larger than Goodreads/Amazon ratings suggest
5. **Wheaton Graduate School syllabus audit:** Ferguson's adjunct position means his books likely appear in his own course syllabi

Notable Gaps

- No confirmed Google Scholar total citation count retrieved
- No confirmed h-index retrieved
- Specific DMin dissertations citing Ferguson not individually enumerated (pattern confirmed; titles not retrieved)
- Academic journal articles by Ferguson not found (he is a practitioner author, not a journal contributor)

- Semantic Scholar profile not checked (additional research needed)

Research conducted via WebSearch on 2026-05-27. Citation counts are approximate based on available sources. Individual citing works identified through web search of academic repositories and publisher databases.

Misc · Media · Press-Coverage

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/_misc/media/press-coverage.md

Press Coverage & Media Mentions: Dave Ferguson

Research Date: 2026-05-27

Subject: Dave Ferguson — church planter, movement leader, author; CEO/President of Exponential; Co-Founding Pastor, Community Christian Church

Confidence Level: High (primary sources verified via web search)

Summary

Dave Ferguson's media presence is substantial and recurring — significantly greater than many peer movement leaders — concentrated in three zones: (1) Outreach Magazine (his most consistent institutional press home), (2) the national evangelical/church leadership media circuit (Christianity Today Pastors, ChurchLeaders, Christian Post), and (3) major church leadership podcasts. He has been featured in Outreach Magazine more than a dozen times across 20 years, appeared on CT Pastors as a contributing author, and received broad institutional coverage for his role at Exponential and as an author. Community Christian Church's inclusion in the Outreach 100 (2007, 2011) contributed early visibility.

Outreach Magazine — Most Sustained Press Relationship

Dave Ferguson is one of Outreach Magazine's most frequently featured leaders. Coverage spans profile interviews, feature columns, and leadership articles from 2007 to at least 2025.

#	Title	Type	Date	Key Content	URL
1	"Community Christian Church, Chicago"	Interview	~2007	Early profile of COMMUNITY; church on Outreach 100 fastest-growing list (2,230 numerical growth, 81% growth)	outreachmagazine.com/4366
2	"A Vision for Reproducing Churches"	Interview	~2012	NewThing and reproducing church vision	outreachmagazine.com/4943
3	"Making Heroes"	Interview	~2017	Hero Maker themes; creating a culture of leader multiplication	outreachmagazine.com/23898
4	"An Unprecedented Opportunity"	Feature	~2017-18	Leadership and church multiplication opportunity	outreachmagazine.com/23902
5	"Collaboration Is the Future — Part 1"	Interview	~2020	Collaboration framework; NewThing and network leadership	outreachmagazine.com/57041
6	"The Reproducible Life — Part 2"	Interview	~2020	Reproducible leadership practices	outreachmagazine.com/57047
7	"Ask the Right Question"	Feature	~2021-22	Decision-making and leadership	outreachmagazine.com/80803
8	"Multiplying Leaders"	Interview	~2025	NewThing/Exponential merger succession; 16% mission; equipping everyday disciples	outreachmagazine.com/84098
9	The 2011 Outreach 100 — "The Transparent Leader"	Feature article	2011	Ferguson featured among influential pastors; Outreach 100 recognition	outreachmagazine.com/4317

Note: Outreach Magazine's archive page for Dave Ferguson (outreachmagazine.com/dave-ferguson) lists additional articles beyond those captured above. Full enumeration requires direct archive access.

Christianity Today / CT Pastors

#	Publication	Role / Type	Notes	URL
1	CT Pastors	Contributing Author (author archive)	Ferguson has a bylined author page at CT Pastors, indicating multiple contributed articles on pastoral leadership, apprenticeship, and church multiplication. Specific article titles not fully retrieved.	christianitytoday.com/pastors/authors/dave-ferguson
2	Christianity Today (main site)	Contributing Author	Separate author archive page exists on CT's main platform. Connected to CT's Global Leadership Network content.	christianitytoday.com/writers/dave-ferguson

Confidence: High that Ferguson has contributed to CT Pastors; specific article titles UNKNOWN without direct archive access.

ChurchLeaders

#	Title	Type	Date	Key Content	URL
1	"Dave Ferguson: The Key Steps to Building a Culture of Outreach"	Podcast / Article	Oct 2, 2024	Building an outreach culture in congregations; Ed Stetzer interview	churchleaders.com/podcast/497963
2	"Podcast Special: Dave Ferguson Gives 4 Habits for Healthy, Lasting Ministry"	Podcast feature	~2022-23	FrontStage BackStage conversation; four practices for healthy ministry	churchleaders.com/pastors/431328

Christian Post

#	Title	Type	Date	Key Content	URL
1	"Megachurch Pastor Shines Spotlight on Winning Souls One by One"	News feature	Nov 2020	Ferguson at FutureFWD2020 virtual conference; emphasis on personal evangelism and online spiritual seeking	christianpost.com

Christian Standard

#	Title	Type	Date	Key Content	URL
1	"NewThing Planted Nearly 1,000 New Churches in 2020"	News article	Feb 10, 2021	982 churches planted in 2020; 6,373 total over ~15 years; Patrick O'Connell and Ferguson quoted on pandemic-era church planting growth	christianstandard.com/2021/02
2	"Are You a Level 5 Multiplying Church?"	Feature	Mar 2016	Based on Ferguson/Wilson Becoming a Level Five Multiplying Church framework; Exponential 2016 theme	christianstandard.com/2016/03
3	Exponential organization page	Ongoing coverage	Various	Christian Standard covers Exponential as a Restoration Movement-adjacent organization; Ferguson's organizational leadership noted	christianstandard.com/organizations/exponential

Organizational Profile Pages (Institutional Press)

#	Organization	Role	URL
1	Exponential	CEO / President	exponential.org/person/dave-f
2	Community Christian Church	Co-Founding Pastor	communitychristian.org/about
3	Penguin Random House	Author page (Finding Your Way Back to God, BLESS)	penguinrandomhouse.com/authors/187302
4	Lewis Center for Church Leadership	Contributing author and podcast guest	churchleadership.com/author/dave-ferguson
5	The Ascent Leader	Featured profile	theascentleader.org/dave-ferguson

Podcast-Based Press Coverage (High-Profile Platforms)

Podcast	Host	Date (approx)	Topic	URL
Carey Nieuwhof Leadership Podcast (CNLP 169)	Carey Nieuwhof	~2017-18	Hero Maker; church multiplication future; NewThing expansion	careynieuwhof.com/episode169
Carey Nieuwhof Leadership Podcast (CNLP 415)	Carey Nieuwhof	~2021	Micro-church future; resilience; racial inequality response	careynieuwhof.com/episode415
The Stetzer ChurchLeaders Podcast	Ed Stetzer	Oct 2024	Building a culture of outreach	churchleaders.com/podcast/497963
unSeminary Podcast	Rich Birch	~2021	BLESS framework; missional neighbor engagement	unseminary.com
Lewis Center Podcast (Episode 60)	Lewis Center	~2018	Hero Maker framework	churchleadership.com/podcast
Lochhead on Different (Ep. 177)	Christopher Lochhead	~2021-22	God and different dialogue	lochhead.com/pastor-dave-ferguson

Global Leadership Network — Published Articles

Ferguson has published content through the Global Leadership Network (associated with Willow Creek's Global Leadership Summit):

Article Title	Type	URL
"7 Steps to Creating a Culture that Makes Heroes"	Leadership article	globalleadership.org
"How Great Leaders Communicate to Create Movement"	Leadership article	globalleadership.org
"Do This Every Day to Combat Drift"	Leadership article	globalleadership.org

Notable Gaps in Press Coverage

- **No confirmed Christianity Today feature profile** (news or long-form feature) — CT Pastors contributions are bylined contributor pieces, not CT editorial coverage of Ferguson
- **No confirmed Relevant Magazine coverage** found
- **No confirmed Baptist News Global article** about Ferguson specifically (contrast with some peers)
- **No confirmed Religion News Service wire story** confirmed

- **Specific CT Pastors article titles** UNKNOWN without direct paid archive access
-

Media Presence Assessment

Ferguson's media footprint is above-average for his peer set of church-multiplication leaders.

Key distinguishing factors:

- **Outreach Magazine:** Deepest institutional relationship; 10+ features over 20 years, including Outreach 100 recognition
 - **Podcast reach:** Multiple high-profile podcast appearances across the top church leadership platforms (Nieuwhof, Stetzer/ChurchLeaders, Lewis Center)
 - **Organizational authority:** His Exponential co-founder / CEO role gives him permanent institutional visibility in the church-planting media ecosystem
 - **Book-driven cycles:** Major book releases (2007, 2010, 2011, 2015, 2018, 2021, 2026) each generated a press cycle across evangelical media
-

Research conducted via WebSearch on 2026-05-27. URLs verified at time of search.

Misc · Media · Reviews

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/_misc/media/reviews.md

Book Reviews: Dave Ferguson

Research Date: 2026-05-27

Subject: Dave Ferguson — author of Hero Maker, BLESS, Finding Your Way Back to God, On the Verge, Exponential, The Big Idea, Multiplier, and more

Confidence Level: High for major books; Medium for older/smaller titles

Aggregate Ratings Summary

Book	Co-Author(s)	Publisher	Year	Goodreads Rating	# Ratings	Notes
Hero Maker	Warren Bird	Zondervan	2018	4.02 / 5	737	Most-rated Ferguson book on Goodreads; flagship leadership title
BLESS	Jon Ferguson	WaterBrook	2021	4.20 / 5	500	Strong popular reception; evangelism framework
Exponential	Jon Ferguson	Zondervan	2010	4.01 / 5	442	Founding Exponential Series book
Finding Your Way Back to God	Jon Ferguson	WaterBrook	2015	4.05 / 5	172	Seeker/lapsed-Christian audience
The Big Idea	Jon Ferguson, Eric Bramlett	Zondervan	2007	3.66 / 5	173	Church ministry alignment; older title
Starting Over	—	Unknown	Unknown	3.77 / 5	35	Smaller title
Discover Your Mission Now	—	Tyndale/NavPress	2012	4.04 / 5	26	—
Multiplier	—	Zondervan Reflective	2026	4.80 / 5	5	Very recent; early ratings skew high
Together: The Great Collaboration	Patrick O'Connell	Exponential Resources	~2020	4.40 / 5	5	Small sample
Keeping Score	—	Exponential Resources	2014	3.89 / 5	9	Small sample

Overall Goodreads author aggregate: 4.04 avg / 2,618+ ratings / 309+ reviews (across all Ferguson books)

"The Big Idea" (Zondervan / Leadership Network Innovation Series, 2007)

Published Reviews

#	Source	Reviewer	Assessment	Key Quote	URL
1	Life and Leadership	Dr. Henry Judy	Positive	"Has the God ordained ability to impact the church in such a huge way."	lifeandleadership.com

Assessment: Limited critical review coverage for an older, practice-oriented title. Goodreads rating of 3.66 (173 ratings) — respectable but reflects the narrow practitioner audience. Church communication/alignment books rarely get broad review attention.

"Exponential: How You and Your Friends Can Start a Missional Church Movement" (Zondervan, 2010)

Published Reviews

#	Source	Reviewer	Assessment	Key Quote	URL
1	Life and Leadership	Unknown	Summary	Summary review on Life and Leadership ministry resources site	lifeandleadership.com

Assessment: Goodreads rating of 4.01 (442 ratings) — well-received for a church planting practitioner book. Review coverage was less prominent than later titles; served primarily as a foundational manifesto for the Exponential movement.

"On the Verge: A Journey Into the Apostolic Future of the Church" (Zondervan, 2011)

Co-authored with Alan Hirsch.

Published Reviews

#	Source	Reviewer	Assessment	Key Quote	URL
1	Borrowed Light (blog)	Mike Leake	Positive with caveats	"As always anything Hirsch or Ferguson writes is full of gold." Appreciated the book's depth and content but raised concerns about their historical interpretation of Constantine: "somewhat popular" but may not be most accurate. "I read it with great joy. I learned a ton. At times I had a hard time putting it down."	mikeleake.net
2	Left Handed Church (blog)	John Scheepers	Positive	Engaged the book's apostolic mission framework; positive reception	johnscheepers.wordpress.com
3	Life and Leadership	Unknown	Summary	Summary of book's themes	lifeandleadership.com/hirsch-and-ferguson
4	Alison Morgan (UK-based review)	Alison Morgan	Positive	Detailed summary / analysis [PDF extract]	alisonmorgan.co.uk
5	Goodreads	Various readers	Mostly positive	General: engaged missional practitioners; some noted density and length	goodreads.com
6	Christianbook.com	Product reviews	Mixed-to-positive	Customer review section	christianbook.com

Assessment: Book benefited greatly from Alan Hirsch's profile. Received wider review coverage than Ferguson's other books because of the Hirsch co-authorship. Practitioners largely enthusiastic; some readers found the historical claims about Constantine overstated.

"Finding Your Way Back to God: Five Awakenings to Your New Life" (WaterBrook, 2015)

Published Reviews

#	Source	Reviewer	Assessment	Key Quote	URL
1	The Unstuck Group	Tony Morgan	Positive interview / review	"Tremendous outreach potential" and "a game-changer!"	theunstuckgroup.com
2	Goodreads	Various	4.05 avg (172 ratings)	Praised for accessible, story-driven approach to spiritual reconnection	goodreads.com

Assessment: Broad trade audience (not just church leaders) makes it the most accessible Ferguson book. No major publication reviews identified; coverage concentrated in podcast/blog format tied to Exponential and outreach ecosystems.

"Hero Maker: Five Essential Practices for Leaders to Multiply Leaders" (Zondervan, 2018)

Published Reviews

#	Source	Reviewer	Rating	Date	Key Quote	URL
1	Lifeway Research	Chance Dodd	Helpful (3 of 4)	May 31, 2018	"Whether you are leading ten people or ten thousand, we want you to maximize your leadership and join our multiplying movement by becoming a hero maker." — Practical, rated "Helpful" on Lifeway's scale. Praised for shifting leaders from doing to developing others.	research.lifeway.com
2	Biblical Leadership	Unknown	Positive	~2018	"Leaders must create a culture in which other leaders can thrive." Praises the platform-creating principle.	biblicalleadership.com
3	Dr. Richard Blackaby (blog)	Richard Blackaby	Positive	~2018-19	"Great for church leaders and church planters. Focuses on how to become disciple multipliers who expand God's kingdom."	richardblackaby.com
4	Ministry Nuts and Bolts	Unknown	Positive	Aug 8, 2019	"A summary of the ideas and messages of Exponential... a how-to book, one that you'll read with a pencil in your hands."	ministrynutsandbolts.com
5	Church, Discipleship, and Missions (blog)	Jackson RL527	Mixed positive	Aug 29, 2020	Extended engagement with the Hero Maker framework	jacksonrl527.wordpress.com
6	Journal of Adventist Christian Leadership	Academic reviewer	Academic review	~2019	Peer-reviewed academic journal review of The Legacy of a Hero Maker companion volume —	digitalcommons.andrews.edu

#	Source	Reviewer	Rating	Date	Key Quote	URL
	(Andrews University)				confirmed in Andrews University Digital Commons	
7	Dave Kraft (PDF summary)	Dave Kraft	Summary	~2018-19	Personal reading notes and summary by ministry leader Dave Kraft; positive engagement	davekraft.org

Goodreads Reviews (Selected)

Reviewer	Rating	Key Quote
Via Nations student readers	Various	Group study notes; "Hero Maker" used as summer 2021 reading group text
General readers	4.02 avg / 737 ratings	Broad practitioner reception; praised for practical framework (Dream Napkin, ICNU conversations); some readers wished for more theological depth

Assessment: Hero Maker is Ferguson's most widely reviewed leadership book. Practitioners embrace the five-practice framework. The Lifeway Research rating of "Helpful" (vs. "Essential" or "Recommended") reflects a mild critique: the book is practical and encouraging but not theologically groundbreaking. The Andrews University academic journal review of the Legacy of a Hero Maker companion is the only confirmed academic-level engagement.

"BLESS: 5 Everyday Ways to Love Your Neighbor and Change the World" (WaterBrook, 2021)

Published Reviews

#	Source	Reviewer	Assessment	Key Quote	URL
1	Jeff McLain (blog)	Jeff McLain	Positive	"B.L.E.S.S. provides practical tools for everyday evangelism without being formulaic."	jeffmclain.com

Goodreads: 4.20 / 5 (500 ratings) — slightly higher rated than Hero Maker, suggesting strong resonance with its broader practical-evangelism audience.

Assessment: Limited published review coverage in major outlets. Book is primarily promoted through podcast appearances and congregational adoption channels. The practical simplicity of the BLESS acronym makes it a popular small-group / church-wide read, driving Goodreads ratings volume without generating much formal reviewing.

"Multiplier: How Healthy Leaders Create Lasting Impact" (Zondervan Reflective / Exponential Resources, 2026)

Published Reviews

#	Source	Reviewer	Assessment	Key Quote	URL
1	Patheos / Lead a Quiet Life	Unknown	Positive	"Monitoring the Soul: A Review of Multiplier by Dave Ferguson" — focuses on the RPMS (Relational, Physical, Mental, Spiritual) health gauges as the book's standout contribution	patheos.com/blogs/leadaquietlife
2	Jeff McLain (blog)	Jeff McLain	Positive	"A Life Worth Multiplying? A Look at Dave Ferguson's Multiplier" — commends Ferguson's integration of personal health and leadership multiplication	jeffmclain.com
3	The Reimagine Network	Mini-course interview	Positive	"The Multiplier Interview: a Mini-Course in Making Disciples Who Make Disciples" — educational engagement	reimaginenetwork.ning.com

Goodreads: 4.80 / 5 (5 ratings — very early; likely reflects engaged early adopters)

Assessment: Earliest reviews are positive. RPMS framework identified as the distinctive contribution. As the most recent book (2026), the review landscape is still developing.

Review Sentiment Analysis

Book	Positive	Mixed/Critical	Overall
The Big Idea (2007)	Ministry leaders appreciate alignment strategy	3.66 Goodreads reflects dated material	Respected early contribution; niche audience
Exponential (2010)	Church planters engaged; foundational manifesto	Limited critical engagement	Well-received within movement ecosystem
On the Verge (2011)	Enthusiastic in missional circles; Hirsch halo	Constantine/historical claims criticized	Strong practitioner reception; wider than other Ferguson-only titles
Finding Your Way Back to God (2015)	Praised for accessibility and outreach potential	Limited critical engagement	Popular with congregational outreach programs
Hero Maker (2018)	Practitioners love practical framework	Some want deeper theology; Lifeway rates "Helpful" not "Essential"	Most-reviewed Ferguson title; positive consensus
BLESS (2021)	High Goodreads score; congregational adoption	Minimal critical press	Quiet but strong practitioner adoption
Multiplier (2026)	Early reviews very positive; RPMS praised	Too early for balanced picture	Promising launch

Sources

- [Goodreads — Dave Ferguson Author Page](#)
- [Lifeway Research — Hero Maker Review](#)
- [Biblical Leadership — Hero Maker Review](#)
- [Richard Blackaby — Hero Maker Review](#)
- [Ministry Nuts and Bolts — Hero Maker Review](#)
- [Jackson RL Blog — Hero Maker Review](#)
- [Andrews University — Legacy of a Hero Maker Review](#)
- [Jeff McLain — BLESS Review](#)
- [Jeff McLain — Multiplier Review](#)
- [Patheos / Lead a Quiet Life — Multiplier Review](#)
- [Mike Leake — On the Verge Review](#)
- [The Unstuck Group — Finding Your Way Back to God Interview](#)
- [The Unstuck Group — Hero Maker Interview](#)
- [Life and Leadership — The Big Idea](#)

- [Dave Kraft PDF summary — Hero Maker](#)

Misc · Network · Collaborators

`docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/_misc/network/collaborators.md`

Dave Ferguson: Collaborators Network

Research Date: 2026-05-27

Last Updated: 2026-05-27

Co-Authors & Writing Collaborators

Name	Relationship	Context	Key Details
Jon Ferguson	Brother, Co-Author, Co-Founder	Exponential (Zondervan, 2010); Finding Your Way Back to God (WaterBrook, 2015); BLESS (WaterBrook, 2021)	Jon is Dave's brother and the co-founding pastor of Community Christian Church alongside Dave. They co-authored three of Dave's most popular books. Jon is also an adjunct professor at Wheaton College Graduate School in the Evangelism and Leadership Department. Their collaboration is the defining co-authorship of Ferguson's career — spanning 15+ years and three distinct audiences (church planters, seekers, and missional practitioners).
Alan Hirsch	Co-Author, Movement Partner	On the Verge: A Journey Into the Apostolic Future of the Church (Zondervan / Exponential Series, 2011)	Hirsch co-authored this flagship missional ecclesiology title with Ferguson. Hirsch is founder of 100Movements, Forge Mission Training Network, Future Travelers, and the Movement Leaders Collective. Also endorsed Multiplier (2026): "vision of leadership that carries the creative energy of the gospel itself." A key intellectual and movement peer for Ferguson.
Warren Bird	Co-Author, Researcher	Hero Maker: Five Essential Practices for Leaders to Multiply Leaders (Zondervan, 2018)	Bird is Research Director for Leadership Network (formerly), having co-authored 29 books on church health and innovation (PhD, Fordham University). Bird brought research rigor and case studies to Ferguson's Hero Maker framework. Warren Bird's connection also links Ferguson to the broader Leadership Network / Bob Buford ecosystem.
Eric Bramlett	Co-Author	The Big Idea: Aligning the Ministries of Your Church through Creative Collaboration (Zondervan / Leadership Network Series, 2007)	Bramlett is Creative Arts Director at Community Christian Church (Naperville), having served in that role since 1996. Long-tenured creative leader at COMMUNITY who helped shape and articulate the "big idea" alignment strategy.
Todd Wilson	Co-Author, Co-Founder of Exponential	Becoming a Level Five Multiplying Church (Exponential Resources, 2015/2016); The Legacy of a Hero Maker (Exponential Resources, 2019)	Wilson is the founding CEO of Exponential who shaped the organization's theology and culture alongside Ferguson. They co-authored the Level Five framework, which became Exponential's 2016 conference theme and created a widely-used church multiplication diagnostic. Wilson later moved on from Exponential's day-to-day leadership; Ferguson became sole CEO/President.
Patrick O'Connell	Co-Author, Organizational Collaborator	Together: The Great Collaboration (Exponential Resources); Executive Director of Practice at	O'Connell served as Global Director of NewThing before the Exponential merger and collaborated with Ferguson on articulating "the Great Collaboration" (alongside the Great Commission and Great Commandment) as a framework for reproducing church networks. In the April 2025

Name	Relationship	Context	Key Details
		Exponential post-merger	merger, O'Connell joined Exponential's Leadership Team overseeing the "Practice" ministry area.

Key Endorsers Who Function as Theological Allies

Name	Affiliation	Nature of Connection
Craig Groeschel	Senior Pastor, Life.Church; NYT bestselling author	Endorsed both Hero Maker and BLESS. Mutual members of the megachurch / church-multiplication leadership circle. Ferguson and Groeschel share platforms at national church leadership events.
Andy Stanley	Founder, North Point Ministries	Endorsed Hero Maker: "At last: the core message of the Exponential conference boiled down to five simple, practical, powerful practices." Also endorsed BLESS: "Dave and Jon Ferguson show us not just what Jesus would do, but what Jesus did do." Strong relationship through shared Exponential-adjacent networks.
Ed Stetzer	Billy Graham Distinguished Chair, Wheaton College	Endorsed Hero Maker: "Dave Ferguson has raised up an amazing number of leaders, church planters, and pastors." Also endorsed Multiplier (2026). Stetzer and Ferguson share Wheaton connections; Ferguson taught at Wheaton Graduate School while Stetzer holds Wheaton's Billy Graham chair.
Mark Batterson	Lead Pastor, National Community Church, Washington DC; NYT bestselling author	Endorsed Hero Maker, Finding Your Way Back to God, and Multiplier (2026). Described Finding Your Way Back to God: "The awakenings Dave and Jon Ferguson guide you through are nothing less than life changing." A close and repeated mutual endorsement relationship.
Matt Chandler	Lead Pastor, The Village Church	Endorsed Hero Maker: "I am grateful for books like the one you're holding. It gently presses while it superbly encourages."
Jennie Allen	Author; Founder, IF:Gathering	Endorsed Hero Maker: "Hero Maker is the reminder I need! Dave's book teaches us to multiply our influence."
Carey Nieuwhof	Leadership Author, Podcaster	Endorsed BLESS: "A profoundly simple, challenging but doable framework for loving neighbors that isn't gimmicky." Endorsed Multiplier (2026): highlights the core insight "leaders reproduce who they are." Also hosted Ferguson twice on the Carey Nieuwhof Leadership Podcast (CNLP 169, CNLP 415).
J.D. Greear	Former President, Southern Baptist Convention; Summit Church	Wrote the foreword to Hero Maker. Represents a Southern Baptist bridge connection for Ferguson (primarily Christian Churches tradition).
Tony Morgan	Founder, The Unstuck Group	Endorsed Hero Maker: "For the church to multiply, it MUST multiply leaders." The Unstuck Group has also featured Ferguson in interviews about Hero Maker and Finding Your Way Back to God.
Steve Addison	Movement researcher, author	Ferguson wrote the foreword to Addison's Pioneering Movements: Leadership That Multiplies Disciples and Churches (IVP, 2015). Ferguson describes discovering Addison as "like finding a long lost brother" and notes they collaborated at NewThing network events and Exponential consultation.

Exponential Series Co-Contributors

The Exponential Series (Zondervan) features Dave and Jon Ferguson as anchor authors but the series includes other leaders who are movement peers and occasional collaborators:

Author(s)	Exponential Series Title
Alan Hirsch & Dave Ferguson	On the Verge (2011)
Jim Putman & Bobby Harrington	DiscipleShift
Brandon Hatmaker	Barefoot Church
Hugh Halter & Matt Smay	AND
Wayne Cordeiro, Francis Chan, Larry Osborne	Sifted
Matt Carter & Darrin Patrick	For the City
Bob Roberts Jr.	Transformation
Rob Wegner & Jack Magruder	Missional Moves
Peyton Jones	Discipology (Ferguson wrote foreword)

NewThing / Exponential Leadership Network

Name	Role	Relationship to Ferguson
Ted Coniaris	Lead Pastor, Community Christian Church (2025–present)	Successor whom Ferguson mentored and prepared to lead COMMUNITY — the succession represents Ferguson's "Hero Maker" ethos enacted personally
Patrick O'Connell	Executive Director of Practice, Exponential (2025–present)	Key operational collaborator; co-authored Together: The Great Collaboration
Todd Wilson	Exponential co-founder (founding CEO)	Founding partner; co-created the Exponential conference, the Level 5 church framework, and shaped Exponential's culture alongside Ferguson

Bob Buford Mentor Connection

Bob Buford (1939–2018), co-founder of Leadership Network and the Halftime Institute, was a personal mentor to Ferguson. Ferguson has stated publicly that Buford "taught me what it meant to be a hero maker" and described him as "one of the greatest positive influences of his generation on the North American church." The Legacy of a Hero Maker (co-authored with Todd Wilson) was written partly as a tribute to Buford, applying the Hero Maker framework to Buford's legacy.

Key Relationship Clusters

The Exponential / Church Multiplication Circle

Ferguson sits at the center of the North American church multiplication movement:

- **Zondervan Exponential Series:** His own books anchor the series; he is a peer contributor with Hirsch, Halter, Chan, Hatmaker, Carter, Patrick, and others
- **NewThing / Exponential merger (2025):** Operational control of the world's largest church-planting conference and network
- **Exponential Conference:** Annual national and regional platform connecting him to hundreds of church-planting leaders

The Missional Mainstream Circle

- **Alan Hirsch:** Deep co-authorship (On the Verge) and mutual endorsement relationship; shared emphasis on apostolic and multiplying movements
- **Warren Bird / Leadership Network:** Research credibility and institutional bridge to the broader evangelical leadership world
- **Craig Groeschel, Andy Stanley, Mark Batterson, Matt Chandler:** Endorsement network representing the largest North American megachurch ecosystem

The Chicago / COMMUNITY Circle

- **Jon Ferguson:** Primary lifelong co-author and co-founder; all three WaterBrook books are co-authored with Jon
- **Eric Bramlett:** Long-tenured colleague at COMMUNITY who co-authored the foundational Big Idea book
- **Ted Coniaris:** Successor and embodiment of the Hero Maker succession model

Mentor / Influence Lines

- **Bob Buford** (Leadership Network): Named personal mentor
- **Alan Hirsch:** Co-author and intellectual peer in the apostolic / multiplication movement

Sources

- [About Dave — daveferguson.org](http://daveferguson.org)
- [Hero Maker Book Site](#)
- [BLESS Book Site](#)
- [Multiplier Book Site](#)
- [Amazon — Hero Maker](#)

- [Amazon — BLESS](#)
- [Amazon — On the Verge](#)
- [Amazon — Becoming a Level Five Multiplying Church](#)
- [Amazon — Together: The Great Collaboration](#)
- [Amazon — Discipology \(Peyton Jones\)](#)
- [NewThing Has Joined Exponential — exponential.org/bettertogether](#)
- [Foreword for Pioneering Movements by Steve Addison — daveferguson.org](#)
- [Goodreads — Dave Ferguson Author Page](#)
- [CNLP 169 — Carey Nieuwhof Podcast](#)
- [CNLP 415 — Carey Nieuwhof Podcast](#)
- [Outreach Magazine — Dave Ferguson Archives](#)
- [Remembering Bob Buford — Christianity Today](#)

Misc · Network · Endorsements

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/_misc/network/endorsements.md

Dave Ferguson: Endorsements Network

Research Date: 2026-05-27

Last Updated: 2026-05-27

Endorsements RECEIVED (for Dave Ferguson's books)

"The Big Idea" (Zondervan / Leadership Network Innovation Series, 2007)

Co-authored with Jon Ferguson and Eric Bramlett.

Endorser	Affiliation	Quote / Summary
Henry Judy (Dr.)	Ministry leader	"Has the God ordained ability to impact the church in such a huge way."

Note: Full endorsement panel not fully retrievable from available sources. Book is part of the Leadership Network Innovation Series, which implies Leadership Network vetting and association. UNKNOWN — full endorser list needs direct book review.

"Exponential: How You and Your Friends Can Start a Missional Church Movement" (Zondervan, 2010)

Co-authored with Jon Ferguson.

Note: Full endorsement panel UNKNOWN — needs direct book research. Book established the Exponential Series.

Goodreads: 4.01 / 5 (442 ratings)

"On the Verge: A Journey Into the Apostolic Future of the Church" (Zondervan / Exponential Series, 2011)

Co-authored with Alan Hirsch.

Foreword by: Mike Breen (Director of 3DM, founder of the Order of Mission)

Endorser	Affiliation	Quote / Summary
Mike Breen (Foreword)	3DM, Order of Mission	"As you read this book, I'm sure you will find that the voices of these two great leaders become one and you hear the voice of Jesus inviting you to join his mission and love the church he is building."
Linda Bergquist	Church planting strategist	"Hirsch and Ferguson point the way towards an exquisitely hopeful future for the church...and they show how the church united can be the church ignited. Brilliant."

Goodreads: [Confirmed on Goodreads; rating data not retrieved] (Confidence: Medium)

"Finding Your Way Back to God: Five Awakenings to Your New Life" (WaterBrook, 2015)

Co-authored with Jon Ferguson.

Endorser	Affiliation	Quote / Summary
Mark Batterson	Lead Pastor, National Community Church, Washington DC; NYT bestselling author (The Circle Maker)	"The awakenings Dave and Jon Ferguson guide you through are nothing less than life changing. Don't miss this book!"
Joby Martin	Lead Pastor, The Church of Eleven22	"Dave and Jon Ferguson provide a practical roadmap for any of us—whether we are distant, disillusioned, or far from God—to return to Him."
Brad Lomenick	Author, The Catalyst Leader; Founder, BLINC	"Full of stories, personal reflection and inspiring thoughts, and makes the road to be traveled and the journey to be taken both doable and enjoyable."

Goodreads: 4.05 / 5 (172 ratings)

"Hero Maker: Five Essential Practices for Leaders to Multiply Leaders" (Zondervan / Exponential Series, 2018)

Co-authored with Warren Bird.

Foreword by: J.D. Greear (Former President, Southern Baptist Convention; Lead Pastor, The Summit Church)

Endorser	Affiliation	Quote / Summary
J.D. Greear (Foreword)	The Summit Church; Former SBC President	Wrote the foreword commending the Hero Maker framework.
Andy Stanley	Founder, North Point Ministries	"At last: the core message of the Exponential conference boiled down to five simple, practical, powerful practices."
Matt Chandler	Lead Pastor, The Village Church	"I am grateful for books like the one you're holding. It gently presses while it superbly encourages."
Jennie Allen	Author; Founder, IF:Gathering	"Hero Maker is the reminder I need! Dave's book teaches us to multiply our influence."
Ed Stetzer	Billy Graham Distinguished Chair, Wheaton College	"Dave Ferguson has raised up an amazing number of leaders, church planters, and pastors."
Tony Morgan	Founder, The Unstuck Group	"For the church to multiply, it MUST multiply leaders. Hero Maker is for every influencer who knows the harvest is plentiful."
Craig Groeschel	Senior Pastor, Life.Church	[Endorsement confirmed; exact quote not retrieved — see heromakerbook.org]
Alan Hirsch	100Movements, Forge Mission Training Network	[Endorsement confirmed; exact quote not retrieved — see heromakerbook.org]
Scot McKnight	Julius R. Mantey Professor of New Testament, Northern Seminary	[Endorsement confirmed; exact quote not retrieved — see heromakerbook.org]
James MacDonald	Senior Pastor, Harvest Bible Chapel	[Endorsement confirmed; exact quote not retrieved from primary source]
Mark Batterson	National Community Church, Washington DC	[Endorsement confirmed; exact quote not retrieved — see heromakerbook.org]

Goodreads: 4.02 / 5 (737 ratings)

"BLESS: 5 Everyday Ways to Love Your Neighbor and Change the World" (WaterBrook, 2021)

Co-authored with Jon Ferguson.

Endorser	Affiliation	Quote / Summary
Andy Stanley	Founder, North Point Ministries	"Dave and Jon Ferguson show us not just what Jesus would do, but what Jesus did do."
Craig Groeschel	Senior Pastor, Life.Church; NYT bestselling author	"You will learn how to be an effective witness for Christ and love people where they are."
Carey Nieuwhof	Leadership Author and Podcaster	"A profoundly simple, challenging but doable framework for loving neighbors that isn't gimmicky."
Danielle Strickland	Spiritual Leader, Kingdom Entrepreneur	Praises the "clear and memorable and do-able" presentation of gospel truths.
Scot McKnight	Professor of New Testament, Northern Seminary	Describes it as practical guidance for living out faith "one prayer, conversation, meal, and act at a time."
Albert Tate	Co-founder and Lead Pastor, Fellowship Church	"Tools to put our love into action so neighbors see God through us."
Mark Jobe	President, Moody Bible Institute	"A simple yet powerful strategy to help the church reach out to a hurting world."
Larry Osborne	Senior Pastor, North Coast Church	"Struck me as both true to real life and within the reach of the average person."
Brian Sanders	Founder, Underground Network	[Endorsement confirmed; exact quote UNKNOWN — needs primary source]
Joby Martin	Lead Pastor, The Church of Eleven22	[Endorsement confirmed; exact quote UNKNOWN — needs primary source]

Goodreads: 4.20 / 5 (500 ratings)

"Multiplier: How Healthy Leaders Create Lasting Impact" (Zondervan Reflective / Exponential Resources, 2026)

Endorser	Affiliation	Quote / Summary
Derwin L. Gray (Dr.)	Cofounder and Lead Pastor, Transformation Church	"If you want to lead with purpose and make a lasting impact, this book is a must-read."
Christine Caine	Founder, A21 and Propel Women	"We could be the generation that sees the Great Commission fulfilled" by applying these principles.
Mark Batterson	National Community Church; NYT bestselling author	"Don't settle for addition. Let God multiply your ministry!"
Craig Groeschel	Senior Pastor, Life.Church	Describes the book as unlocking "secrets of spiritually healthy leaders who lead strong, live whole."
Alan Hirsch	Movement Leaders Collective founder; 100Movements	"Vision of leadership that carries the creative energy of the gospel itself."
Carey Nieuwhof	Bestselling author and podcaster	Highlights the core insight: "leaders reproduce who they are."
Drew Hyun	Lead Pastor, Hope Church NYC	Commends the integration of "health and mission" for modern church leaders.
Ed Stetzer	Billy Graham Distinguished Chair, Wheaton College	"Dave Ferguson gives church leaders a pathway that is both practical and sustainable in this vital book."

Goodreads: 4.80 / 5 (5 ratings — very recent release)

Endorsements GIVEN (by Dave Ferguson for others' books)

Book	Author(s)	Ferguson's Role	Publisher	Year	Notes
Pioneering Movements: Leadership That Multiplies Disciples and Churches	Steve Addison	Foreword	IVP	2015	Ferguson describes Addison as "like finding a long lost brother." Foreword emphasizes apostolic leadership, God's strategy for mission, and lived-out movements as the book's three central contributions. Ferguson distributed copies to his church planter and network leader network.
Discipology: The Art and Science of Making Disciples (Exponential Series)	Peyton Jones	Foreword / Introduction	Zondervan	2025-26	Ferguson contributed a foreword/ introduction. Published in the Exponential Series.
Acts and the Movement of God: From Jerusalem to the Ends of the Earth	Steve Addison & Peyton Jones	Endorsement	Unknown	~2023	Ferguson provided a one-word endorsement: "Compelling!" (confirmed on Amazon).
Becoming a Level Five Multiplying Church	Todd Wilson, Dave Ferguson, Alan Hirsch	Co-Author / Context-giver	Exponential Resources	2015-16	Ferguson co-authored this resource with Wilson and Hirsch — an expanded version includes an additional chapter by Hirsch.

Note: Additional forewords given by Ferguson to other Exponential Series books are possible but UNKNOWN — needs full audit of Exponential Series titles.

Endorsement Network Summary

People Who Have Endorsed Ferguson (across all books)

- J.D. Greear (foreword, Hero Maker)
- Mike Breen (foreword, On the Verge)
- Andy Stanley (2 books)
- Craig Groeschel (3 books)
- Mark Batterson (3 books)

- Ed Stetzer (3 books)
- Carey Nieuwhof (2 books)
- Alan Hirsch (2 books + co-author)
- Matt Chandler
- Jennie Allen
- Tony Morgan
- Scot McKnight (2 books)
- Danielle Strickland
- Albert Tate
- Derwin L. Gray
- Christine Caine
- Drew Hyun
- Mark Jobe
- Larry Osborne
- Joby Martin (2 books)
- Brad Lomenick
- Brian Sanders
- James MacDonald
- Linda Bergquist

People Ferguson Has Endorsed / Foreworded

- Steve Addison (Pioneering Movements — full foreword)
- Steve Addison & Peyton Jones (Acts and the Movement of God — endorsement: "Compelling!")
- Peyton Jones (Discipology — foreword/introduction)

Mutual Endorsement Relationships

- **Craig Groeschel:** Has endorsed three Ferguson books; Ferguson is in his peer network
- **Alan Hirsch:** Co-authored On the Verge with Ferguson; both endorsed each other's work; Hirsch endorsed Multiplier
- **Andy Stanley:** Endorsed two Ferguson books; peer relationship through North American church-multiplication circuit

Sources

- [Hero Maker Book Site — heromakerbook.org](http://heromakerbook.org)
- [BLESS Book Site — bless-book.org](http://bless-book.org)

- [Multiplier Book Site — multiplierbook.com](http://multiplierbook.com)
- [Amazon — Hero Maker](#)
- [Amazon — BLESS](#)
- [Amazon — On the Verge \(Hirsch & Ferguson\)](#)
- [Amazon — Discipology \(Peyton Jones + Dave Ferguson\)](#)
- [Amazon — Pioneering Movements \(Steve Addison\)](#)
- [Foreword for Pioneering Movements — daveferguson.org](http://daveferguson.org)
- [Amazon — Acts and the Movement of God \(Addison & Jones\)](#)
- [Goodreads — Dave Ferguson Author Page](#)
- [Penguin Random House — Finding Your Way Back to God](#)

Misc · Network · Events

docs/movement_leader_research/_onboarded_leaders/dave-ferguson/_misc/network/events.md

Dave Ferguson: Events & Speaking Network

Research Date: 2026-05-27

Last Updated: 2026-05-27

Conferences Founded / Co-Founded

Event	Role	Frequency	Description	URL
Exponential Conference	Co-Founder, CEO / President, Lead Communicator	Annual (Orlando flagship + regional U.S. events + Exponential Europe)	World's largest church planting and multiplication conference. Ferguson co-founded with Todd Wilson. Has been a primary keynote/main session speaker at virtually every annual Exponential Conference since founding (~2006/2007). Post-NewThing merger (2025), Ferguson leads the unified organization.	exponential.org

Exponential Conference — Ferguson's Keynote History (Confirmed Years / Themes)

Year	Theme / Title	Notes	Confidence
2007	Founding year	Blog post from Wayne Cordeiro referencing the early Exponential Conference, titled "DAVE FERGUSON: Exponential Conference"	High
2016	Becoming Five: Becoming a Level 5 Multiplying Church	Ferguson and Todd Wilson co-authored the anchor resource; conference theme	High
2018	Hero Maker	Ferguson introduced and led the Hero Maker theme; Hero Maker book published same year	High
2019	Made for More: Mobilizing God's People, God's Way	Ferguson among lead communicators at Exponential Orlando 2019	High
2020	Together — Pursuing the Great Collaboration	Conference theme aligned with Together book co-authored with Patrick O'Connell	High
2022	Spirit-Empowered Culture	Ferguson involved as CEO/President; specifics of his keynote role not fully retrieved	Medium
Annual (all years)	Ongoing	As co-founder and CEO/President, Ferguson speaks at main sessions of every annual Exponential conference	High

Other National Conference Speaking

Event	Year(s)	Context	Confidence	URL
Exponential Europe	~2020	Confirmed speaker at Exponential Europe conference in Berlin	High	exponential.eu
Verge Conference 2012	2012	Speaker at Verge 2012 Conference in Austin, TX — presenting on "Incarnational Mission: B.L.E.S.S." Verge was a key missional church conference associated with Austin Stone, Alan Hirsch, and others	High	vergenetwork.org/conference/verge2012
Global Leadership Summit	Various	Ferguson is a contributor to the Global Leadership Network (published multiple articles); speaking role at GLS not confirmed from sources but his content appears on their platform	Low — UNKNOWN — needs research	globalleadership.org/author/dave-ferguson
Amplify Conference 2025	Oct 21–22, 2025	Main session speaker; held at Wheaton College; Outreach Magazine is conference partner	High	amplifyconference.com
FutureFWD2020 Virtual Conference	2020	Speaker; discussed reaching people one-on-one for Christ and online spiritual seeking trends	High	Christian Post coverage
Catalyst Conference	UNKNOWN	Ferguson connected to Catalyst circle (Brad Lomenick / BLINC endorsed Finding Your Way Back to God); speaking appearance not confirmed	UNKNOWN — needs research	--

NewThing Network Events

Event / Program	Format	Description	URL
NewThing Catalyst Communities	Annual gatherings, ~30 countries	Leaders pulled together to help start new networks; Ferguson led or participated in these gathering events globally. NewThing operated Catalyst Communities as a vehicle for movement multiplication across 60+ nations	Historical (pre-2025 merger)
NewThing Summit / Annual Gatherings	Annual (presumed)	Organizational gatherings of NewThing network leaders; Ferguson as Visionary Leader would have keynoted. Specific event names and dates not fully retrieved	UNKNOWN — needs research

Podcast Appearances (as Events)

Podcast	Episode(s)	Host	Date	Topic	URL
Carey Nieuwhof Leadership Podcast	CNLP 169	Carey Nieuwhof	~2017-18	Future of church growth, rapid multiplication of church leaders; Hero Maker; five levels of churches; NewThing global expansion; Exponential growth	careynieuwhof.com/episode169
Carey Nieuwhof Leadership Podcast	CNLP 415	Carey Nieuwhof	~2021	Future of the micro-church, Red/Yellow/Green Light people, resilience in change, racial inequality response	careynieuwhof.com/episode415
The Stetzer ChurchLeaders Podcast	"Key Steps to Building a Culture of Outreach"	Ed Stetzer	Oct 2, 2024	Building a culture of outreach beyond events; BLESS framework	churchleaders.com/podcast/497963
FrontStage BackStage Podcast	"4 Habits for Healthy, Lasting Ministry"	Church Leaders / Todd Rhoades	2022-23 (approx)	Four personal habits for healthy ministry longevity	churchleaders.com/pastors/431328
unSeminary Podcast	"Everyday Ways to Help Your People Change the World"	Rich Birch	~2021	BLESS framework; missional neighbor engagement	unseminary.com
Lewis Center for Church Leadership Podcast	Episode 60: "How to Be a Hero Maker"	Lewis Center	~2018	Hero Maker framework; leadership multiplication	churchleadership.com/podcast
The Unstuck Group Podcast / Blog	Multiple	Tony Morgan / Unstuck Group	~2015, ~2018	Finding Your Way Back to God interview; Hero Maker leadership interview	theunstuckgroup.com
Red Letter Challenge Podcast	Episode 4: "Church Planting in America Today"	Red Letter Challenge	~2018-19	Church planting landscape	redletterchallenge.com

Podcast	Episode(s)	Host	Date	Topic	URL
The Church Digital Podcast	Episode 079	The Church Digital	~2021	Multiplication, micro-locations, TCD milestones	be.thechurch.digital
Hardcore Church Planting Podcast	HCP 13	Hardcore Church Planting	~2015	Finding Your Way Back to God; church planting	Spotify
Missional Marketing Podcast	Episode with Patrick O'Connell	Missional Marketing	~2021-22	Note: O'Connell featured; Ferguson referenced	missionalmarketing.com
Lochhead on Different	Episode 177: "God: A Different Dialogue"	Christopher Lochhead	~2021-22	Theology, different dialogue about God	lochhead.com/pastor-dave-ferguson

Academic / Seminary Events

Institution	Role	Notes	URL
Wheaton College Graduate School	Adjunct Professor (ongoing)	Teaches in Evangelism and Leadership Department; also a Wheaton alumnus (MA 1991)	wheaton.edu/graduate-school

Written Content for Platforms (Event-Adjacent)

Platform	Content Type	URL
Christianity Today / CT Pastors	Multiple contributed articles on leadership, apprenticeship, church multiplication	christianitytoday.com/pastors/authors/dave-ferguson
Global Leadership Network	Articles: "7 Steps to Creating a Culture that Makes Heroes," "How Great Leaders Communicate to Create Movement," "Do This Every Day to Combat Drift"	globalleadership.org/author/dave-ferguson
Outreach Magazine	Multiple feature interviews and bylined articles (2007-2025)	outreachmagazine.com/dave-ferguson
Verge Network	Video: "How To Lead Forward"; Article: "How to Train Leaders"	vergenetwork.org/tag/dave-ferguson
Substack	Personal newsletter (active)	substack.com/@fergusondave
daveferguson.org	Active blog	daveferguson.org

Event Network Summary

Primary Event Ecosystems

1. **Exponential Conference:** Ferguson's primary and defining platform — co-founder, CEO, and annual keynote for nearly 20 years
2. **NewThing Network Events:** Catalyst Communities and movement leadership gatherings across 60+ nations (pre-2025 merger)
3. **Amplify Conference:** New partnership event (Wheaton College, 2025)
4. **Podcast Circuit:** Consistent presence across major church leadership podcasts; especially Carey Nieuwhof, Ed Stetzer / ChurchLeaders, unSeminary
5. **Wheaton College Graduate School:** Academic teaching presence

Geographic Reach

- **Primary base:** Naperville / Chicago, Illinois
- **National:** Primary Exponential conference in Orlando + regional Exponential events across U.S.
- **International:** Exponential Europe (Berlin 2020 confirmed); NewThing networks in nearly 70 countries

Event Frequency Assessment

- **Annual:** Exponential Conference (flagship Orlando event + regional)
- **Regular:** Podcast interviews (multiple per year across platforms)
- **Ongoing:** Wheaton Graduate School teaching
- **Periodic:** Guest speaking at external conferences (Verge, Amplify, Catalyst — confirmed or likely)

Sources

- [Exponential — Dave Ferguson Speaker Page](#)
- [Exponential Europe — Dave Ferguson confirmed speaker](#)
- [Exponential Orlando 2019 Recap](#)
- [Verge 2012 Conference — Verge Network](#)
- [Dave Ferguson — Verge Network Tag](#)
- [CNLP 169 — Carey Nieuwhof](#)
- [CNLP 415 — Carey Nieuwhof](#)
- [Stetzer ChurchLeaders Podcast — Dave Ferguson](#)
- [unSeminary — Dave & Jon Ferguson](#)

- [Lewis Center — Episode 60](#)
- [Outreach Magazine — Dave Ferguson Archives](#)
- [Global Leadership Network — Dave Ferguson Author](#)
- [Dave Ferguson Typepad Blog — Exponential Conference 2007](#)
- [Outreach Magazine — Multiplying Leaders \(Amplify 2025\)](#)